

**shy
plays,
high
stakes**

arnica butler

SHY PLAYS, HIGH STAKES

A HOTWIFE NOVEL

By Arnica Butler

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CHAPTER 1

Shiloh opened the door and did her best, disinterested "Hey." Though her stomach did a funny cartwheel, like it often did when she interacted with Joey.

She didn't know what the pre-Joey flip-flop in her abdomen meant, and she preferred not to think about it too much.

He was on his phone - of course. Always on his phone, plotting his next adventure, always with his mind somewhere else. Her eyes were drawn to his hand because his fingers were sweeping the screen quickly, probably swiping away at Tinder - or something more nefarious.

Shiloh thought moves like this were put-on: just Joey, trying to demonstrate that he was *so alpha*, with so many women falling all over him, and that he was *so busy* with his own business that he could barely be bothered to pay attention to her. Even when he had rung the damn doorbell himself.

Not the kind of reception Shiloh usually got from men, and so she supposed that was why she was so annoyed by it.

His hands were large and shapely, whispering at strength that he obviously possessed. Nicks and scrapes, in various stages of partial healing, were scattered over his knuckles. Like the callouses she knew he had, because he took her hand in his whenever they met up, the tattered appearance of his knuckles made something throb inside of her. Joey, with his mildly calloused hands and scraped knuckles, was a very *manly* man.

And his hands were very, very large.

He was also, Shiloh reminded herself, before her thoughts got carried away, a huge jerk. And that bore repeating to herself, so she did. She also diverted her eyes to his face, to take her thoughts off his... hands.

He was dressed in one of his usual get-ups. Jeans, extremely fashionable and expensive, but with a few paint splatters and tears in them. A charcoal t-shirt with no markings, pristine, probably just out of the box. T-shirts fit him well: his biceps bulged against the sleeves, and his military career had left him with a daily push-up habit that gave him a muscled, t-shirt perfect core. (The military hair had not remained with him: he had a rakish black mop of straight hair that lent him a faintly rocker vibe).

"Hey, baby," he said, tucking the phone into his back pocket suddenly, without appearing to have finished whatever he was doing. He grinned at her, his hazel eyes flashing devilishly. As always.

"*Baby?*" Shiloh said, wrinkling her nose. She stepped back and held her hand out toward the interior, inviting him in.

Joey just grinned. As he stepped up to the floor level of the house, he towered over her, and she caught a whiff of his... what was it? Deodorant? Cologne? Body wash? He didn't seem like the type for any of those things, to be honest, but he always smelled good.

She watched him stroll in and hesitated by the door. "Don't you have a toolbox?" she asked.

Joey was looking around at the house, as if he had never been there before. This question made him turn around and grin. "Loaded question, Shy-shy."

"Ugh," she said, exasperated. "For *fixing things*."

She was already hours in the future, calling Mike, explaining to him why this "arrangement" wasn't going to work. Joey was just so... Joey.

Joey looked like he might make a joke for a second, but shrugged and took a more serious tone.

"I'm a contractor, Shy. I have like thirty toolboxes."

"Do you *need* one of them?" she asked, trying to tamp down her irritation at Joey's condescending tone. It didn't help anything if he smelled irritation; it only made him worse.

"The thing is, Shiloh, it's possible that I don't," Joey said brightly.

Here we go, Shiloh thought. Here comes his sexist comment.

"I find a lot of times, I get in the house with the ladies, they have a problem, and it turns out something just isn't... plugged in. You know? So then I've hauled all my tools inside. For nothing."

Shiloh rolled her eyes.

"So where is this washer?"

She pointed toward the kitchen, to the door leading to the laundry room at the other side of the house. Which Joey, she knew, had definitely *seen*, because he had sat on the dryer one night drinking beer and making a gaggle of women swoon at his "charming" ways. In fact, she was pretty certain that her friend Rebecca's guest - some floozy she had never heard about or seen since, Christy-something - had let him fuck her over the dryer in the wee hours of the morning when everyone else had gone to bed.

Scratch that. She *knew* that he had done this, because she heard the whole thing, and if they hadn't been fucking, then they had at least been doing something that any person would at least remember *enough* to know where the laundry room was.

But Joey was such an alpha, she reminded herself, he probably didn't bother remembering things like that.

Joey strolled into the kitchen, surveying it as he passed through. Shiloh followed him. He lifted a wine glass, a dried puddle of red in the bottom, and looked back at her. "Solo drinking, Shiloh?" He tsked, setting it down, and continued on his way. "It's a shame, really," he said, entering the laundry room. "Pretty lady like you, drinking alone in the kitchen, no one to keep her company..."

"I was talking to Mike," she said. She stood in the laundry room doorway and leaned on the frame, watching as Joey examined the washer by tugging on the door and then leaned, athletically, to look behind it. "Oh, God, Joey, look - it's plugged in. I'm not an idiot."

Joey looked at her as he twisted sideways and easily shoved the washer to the side at an angle. "Dunno about that, darlin,'" he quipped, grinning. "You *did* marry Mike." He crouched down and squinted at something at the back of the washer. "Guy's a douchebag."

Joey was Mike's good friend, so Shiloh didn't respond to this, or even bother to roll her eyes. Joey fiddled with a few things and then popped up to standing. "Well," he said, looking at her, rubbing his hands together, eyebrows arched. "It seems I *am* gonna need that toolbox, after all."

She sighed. "Do you think you can fix it?" she asked, her tone much more desperate than she wanted it to be. She had clothes that she really needed in the washer, and they were trapped, along with gallons of soapy water. "Should I just call a... you know, official washer guy?"

Joey snorted, then put both hands on Shiloh's shoulders. "Shiloh," he said, his tone so serious that she knew he was fucking with her. "Mikey has entrusted me with the care of his most precious possession. 'Take good care of Shiloh for me, buddy,' is what he said. You remember? He doesn't want some dirty plumber with his ass crack hanging out, belching all over his nice, pristine, canary-yellow laundry room and pawing at his wife's... dirty laundry."

She stared at him, knocked off-balance as always. As usual, Joey's speech was rife with sexual innuendo, none of it particularly clever. She

also knew he was going in for the kill next: some ham-handed one-liner that she wouldn't have a comeback for.

"And face it, Shy... would you rather have a nice," he let go of her shoulders and rubbed his chest to his abdomen with his hands, "respectable and good-looking man like me in here, fixing things for the low, low price of your gratitude and affection? Or some fatso creep who'll charge you six hundred dollars?"

Shiloh blinked, slowly, her mouth open, her temper flaring inexplicably. "The washer's not even worth six hundred -" she began, in a huff, but Joey was already grinning, spinning toward the door, having winked at her.

"Back in a sec," he called out, as he strolled through the kitchen. When he passed the wine glass he reached out and flicked it with one of his muscular, veined fingers, and it rang with a delicate ting.

Shiloh blew at her loose bangs. Annoyed.

God, Joey was so *annoying*.

She looked over at the full-length mirror on the opposite side of the laundry room as she tucked her loose hair behind her ear. She patted the ponytail she had made hastily, right when she heard Joey's familiar knock on the door. Her wavy, dark hair rarely cooperated with that kind of quick and dirty look, and a large chunk of hair was sort of protruding ridiculously from the whole 'do.

She scowled at herself reproachfully. The ponytail was bad, but what was worse is that she was *fixing it*.

She dropped her hand. She *wasn't* going to fix it, just like she had decided she *wasn't* going to wear her hair down for Joey. Specifically because Joey always commented on her hair and how beautiful it was. But, also, because she had put way more thought into what she was wearing than she cared to admit to herself, and it had seemed inappropriate - somehow - to have her hair down on top of all that.

She scowled again, screwing up her fine features. She knew people tended to say she had an "uptight" appearance: her features were small and perfectly symmetrical, and she looked the part of a hyper-organized career woman, which she didn't like thinking of herself as.

But was, probably, a fair conclusion.

She wore jean shorts and a loose white shirt. The shorts complimented her best feature, her long, slender legs. And she knew that.

That's why she had chosen them. The shirt - loose, button-down - had been meant to balance the very short shorts with something conservative, but she had left the top buttons undone, doing her second-best feature - her pert breasts - a tremendous favor.

Whatever, she thought. Joey hadn't even looked at her. No harm, no foul.

She suddenly felt ridiculous, and a little bit guilty. What the hell was she doing anyway? Joey was such a... jerk. And even if he wasn't a jerk (which he was), he was her husband's friend and Mike had entrusted Joey with "taking care of her" while he was away for three months on business. So obviously, even thinking about what she was wearing when Joey came by was... bad.

She needed to find something to do, in some other part of the house. She strode through the kitchen, hoping to escape toward the stairs before Joey was back inside.

But he was already coming through the kitchen, tools in hand.

"I'm just... uh... gonna go upstairs," she told him, her finger pointing at the ceiling. "Holler if you need anything."

"*You* holler if *you* need anything," Joey quipped, grinning. But he kept moving.

Shiloh rolled her eyes on the way out, to the audience of the wine glass alone.

*

Things had always been like this, she reminded herself, sitting down on the edge of the bed with her laptop. There was nothing new in Joey's jokes, his sexual connotations, his open flirtation with her - it was all just an act. And obviously, Mike thought so, too, or he wouldn't have asked his good buddy to be the go-to man for "anything that comes up," while he was away.

She opened the laptop and stared at her desktop, but then tossed it aside. A loud bang came from downstairs.

She sighed and picked up her phone.

Hey. Joey's here. Does he really know what he's doing with this thing?

She sent the message to Mike, and then regretted it immediately. Mike was at work right now, probably in a meeting, and his answer was going to be the same as the answer he'd already given her when they spoke last night about the washer: *He'll find a way, he's crafty.*

Another loud bang. She stared at the phone, then tossed it to the side and picked up her laptop again.

God, she was tired of working from home. Tired of looking for a new job, like everyone else seemed to be doing. She didn't really dislike her current job - but you were a fool in these crazy times if you didn't change jobs, get a better salary, move up the ladder. She didn't want to be a chump.

And she was *bored*. So bored. Mike was in Toronto, all her friends were married with kids and busy as hell, and she wasn't the type to go out by herself. Anyway, going out by herself didn't offer her the particular *kind* of fun she was seeking.

She listlessly scrolled through emails, visited some sites she was scoping out to have great answers to interview questions, and processed none of what she was reading. Joey banged away at the washer.

Great, she thought. She had really, really wanted a blouse that was in there for her interview earlier today, but more generally, *someday*. Who knew what Joey was going to do to it? It wasn't like he was some kind of specialist in anything, except being a male slut.

Her phone dinged.

*He'll fix it.
Hey, why don't you go out with Joey tonight?*

A knife of salacious lust and cold guilt cut through her chest before dissipating into annoyance. She couldn't tell if this was serious or not.

With Joey.

She typed, very deliberately placing a dry period at the end of the sentence. Obviously, Mike was joking. First of all, she *detested* Joey, and Mike knew it. She tolerated him because he was Mike's buddy, but everyone knew where they stood here. Second, he couldn't actually be suggesting that she go out with his skeeziest friend?

And finally, it was Friday. Joey probably had like thirty women lined up on a tight schedule.

She stared at the phone.

Her answer seemed a little bitchy. She added to it.

Joey's probably got like sixty -

She stopped typing, as the wave of little balls beneath her first reply began to roll, indicating that Mike was typing back to her. She waited.

You just seem so down. I already talked to him about it, he offered to take you out. Go get some dinner, maybe flirt with the waiter...?

This was a reference to their little "game," one they'd started not very long ago. A fun game, one she enjoyed, in which she flirted with strange men.

It was, vexingly enough, an idea they'd gotten from Joey himself. Joey lived a pretty wild sexual life, and he was into all kinds of crazy shit, but mainly into watching his girlfriends fuck other guys.

Which had intrigued Shiloh when she had first found out about it, five years ago, but was something she hadn't wanted to admit to be intrigued by, so had instead claimed to be disgusted by it. But it had gone from being something she couldn't even wrap her head around, to the "game," mostly because Mike had confided to her that he thought it was actually hot.

She had participated in it the first time to prove her own point: that he wouldn't actually be into it when it really happened. And, in doing so, she had actually proven herself wrong: Mike *did* think it was hot.

And, more surprisingly, so had *she*.

She was never going to *do* anything with some other guy, though. So she flirted. And she liked it way more than she even wanted to admit to herself.

But *that* game, and having "drinks" with Joey, were... two completely, totally, wildly different things. She deleted her half-typed response and started a new one.

Flirting with the waiter is only fun when you're watching.

She smiled. Flirting with the waiter *was* fun with Mike watching. And then a dark, frightening snake of lust wound through her abdomen, as she pictured herself flirting with the waiter while *Joey* watched.

"Jesus," she whispered under her breath. She stared at the little balls at the bottom of the screen as she waited for Mike's reply, trying to push away the thought she'd just had, and any lingering traces of it, from her mind. Because if there was one thing she knew, it was that Joey was out-of-bounds. Totally out-of-bounds, because he was... well, Joey.

Good friends were a no-go, she and Mike had decided over post-sex pillow talk. It was after they had sex that she was most open to flirting with the dark idea of actually *doing* something with another man, and they would sometimes talk about it like it was a real plan.

Even though she thought of those conversations as play-acting - just a way to get riled up again and have more hot sex - she was pretty sure the content was serious.

No good friends.

Which, of course, even in a crazy world where husbands actually watched their wives fuck other guys, was an *obvious* rule.

Anyway, she *detested* Joey.

In that way, at least.

Mike's reply materialized on her screen.

That's hot as fuck.

But I think you should go out. Have some fun. Just get out of the house.

She chewed on her lower lip, thinking of a reply. She typed, "But no flirting with Joey," but hesitated, and then deleted it. That was probably a bad joke, and she didn't want Mike to think there was any element of seriousness to her "going out with" Joey, which she wasn't even going to do.

Mike was already typing.

I have to run. Go out. Have fun.

She rolled her eyes, a filament of resentment boiling up inside of her. Mike was out having fun, Mike was out every damn night. He said it was for business, and she trusted him - it wasn't that she worried about him picking up other women. It was just that she was so tired of being stuck in the same city, living the same day over and over again, while he got to have all the fun, somewhere new and different.

Yeah, well, she typed. It's not like there's any danger of me having a good time with -

"Shy!" Joey called from below, making her heart stop and her blood run ice cold. She closed her messaging app without sending her message and stepped softly toward the door of the master bedroom. "Yeah, what?" she called.

Joey was at the foot of the stairs. He bowed. "Your washer is fucked, m'lady."

Shiloh sighed, trying not to act too disappointed. "Great," she said, uneasily.

He held up a hand. "'Til tomorrow. Need a part."

"You can't open the door by any chance?" she asked, tipping her head to the side and crossing an ankle playfully over the other.

She was rattled by herself. What *was* that?

So lame.

So stupid.

So... inappropriate.

Joey smiled at her. A self-assured, jackass smile, like he knew something. The back of her neck got hot again.

"Sure, I can get the door open, darlin,'" Joey told her. "I'm really good at getting things to open up -"

"Jesus, Joey."

He chuckled and put a pencil in his mouth. "Thing is, you're just going to have a bunch of water all over the floor. I'd wait for the part, then you can drain it, and *voila*."

"The clothes are going to get musty," she told him flatly.

"Ooooooh," he squealed, fluttering his hands around. "God, Shy. You never left your clothes in the washer too long?" He was laughing before he

finished the question, holding up a hand. "Never mind, of course not. Me? I do it all the time. I got a fix for that."

Shiloh folded her arms across her stomach, not just to display her disbelief, but also to quiet the fluttering that was occurring, in the lowest parts of her abdomen. "Wash them again?" she asked, dryly as possible.

Even so, she grinned, in spite of herself.

Joey leaned on the banister, grinning even more. He snatched the pencil from his mouth. Naturally, Joey, a former soldier and a tattoo-riddled badass, was a former and sometimes-smoker, forever leaving the impression that he was, in fact, smoking a cigarette, no matter what he was actually doing. He pointed it at her. "Tell you what? Get dolled up, I'll take you out, and if you buy me enough drinks, I'll tell you my secret sauce."

She stared back at him, unable to think of anything to say.

"Come *on*," he said. "It's all cleared with Mikey."

She held up her phone, which she was still clutching in her hand. "I know," she said.

"So what's the problem, woman?" he said, extending his sculpted biceps, grinning. "Get your dancing shoes on -"

"I'm *not* going dancing," Shiloh said, much too quickly. She wasn't even sure why she had objected to that; she loved dancing.

Joey was undeterred and plowed right ahead. " - and I'll be back to pick you up in... how long does it take for a girl like you to get dressed up? An hour?"

"I'm not getting *that* dressed up," she responded, her mind already ransacking her clothes closet, searching for the perfect thing to wear that was, in fact, *that* dressed up, but would not appear to be to Joey.

"Suit yourself," Joey said. "But Joey has to look nice for the ladies. You never know when they'll jump out of the water at you. I'll be back at..." he checked his watch. "Seven."

Shiloh held her hands open and shrugged in helpless surrender. "Fine, whatever."

Joey whistled and picked up his toolbox, starting to stroll toward the door. He stopped, leaning back to look up at her. "Oh, and Shy?"

She raised her eyebrows.

"Don't take that wedding ring off."

Her heart skipped a beat, and her blood boiled with the now-familiar mixture of rage and dirty, wrong attraction. Like she *would*.

"Nothing trawls the ladies like a little competition," he said, winking. Joey grinned as he walked off.

The door clicked open, and she waited for it to close, then another beat.

"Jesus," she breathed, rolling her eyes.

Joey had two vehicles, both of them pricey, which always made Shiloh wonder what his financial situation was, because that was the kind of thing Shiloh wondered about and wished she didn't. She was relieved to see his Dodge Charger, a conspicuously red, conspicuously masculine car, parked in the driveway, and not his huge-ass black truck - the make and model of which she refused to know or care about.

He opened the door for her but did it with such a smirk on his face that she waved at him dismissively. "Thanks, but there's no need," she told him.

He held onto the door and closed it gently behind her anyway, unflappable as always.

"Okay, so look," she said, when he got in the car. "I don't want to go any crazy place, Joey."

Joey put his arm over her seat to look behind him as he backed up. "Gotcha. No opium dens, no churches."

She laughed in spite of herself. "No, just, no -"

"I know an opium den *in* a church," he offered, smiling.

"Ugh. Just no... swingers clubs or whatever it is. No clubs, actually."

Joey halted after backing into their very narrow alley with remarkable precision, at an unruly rate of speed, and shifted the car. Then he reached over and put a hand on her knee.

For a dangerous moment, he looked at her with a sexual seriousness that actually made her pussy quiver, dampening her panties, she was sure of it. She had her slap all ready for him - in her mind - but she was paralyzed.

"Shiloh," he said, and she looked down at his hand, which he wasn't moving, but which was warm and dry, a little rough in patches, incredibly sexy even the way he had placed it, almost paternalistically. "I don't know if you know this, but they don't serve food at *clubs*. Also, it's seven o'clock."

He grinned and started to drive. "Anyway, the deal is: I am taking my good buddy Mike's uptight wife out for dinner, because she is cranky about being left behind in the boring-ass suburban wastelands while Mikey has a

grand time in Canucksville speaking corporate babble to corporate bobbleheads, which is, correct me if I'm wrong, what she would love to be doing more than anything in the world right now."

"Oh, God, shut up," Shiloh said. But they were entering the playful banter zone, and she was smiling.

"Talking about scaled inter-operable services and brand-targeted e-business -"

"Joey, seriously."

He looked over at her. "It gets you hot," he joked.

She waved a hand at him and rolled her eyes.

"It's cool, Shy-Shy -"

"*Don't* call me Shy-Shy, Joey."

" - all the ladies have a little something that makes them tick."

"You're *so* stupid."

Joey smiled and drove, silent for a moment.

"*Transition cooperative theme services*," he purred, grinning.

Shiloh looked out the window to hide her smile. She was burning up, both having fun and irritated by the fact that this is what he thought of her and by the fact that she was weirdly enjoying his attention.

However wrong any of that was.

CHAPTER 2

"So?" Joey said, leaning back and putting his arms over the back of the booth. "Does this meet with your approval?"

Shiloh squeezed lime into her drink, a rum and diet coke that she had zero intention of finishing, and shrugged. "It's... good," she said. She lifted the drink to her lips and looked around.

It was actually better than "good," but she didn't need Joey getting a huge head about it. The bistro he had taken her to was a trendy one, in the downtown core, brimming with attractive, vibrant, thirty-somethings - not the children she had expected - and the mood was pleasant. They were on a small patio on the roof, and the weather was unusually warm, hinting at the possibility of summer. A real summer, after two years of madness.

She set her drink down and arranged it carefully on the napkin.

Joey watched her and made a sound as he grinned and looked out into the crowd, which was thickening into a soup of young people, getting louder with each passing second.

"What's that for?" she asked.

Joey looked at her sideways and smiled. "What's what for?"

She imitated his derisive snort, then rolled her own eyes and looked out at the crowd.

"Oh, Shy, don't be like that. If you're like *that*, then *I'll* start thinking *you* care what I think."

"I don't," she said, much too quickly. "It was a rhetorical question."

Joey turned back to face her. "Sorry, darlin.' Me no understand big words."

Shiloh rolled her eyes yet again, and then reminded herself to stop doing that. "How is it you don't have anything better to do on a Friday night than hang out with... what was it you called me? 'The most tightly wrapped suburban soccer mom-in-training' you have ever met?"

Joey inhaled sharply and made a face. "Ouch. That was terribly rude of me."

She smirked.

"...to say to your face." Joey grinned and lifted his glass, already tossing his "apology" aside. "I'm a good guy, what can I say?"

Shiloh lifted her drink and snorted quietly before sipping it. "No, seriously. You must be having a real dry spell."

Joey looked at her, relaxed, and then up, like he was thinking about it.

"Yeah. No. That doesn't happen to me."

Shiloh, mindful that she was finishing her drink in record time, which she had not intended to do, swallowed a large gulp. "I guess I should be flattered, then."

Joey grinned at her and didn't respond for a moment.

Shiloh finished her drink, eliciting a surprised face from Joey.

"What now?" she asked.

"Just surprised to see you letting loose."

"Mike told me to have a good time," she answered.

Joey's eyes flickered with mischief. "Mmm. And you always do what Mike tells you?"

It was stuff like this that drove her crazy about Joey. She sometimes wanted to punch him, and yet when he said things like this, it made her squirm. Which made her want to punch him even more.

She didn't answer, instead looking over at the bar. Their waiter was nowhere to be seen and she wanted another drink. Just one more, to make Joey bearable. "I don't see our waiter anywhere," she said. "I'm going to the bar. You want another one?"

"I can't let you go to the bar, Shy. That would be un-chivalrous. Unless..."

She was already getting out of their booth, but she paused, leaning back in on her elbow. "Unless...?"

"Well, if you're going to the bar just for drinks, it would be un-chivalrous of me to let you do that." He leaned forward on his forearms, which Shiloh couldn't help but take a moment to glance at and admire. "But if you're playing some kind of 'game,' well, then, that's different."

Shiloh narrowed her eyes and pursed her lips. It was a reflexive expression, one she wished she never made, and she tried to relax her features as soon as she was aware of what she was doing. But a knife of cold... what? Embarrassment? Fear? Arousal? All three? sliced through her.

She knew Joey and Mike were good friends, and she knew that Joey was an open book - too open, she would say. But she had always harbored the secret hope - or belief, she would say - that Mike kept their sex life bound up and away from Joey.

At the same time, Joey mentioning "the game" sent a little thrill through her.

Joey watched her face, and grinned at exactly the moment she had that thought, almost like he was reading her mind.

She shook her head before standing up. "I only play 'games' with Mike," she said. She was pleased with the face that Joey made as she walked away.

She was wearing a summery dress, black with white polka dots. It was short, showing off her legs, but loose-fitting, so she didn't look trampy. The back was open, and the deep plunge of the neckline showcased her breasts nicely. She knew she looked great, and something about looking great with Joey watching her walk away gave her a similar thrill to the thrill she got out of her and Mike's "game."

She maneuvered herself in at the corner of the bar and ordered, without looking around. The man next to her was staring at her, looking like he wanted to start a conversation, but she ignored him studiously. She waited silently, took the drinks, and returned.

"That guy was checking your ass out," Joey informed her.

Shiloh gave a toss of her hair and picked up her drink. "Hmm."

Joey gave this an appreciative chuckle and reached for his beer. "So what's the deal, Shiloh? With you and Mike? You just flirt, Hoover up some free drinks, and then... that's it?"

"Not that it's any of your business," Shiloh said, sipping her drink. They were going down easy, and she was getting a pleasant buzz. It really did feel good to be out. Even with Joey. And she had explicit permission to be doing this - from Mike.

Who *surely* knew what kind of guy Joey was.

And who had also, apparently, shared some details of their sex life with Joey.

This thought gave her a little bit of a rise.

"Not that it's any of my business," Joey echoed, mockingly. "But this isn't a business lunch. Come on Shy. Dish some dirt."

"You have the whole story," she said, tipping her head flirtatiously.

Joey scowled. "I don't believe it."

"What don't you believe?"

"Any of it," Joey said, smirking, returning to his alpha-male perch with his arms over the back of the booth.

"Ah," Shiloh said. She set her drink down and traced the lip of it with her finger, then touched her bare chest, tracing a line from the flesh of her left breast to her neck. "You don't think Mike's uptight suburban soccer mom-in-training has the nerve?"

Joey grinned and pointed a finger lazily at her without moving his arm. "You've got the nerve, Shiloh. I just don't get the impression that you're capable of having any *fun*."

She gave him her most simmering look, one she knew was heart-stopping - because Mike had told her. Framed by long, thick lashes, her eyes were an alluring, smoky blue, and a half-sleepy, bedroom-eyed gaze never failed her. "That's probably because whenever you see me, I'm with *you*," she quipped.

Joey's mouth pursed in an amused whistle, but he made no sound. She was pleased with herself for the witty comeback, pleased that it had gotten the reaction that it did.

"I have it on good authority that I'm *very* fun," Joey said.

"Yeah? Whose authority?"

Joey smirked. "It's my reputation."

"It's *part* of your reputation," she sniffed, taking another, too-large swallow of her drink. She smiled. "Anyway, like I said, this is none of your business."

"Not very many things are my business, Shiloh. I'm a man of leisure and recreation. I'm fixing your washer. For free. Humor me."

"Don't you have your own wild sexcapades to think about?"

"First of all, I have already jerked off to all of my own 'sexcapades' - are you in fifth grade? And secondly, this is *much* more interesting."

Shiloh smiled. "I'm *sure* it's not."

"Tell me about it, darlin,' and I'll be the judge of that."

"There's nothing else to tell, Joey. It's just... *that*. I flirt, Mike watches, and, you know... we go home. The end."

Joey looked at her without comment, then slowly started to shake his head, smirking a little. "Ehhhh... sorry, Shy. I can't picture it."

"You can't picture it," she repeated, sarcastically.

"I can't picture it," Joey said, lifting his hands and shrugging.

Another rise of that... something... swelled in her chest. She brushed her loose hair from her face and tilted her head into her hand. "Well..." she

began, and then had no idea what else to say. She shrugged. "Oh well. Too bad for you."

"I'm the kind of guy who needs to see things to believe them," Joey continued.

"You're not cajoling me into doing this," she retorted, in her firmest voice.

He pointed at her again. "*That's* the Shiloh I know. See, that's why I have a hard time believing this."

"We have *rules*," she said quietly, getting a little flustered, annoyed with herself for getting flustered. This was just like Joey, just how she had him pegged. Always trying to get women to do things, always getting his way. "*You* should know that."

"I like rules. Tell me about them."

She tipped her head to the side and narrowed her eyes. "One of the rules is that I do this stuff with *Mike*. Not his jackass friend."

Joey smiled. "That is a very boring rule, Shiloh, to be perfectly honest."

"I'm guessing all rules are boring to you."

"Nope. Some rules give me a fucking hard-on."

Shiloh's breath actually froze, crystallizing into a nexus of prickling icicles in her chest. "Like what?" she said, barely able to expel enough of her icy breath to say the two words.

"Like... 'I only share my mouth.' Or: 'I can only fuck with my heels on.'"

Her pussy contracted, an ache chasing after the warm, wet liquid that was seeping into her panties. She could feel a flush creeping across her cheeks and willed it away. She forced herself to keep her eyes on Joey's smirking, asshole expression. His words bounced around in her head, conjuring all kinds of filthy images, thoughts, and feelings.

This had, she decided, definitely crossed some line. Her mind was at work, retracing the conversation, trying to decipher if she had crossed the line herself, or led Joey across it. But Joey was Joey, he was always saying inappropriate things.

Just not quite so... shocking.

Not quite so close to home.

She had a moment of terrifying vertigo, feeling like she had gone out too far on a limb. What would Mike say, if he knew she was having this

particular conversation with Joey? She felt a heavy throb of guilt travel from her throat to her stomach, like she'd swallowed a glob of lava.

She shook her head dismissively, getting a hold of herself. "We're not that deep in the bubble, Joey."

"But will you ever be?"

He shot this back so quickly, his eyes boring into hers, that she looked away as a reflex.

"Look, one thing I know is that I don't think we should be having this conversation," she said, her words staccatoed, hollow.

"No conversation, gotcha," Joey said. "That's a good rule."

"No *friends*," she retorted.

"No conversations with friends. Racy."

"Joey," she said, exasperated. "No... you know. *Anything*. With friends. Of Mike's."

"Yeah, yeah, I got you," he said. "But it doesn't seem to me, Shy, like you're doing *anything* with *anyone*. Or am I wrong about that?"

She slammed the rest of her drink. "I don't think I should be talking to you about this."

"You could *show* me," he suggested.

She narrowed her eyes. "Does Mike know you're this big of a pig?"

"Ah. Okay. It's Mike." He fished his phone out of his pocket and started to swipe at the screen. Shiloh stared at him for a moment, unable to process what he was doing.

"Wait," she said, reaching for the phone. He snatched it out of her reach and continued typing.

"What are you doing?" she muttered.

"I'm asking... Mike..." he typed, and then set the phone down, "if you have permission to show me what you guys get up to. Is all."

Her heart nearly exploded. "Joey," she whined, reaching for his phone.

He let her grab it and read the message.

Here with Shy at Beastro. Does she have your permission to flirt with the waiter?

"With the waiter?" she said, her throat dry. She looked up. "I don't even *like* the waiter."

Joey snatched the phone and typed.

"What the hell are you *doing*?"

"Amending," Joey said, holding up a finger and typing with one thumb.

He showed her the screen when he was done.

Correction: with some other dude. She doesn't like the waiter.

For a moment, Shiloh felt like she was going to cry. She had these moments of intense physical reaction sometimes, usually when something went outside of her control, and she hated them. They had happened at least three times a day when she was an adolescent, and much less frequently now. She regained her control immediately - she was experienced at that. But she still felt like she had gone off the map, she was lost. There was something dark and dangerous about what was happening here, darker even in the truth that she was refusing to admit to herself: there was, underneath all the weird angst, a thrill that was blossoming inside of her.

This *was* kind of... *fun*.

But no, she thought, just as quickly. This was wrong, all wrong. She might entertain the occasional naughty thought about Joey, but it was always a fog of thought, not anything real that she would ever act on. At all. In any way. And it felt so... invasive, that he was talking to Mike about it. Even if Joey had been the one to stimulate the conversation that led to this "game," - she still didn't want him involved in it.

Not at all.

She fished her phone out of her bag and hurriedly typed to Mike.

"Aw, Shiloh, don't," he whined, his tone mocking. "You're taking all the fun out of it for him."

She paused, her fingers hovering over the screen.

Joey, aware that he had her attention, dove into it. "He likes the angst, Shiloh. If you go writing to him that everything is hunky-dorey, he won't get any of that."

She glared at him over the phone, her fingers typing nonsense for good measure.

"Or maybe you think I'm wrong?" Joey laughed. "He doesn't like the angst?"

Mike's exact words, in fact: *I like the angst.*

She stared at Joey. "It doesn't -"

She was about to say "feel right," but Joey's phone buzzed.

Joey read the message and smiled. Then he put his phone back on the table, face-down.

"Well?" she snapped.

Joey sipped his beer. "That wasn't him," he said, smirking as he set his drink down.

Shiloh started to revise the nonsense words in her message.

Joey reached over and put his hand on hers. The small callouses scraped her skin, the warmth of it sent a shiver through her. She actually, literally, melted between her legs. And let him take the phone out of her hand.

"Joey!" she complained. But it was half-hearted, and worse yet, Joey knew it. She could see it in his grin.

He shook his head. "Just wait a minute, let the man respond. Trust me, Shiloh."

"Why would I trust *you*?" she whined, reaching for her phone. "Joey, seriously. Come on."

He slid it out of her reach. "Tell me something Shiloh. Do you get your information about shit, say like, medicine... from some random guy off the street, or do you ask an expert?"

Shiloh groaned. Something was logically wrong about that statement, but her head was spinning, and she was disarmed. She couldn't come up with her counter-argument fast enough.

And that *never* happened to her.

"I'm not asking -" she began, but Joey's phone buzzed again.

He read it aloud:

"Mike says: 'Fuck that's hot. Yes.'"

Shiloh waited. Then she shook her head. "Well, whatever. I'm still not doing it."

"Doing *what*? Flirting? I thought this was your game."

Shiloh sat back and folded her arms. Exasperated. "It's my game *with Mike*."

"Mike's *in* the game," Joey said, shaking his phone, the screen facing her.

She glared at him.

"What? Look, Shy, *you're* out of bounds for me. *I'm* not putting any moves on you here. I'm just... a man who has sincere doubts that you are able to flirt with another man, is all." He held a finger to his temple. "I only believe what I can see, Shy."

She glared at him.

"You didn't put that dress on just for me, right?"

What a trap.

What an *asshole*.

"Look, Joey," she began, waving her hand at him. "I don't know what the hell you're up to -"

"I'm just proving a point, darlin'," Joey said.

"A point?" she scoffed. "Which is?"

"That you are too tightly wrapped to have any fun. Even when you have permission."

Shiloh willed herself to not take the bait.

"There's nobody here worth flirting with," she said, finally.

"*I'm* here."

A moment, of unwanted and incredibly powerful lust. Shiloh looked away. "And you're obviously out-of-bounds," she said. Annoyance dripped from her voice. Well, good.

"I am, I am. I'm Mike's good friend -"

"And you're a skeeze."

"Well," Joey said, a satisfied grin on his face. "That is your opinion, and it shows you have good instincts, darlin'. But it has nothing to do with why I'm out-of-bounds." He smiled and shrugged. "Well, whatever. I just thought it would be a nice distraction."

She raised her eyebrows. "Oh, gee, thanks."

"Look, Shy, it's tough being a good guy, okay? I'd have put the moves on you a long time ago if you weren't Mike's wife." He leaned in again. "I would have fucked your brains out."

Briefly, Shiloh's mind disintegrated, while her whole body turned to lava.

"It ain't easy, passing the time with a woman of your considerable charms, knowing I have no shot, no shot at all."

He has his very put-on Southern accent on, dripping with a lazy, false charm that she knew was bullshit, but still found charming.

If, you know, you didn't *know* Joey.

"Shut the hell up with that," she laughed. Then she sipped the last of her drink and cast an eye around the bar.

It *would* be fun.

The voice came to her, from the very dark, very locked chamber deep inside of her, where she kept all of her secrets, all the moist ideas that she didn't want to admit to having.

After all, though: she *did* have Mike's permission. She did have Joey here with her, and while she did think of Joey as a consummate jerk, she also had a weird confidence in Joey to not cross the line with her.

This confidence, she realized, was part of the reason she felt comfortable even dipping her toe in the feelings that Joey inspired in her. She and Mike had had more than one fight centered around Joey, and when the discussion inevitably ran aground at how Joey was a slutty man-whore, Mike never failed to explain that Joey *was* all of the terrible things she thought he was. But he was also a man who strictly adhered to his own code of ethics. Sleeping with a buddy's wife was against his rules.

And she could see that about Joey, and whether she wanted to admit it or not, she believed it about him.

Joey leaned back and shook his head. "Shy, you know, you're the only girl I ever met who doesn't like my Matthew McConaughey voice."

"Really?" Shiloh said, feeling the familiar pull of this kind of exchange with Joey, the loosely flirtatious, going-nowhere, semi-adversarial banter. "So tell me something. How is it you've managed to only meet *one* woman with an IQ over 100 in your whole life?"

Joey liked this. He grinned, which made Shiloh grin, and then he rubbed his chest. "It's the pecs," he said, and then flexed his biceps. "And the guns. Knocks the sense right out of them. They don't know what hit 'em."

Shiloh snorted and slid her empty glass toward Joey. "Your turn," she said.

"My turn," Joey said, exaggerating his drawl. "Come on, come on -"

"Ack!" Shiloh cut him off. "Don't start it. It's too..."

"Hot?"

"Smarmy," she said.

Joey was already getting up and taking the glass with him, grinning broadly.

Shiloh leaned back in the booth and spun a drink menu around to read it but ended up surveying the scene on the rooftop bar. It gave her a delicious shiver to be *out*. Even if it was with Joey, even if Mike was far away. The evening seemed pregnant with excitement, which was nice - even if it was all an illusion. The last two years had been totally devoid of even the promise of excitement, illusion or not.

She slipped her phone out and re-read her last - still un-sent - message to Mike, then deleted it before typing:

Okay, well, I'm here with Joey.

She held up the phone and took a picture of Joey getting more drinks, engaged in an animated conversation with a woman who barely looked legal enough for a hookah bar, wearing a tight red dress that gave her a whoreish appearance. He was leaning in close to her, probably using his fake Southern drawl on her, and she seemed to be eating it up with a spoon.

She sent the photo without further comment.

Joey looked up at her and she grinned menacingly, tipping her head to the side. "Where's my drink?" she mouthed. She hoped she was fucking up Joey's game.

He smiled back at her, a little dangerously, and continued talking to his floozy.

"You all good here?"

She looked up at the waiter - a kid, really, who didn't look old enough to be serving alcohol. He was smiling at her.

"Uh... yeah, you know, no. Could you get me one of these?" She flipped the drink menu around and pointed to the very large, blue drink pictured in the photo. She didn't know what it was, and she didn't go for blue, calorie-riddled drinks, but an impish impulse had overtaken her.

"A Blue Lagoon?" he asked, smiling. "Those things are huge. You got somebody to share it with?"

She smiled, slipping a little into a flirtatious territory, batting her eyes. "Possibly that guy over there," she said, waving dismissively in Joey's direction. "But he's my ride home, so I'm good either way."

She watched his eyes - something she'd started doing since she and Mike had begun playing "the game." They floated quickly over her chest, down to her left hand, where they lingered momentarily on her wedding

ring. A frisson of excitement traveled down her spine, and the air between them seemed to heat up.

She was looking at his eyes when they snapped back to hers. "Okay. One Blue Lagoon... anything for your, uh... driver?" He glanced in Joey's direction, saving a complicit grin for her.

As she glanced with him toward Joey, she caught, in the corner of her eye, that Joey was looking at them, watching their exchange. Or at least he seemed to be.

And suddenly the whole interaction superheated, like it did with Mike. There was nothing extraordinary about the way she was talking to this guy, nothing new in the fact that he - like any guy she spoke to - was conveying a message of embedded hope. Broadcasting it, in fact: *looks like you have things all tied up here, but if you don't... you can always give me a call.*

But something about being *watched*, being watched by a man who you knew was watching *you*, made interactions like this thrilling again.

She leaned on her hand and gave the waiter a coy smile. "Nothing for him," she said, giving her magnificent wavy hair a toss.

The waiter fumbled a little, said "Okey-dokey," and started off toward the bar. Shiloh kept her eyes on him until he was a few yards away and then slowly slid her gaze over to Joey.

Who was grinning at her. He lifted a beer and winked.

Shiloh turned and looked out over the low wall of the patio, at another rooftop bar a few buildings down, mostly to hide her satisfied smile.

Her phone buzzed. She lifted it and looked at the screen, realizing, as she did, that her two drinks had gone very rapidly to her head.

Looks like Joey doesn't understand this game

She smiled. As always, Mike made her laugh. His light-hearted reply was reassuring to her, even if she still had a little shard of annoyance lodged in her chest about Mike telling Joey about "the game."

Yeah, about that: why'd you tell him?

She typed the reply but hesitated. Once the words were typed out, it seemed like a silly question. Joey was really the source of the game even

being part of their marriage. It was only because Joey was into it, because Joey talked about it, that Mike had even proposed it to her as something to do. *Of course* Mike would tell Joey that they sometimes played this game.

And beyond talking about it ("Shiloh flirts with other guys while I watch"), what was there to tell or be told?

Nothing.

The waiter returned, and Shiloh put her phone away without sending the message. In part because it was silly. In part because Joey's voice simmered to the surface of her consciousness: *don't ruin it for him, he likes the angst.*

And, in part, because Joey was strolling back to the table, one rum and Coke and one beer in his hands.

*

"I think I'd better help you out with this one," Joey said, sliding the second Blue Lagoon toward himself and punching a straw into the slushy mixture. Shiloh was holding her fingers to the bridge of her nose and squinting, pained by a grain-freeze headache.

"Ugh," he said, after taking a long draw. "Shy, that's terrible. Why the hell'd you order this thing?"

She shrugged, her headache abating. "Fun?"

Joey shrugged back and took another long draw through the straw. She reached for the drink and started pulling it back toward her. "Hey," she said. "I thought you hated it?"

"I do. I do," he laughed. "But I have responsibilities."

Shiloh was drunk now. Good and drunk, and having a great time, actually, with Joey. She had asked him about his skanky hoe from the bar, and the subsequent banter had turned into a rating game, which was actually quite fun.

Because it was all just that: fun, and only fun.

"Responsibilities?" she said, actually struggling for a moment with what he meant by that.

Joey pointed the straw at her, and then dipped it back into the drink, letting her take it to her side of the table. "I don't think Mike would like it very much if you got wasted and fell down the stairs or something," he said, solemnly. He leaned over and looked under the table, where Shiloh had her

legs crossed appealingly. She enjoyed watching his eyes move up and down her legs, even if it was stupid Joey.

At least she still had it.

"Those shoes look like a dangerous combination with this drink," he assessed, sitting up.

"Well," she said, scooting out to the edge of the booth before swinging her legs out. "We'll see." She stood up. "I have to go to the ladies," she told Joey.

She felt fine. She was at the level of drunkenness where she was just flying. She didn't drink a ton, but alcohol had an odd effect on her: it rarely chipped away at her physical abilities unless she got really wasted.

Her decision-making was another story.

She glided toward the stairs, feeling quite drunk, but walking with her best slinky walk, a skill a friend from college, who had worked as a model had taught her, the "catwalk" walk, one foot placed directly in front of the other.

Halfway down the stairs, she was satisfied with her walk, but unnerved by the mental state that had led her to do it.

She primped a little before going into a stall, and then more when she got out. She was pleased with her reflection, satisfied that she didn't look like she was trying too hard to look beautiful. She met her own eyes in the mirror and had a pang of guilt, but there was no real place to put it. She wasn't flirting with *Joey*, after all. She had permission to be doing this from her husband. Who wanted her to. And all she was really doing was "rating" guys she would never see again, and so it was all just a bunch of harmless, sanctioned fun that she shouldn't feel bad about.

She smiled at herself in the mirror and headed back upstairs.

Joey was deeply engrossed in his phone, which she hadn't expected. It broke up the mood a little, and she found herself mildly annoyed as she sat down, especially because Joey didn't even look up at her right away.

He finished typing, while Shiloh's mood sank with each passing second. She became irritated with herself: irritated that she needed or wanted Joey's attention enough that his *inattention* would affect her mood at all.

He looked up, grinning, leaving the phone on the table.

"Hot date?" Shiloh asked, too much emotion in her voice.

Joey shrugged, glancing down at the phone. "Hot *party*," he said.

"Oh-ho," Shiloh said, sliding her drink closer. "You need to go? I can take a cab home." Her voice was studiously cheerful. It was very important that Joey not think she was disappointed. And anyway, she should probably get home before she drank herself another decibel of headache.

"I'm not making you take a *cab* home, Shiloh," Joey said. "Come on, now. What kind of friend would I be?"

Shiloh shrugged and tipped her head... tipsily. "I don't want to be the reason your big plans for the evening fall through."

"No big plans," Joey said, grinning. His phone lit up with another message, and he held her gaze for a few beats before casually picking it up and being drawn into the messages.

"Seriously," she said, after a few moments, as he typed what seemed like a lengthy reply. "I should probably get home anyway..."

Joey looked up, the phone in two hands, his thumbs hovering over the screen. "You want to go with me?"

She swallowed. A throb of excitement swelled in her chest, and her stomach did a little flip. The prospect of a party was appealing, the prospect of going home was not. And in the middle of all of it was Joey, who spending time with ran hot and cold as a prospect.

Better go home, she told herself. It was *always* a better idea to go home, whatever the choices were.

She smiled, her mouth open to say, "maybe." She shook her head, to force herself to follow up with a polite decline. "Nah," she said. "No, I shouldn't, I should get home. I can just take a cab, seriously."

Joey set the phone on the table, face-down, and lifted his beer. She'd kept an eye on his drinks, just because she didn't trust Joey's definition of "drunk driving." He was only on his third beer, and seemed sober as stone. "It's on the way," he said, suggestively.

"Huh?"

"To your place. The party. We could just... pop in for a bit."

Shiloh was warming to the idea, trying to figure out how to change her mind without looking desperate, longing to be in a house party, full of people, to keep the fun of being out going just a little longer...

Joey, though, became suddenly somber and frowned. "Actually, no... you're right, we should just... get you home."

"Awww," she cooed. "*What?* I was just getting into the idea," she complained.

She was definitely drunk. Her emotions were swinging wildly.

Joey shook his head. "Eh..." he said, and then looked off to his right, like he was thinking. "Nah. We should probably not."

"Wait, what?" she asked. Now she was intrigued, which she guessed was probably Joey's goal. But she was drunk, feeling high and having fun, and she didn't want it to end. "You can't *ask me* to a party and then... you know, snatch it away like that."

Joey was more serious than anything now. "My bad, Shiloh," he said, somberly.

She looked at him in disbelief. "Your *bad*? Dude." She looked over at the bar, suddenly quite steamed.

"Hey, look, I'm sorry," he said, very genuinely. "Let's just have some more drinks."

Shiloh lifted her straw, with a glob of blue slush on the end, listlessly.

"Shy, I wasn't thinking straight, okay? It's... not... uh, your kind of party, now that I think about it."

"Not my *kind* of party?" she said, incredulously. "What kind of party *is it*?"

Joey smiled back at her mysteriously.

"It's not some kind of like, sex party or something, is it?" she asked, scoffing at the ridiculousness of such an idea. But as soon as she said it, and she watched Joey's face, she realized that it wasn't that radical of an idea.

Joey just smiled, a glint in his eye, but a look of resolution on his features.

She stabbed her straw into her drink and pushed it out of the way. "It is?" she asked excitedly, not sure where her reaction was coming from.

"*Actually*?"

Joey shrugged.

"Noooo," she said. "Like, it's actually... a party where people are just like... there to have sex?"

Joey shrugged again and looked up at the sky. "Like I said..."

"Like swingers and stuff?" she asked. "Or that... what's the thing you said you do?"

Joey made a mockery of looking confused. "That could be anything, Shy..."

"Where you like, sleep with married women or like, your girlfriend sleeps with other guys," Shiloh said. "Joey, Jesus, like the game. You know

what I'm talking about!"

He was looking back at her with a blankness so overwrought she had an urge to slap him again.

He broke the somber expression and smiled broadly. "Yes, Shy. *That* kind of party."

She plopped backward in the booth. "Not *really*," she said, her mouth falling open. "You're messing with me."

"You *can't* be surprised about this," Joey countered.

"I didn't think these things were real!" Shiloh said, shaking her head.

She really hadn't, if she was being perfectly honest. It had taken her long enough to believe that guys wanting to watch their girlfriends and wives having sex with other men was even a real thing and not just some weird internet meme or urban legend.

But parties just for that? It seemed a little too...

Joey was sipping his beer.

"So, what? You go to this party and just take your clothes off and start... having sex with anyone?"

Joey looked up at the sky again, but offered no answer.

"*Seriously?*" Shiloh exclaimed. "Wow."

"That's not really how it goes down," Joey said. "Anyway, don't worry about it. That's not for you folks in the kiddie pool."

People who knew Shiloh well, or perhaps better stated, who knew Shiloh at all, knew full well that saying something like "kiddie pool" about anything Shiloh was doing was a direct ticket to unleashing a certain aspect of her personality that she was not very proud of. A sort of hyper-competitive, easily wound-up, stubborn side to her psyche.

"Too *deep* for me," she said sarcastically. "Uh-huh."

Joey looked at her over the drinks as she sucked up an enormous amount of her Blue Lagoon, regretting the headache it would surely give her even before it began to throb in her temple.

His eyes glimmered with something - deep interest, which Shiloh found satisfying - before he shook his head. "Man. Okay, Shiloh, I think we better get you home."

"Is this the kind of party where you absolutely have to get naked and fuck someone?" she demanded. "Like, is that some kind of rule?"

Joey's interested face was back on. Their respective stares wandered, and then locked, with a click that was almost audible, into a fun,

competitive glare.

"Well?" she demanded, playing with her straw. "Is it?"

Joey moved his head slowly. "No," he said, as if the topic had become a diplomatic quagmire. "Not a rule."

"So... someone could just go, and, you know... have some drinks. See what's up?"

Joey looked uncomfortable now. "Yeah..." he said, doubtfully. "Uh... no. Yeah, it's time to get home, Shy."

"Is it Mike you're worried about?"

Joey stared back at her, the same twist of emotions on his face. He was uncomfortable, and Shiloh had never, ever seen him like this.

Finally, she thought, a feeling of triumph in her chest. Adrenaline, a strong elixir of triumph and a competitive win, poured into her arteries.

This was the problem with booze, she thought, though only momentarily. It made her like this: quick to make rash decisions. She didn't even really want to go to this party until this moment, now that she saw how uncomfortable it was making Joey.

She fished her phone out of her purse. "Here," she said. "Let's ask him."

She dialed his number, her finger flying over the screen, her mind far ahead of her thoughts, her fingers moving without her thinking about them. The phone started to ring.

"Shiloh," Joey objected, sullenly, reaching for the phone.

She leaned away. "Let's just ask him. If he answers, then okay, we see what he says. If he doesn't answer..." she let her voice trail off.

Then what?

"Hey. Shiloh?" Mike's voice was in her ear. He sounded concerned.

"Give me the phone, Shy," Joey said.

Shiloh grinned and held up a finger. She wasn't sure what she was doing, exactly. If she wanted to get Joey in trouble with Mike, tease Mike, tease Joey, or actually get permission to go to the party. "Hey, babe. So listen -"

"Shiloh, are you okay?"

"I'm fine, listen, I'm out with Joey, like you said we should do. And now Joey is being very rude, and trying to run off to a party, and ditch me. Well, first he offered to take me, and then he said, no, it's some kind of

swinger-hotwife party and I can't go because I'm too... what did you say?" she looked at Joey. "In the kiddie pool?"

Joey grimaced. There was nothing on the other end of the line but the sound of a crowded bar, or possibly silence, because her bar sounded exactly the same.

"Shiloh, is this for real?" Mike finally said.

She had a momentary lapse of memory and had no idea what she was even calling him about.

"Yes, it's for real," she said, suddenly, the memories pouring back into her head. "So I said, okay, let's call Mike and see what he thinks. So that's... what I'm doing. Calling you to see what you think."

There was a long pause on the other end. Shiloh decided Mike really was in a bar or a club, and she wasn't just hearing things.

"Shy, are you drunk?" Mike said, finally.

"She is," Joey called out from across the table. Shiloh glared at him and waved a hand in his direction to get him to lean back. "Like a skunk."

"I've had a few," she said. "But I'm at a *bar*. So... and anyway, where are *you*?"

She was getting suspicious about something. An element of the noise she could hear in the background was making her think of something, some place... But she couldn't quite grasp it.

"Shy," Mike laughed, genuinely sweetly. "Baby, just give the phone to Joey, okay? I want to -"

"Are you at a *stripclub*?" Shiloh interjected. The idea had blossomed in her head and burst from her mouth before ever reaching her consciousness. But now that she had said it, she realized she had hit the nail on the head.

"Uh," Mike said. A muffling occurred on the phone, and Shiloh pictured her husband moving to a dark corner and covering his mouth to shield the noise.

"Uh?" Shiloh said.

Joey took advantage of the distraction this caused, and reached for the phone, which Shiloh let him have, if only because she was stunned, and because Joey did it with a charming smile and a sort of assuredness in his demeanor. Like he would solve this - whatever it was, not problem, really - and put everything right.

"Buddy, listen," Joey said, smiling at Shiloh. "This is all a huge misunderstanding -"

Shiloh reached for the phone, and Joey held up his arm so fast that Shiloh was actually stunned when her hand ran into the heavy muscle of his forearm.

"Give me the phone, Joey," she hissed. "I'm still talking to him!"

"No," Joey said, to Mike. He held up a finger to Shiloh to shush her, which only had the effect of making her outrageously angry. The worst part was that she wasn't even sure where to place the anger.

She snatched at the phone as Joey was talking.

"Are you at a stripclub?" she demanded.

"Shiloh, baby, yes, but I don't even want to be here, okay? This is clients..." he sighed. "Anyway... Shy, we don't have some rule about this. What's going on?"

Shiloh blushed a little. There was no reason to be getting worked up about this. She knew perfectly well that sometimes clients insisted on going to stripclubs. It was sports marketing. What could anyone expect from a business like that?

"Look," she said, tossing her hair again and eyeing Joey. "I don't care about that. But the way I see it, if you're out having fun at a stripclub, then it's only fair if I get to go to a big-girl party, too. Right?"

Another long pause. Someone in the background called out Mike's name.

"Shy..." Mike said. "I mean... are you serious about this?"

"What's that supposed to mean?" she laughed. "Why would I call you about it if I'm not serious about it?"

"Uh... sure, but just, uh... why do you want to do this all of the sudden?"

Shiloh didn't have an answer. It was under layers and layers of jumbled, drunk thoughts and feelings. It had something to do with being out for the first time in a long time, with the leftover boredom of the pandemic, with the unfairness of Mike being out doing fun things while she was stuck at the homestead. There were elements of her annoyance with Joey, elements of her suppressed (and definitely, still, taboo) attraction-hate to Joey. There was curiosity, a sense of adventure and opportunity.

And, to be sure, a lot of alcohol.

But there was no way, at least none that she could map out in her current state, to explain all of that to Mike over the phone.

"I don't know," she said mysteriously, drawing with her finger on the table through a tiny pool of condensation left at the base of her huge glass. "Just... curious, I guess. And maybe a little bit drunk. But just for the record, it *does* seem kind of fair. You being at a stripclub and all."

There was another significant pause. Shiloh looked at Joey, who had gone from being adversarial to smiling with a certain degree of complicity. This was a dangerous edge, and it made Shiloh's head spin a little.

"Babe, okay, look... uh, give the phone back to Joey, okay?"

"What? Why?"

"Shy, I just need to talk to him about this, okay? Set some... I don't know, ground rules or something."

Shiloh's mouth fell open. "What? We already have ground rules. I'm not going to break them just because -"

"Shy, no, baby, it's not like that, it's just... look, let me talk to Joey. Please. And then if... you know, like, it's cool... I guess..."

Shiloh sighed. Mike was right, after all: this wasn't the time to be hashing out all this stuff, or to be taking some big step like this. She felt a strong pull to somehow put a cork back in this bottle and go straight home.

But Joey was looking at her - *smirking* at her, and a loud cheer went up in the background, and she was having so much fun... and it would be fun, she thought, just to teach Mike the tiniest bit of a lesson about what it felt like to be left out all the time...

"If it's cool," she repeated.

"Yeah, Shy, like... I have to *talk* to him. Okay?"

"You don't want me to go."

Another pause.

"Baby, look, I... no, I want you to go. I want you to have a good time. I mean, seriously, Shy... we've been talking about this forever now. I just didn't... I'm out with clients, they're giving me weird looks, this is just a bad time, okay? I just want to talk to Joey and get an idea of like... what the vibe is. At the party. And make sure he's going to be... I don't know. A decent chaperon."

"*Chaperon?*" Shiloh screeched.

Joey held his hand out, opening and closing his palm.

"Ugh," Shiloh said, slamming the phone into his palm.

Joey didn't say much besides "yeah," "no, definitely she is," and "no," for a few minutes, and Shiloh couldn't hear Mike as clearly second-hand as Joey evidently heard him. The waiter passed by, so Shiloh leaned out to grab his arm coquettishly and asked for another drink.

Joey, eyes hawk-like, snapped his fingers at the waiter and shook his head.

The waiter looked back and forth from one to the other, obviously torn.

"He's my younger brother," Shiloh told the waiter, shaking her head and lying with incredible ease. "And he's a huge, overprotective, bossy little dick. He's always been this way. And he's *younger* than me." She blinked imploringly at the waiter. "Just get me the drink. Please?"

"Not a Blue Lagoon," Joey said, aloud, covering the mouthpiece of the phone.

Shiloh glared at him.

"Do you want to come to the party?" Joey hissed, raising his eyebrows. He mouthed: "Then no Blue Lagoon."

Shiloh rolled her eyes back up to the very uncomfortable waiter, a sandy-haired kid who seemed too young to be serving. It occurred to her that she might have cornered a bus boy. "Just get me a rum and Diet Coke, please," she sighed. The waiter looked relieved by the resolution to his problems, and started to edge away from them.

"Yeah, man, I got it." He was looking at Shiloh across the table with an odd expression, smiling. "Sure man," he said, solemnly. "You want to talk to Shy? She's gonna need to hear that from you."

Shiloh put her hand out, incensed by something.

She put the phone to her ear after Joey handed it to her, grinning.

"So?" she said, an uncharacteristic sassiness in her voice. She sounded sixteen. This was getting ridiculous. And yet, she was deeply interested in it all unfolding, in the weird dynamics of it, the alluring promise of whatever Joey and Mike were cooking up together.

"So Shy, honey, don't take this the wrong way, but Joey thinks you're pretty wasted -"

"I am not *that* -"

"Hey, hey, hey, okay, calm down, I know. You're fine. It's just... this is a big step, you know? And I want you to go have a good time, satisfy your

curiosity... I dunno, maybe get inspired. But if you go tonight, there's no... you know. You're strictly there for observation. Okay?"

"Ugh, *God!* That's all I was going to do anyway," Shiloh muttered.

"Yeah, I know, sweetie. I know that. But you know, you're... I mean, you do sound a little drunk -"

"Yeah, okay, so do you -"

"And all that means is, Joey is going to just, I don't know. Keep an eye on things. And you have to promise me you'll do whatever he says."

A laugh, lusty and also uncharacteristic, erupted from Shiloh's mouth. "Do whatever Joey says..." she said, deliberately dripping with lustiness.

Joey grinned at her from across the table, his arms folded over his chest. He nodded and licked his upper lip, but it was clear - somehow - that he had every intention of being as platonic as possible.

"You know I don't mean it like *that*," Mike said.

"Does Joey?" she asked.

"He does," Mike said with total confidence. "So just to reiterate: I'm at the stripclub, you're at the party. Strictly observing. Both of us."

Shiloh smiled at Joey. "And Joey's in charge."

She had no idea why she said that, why she said it the way that she did.

"Ugh, babe -"

"God, okay, okay, I was just joking," Shiloh said, quickly.

There was an odd silence.

"Mike," she said, purring. "This is totally not a big thing. I don't even have to go -"

"No, Shiloh, *please*. It's really, *really*..." the sound became even more muffled, and she pictured him curling up to speak into the phone, making himself into a phone booth. "It's really okay. Okay? I *want* you to go. Just... yeah, if Joey thinks you're doing something you shouldn't be doing, you know, he's going to... I asked him to, you know. Cut you off. Is all. Like I would."

A wave of extreme irritation came over her. Wasn't this all supposed to be about trust? Isn't that what they had talked about, their heads on the pillow, when Mike had been explaining this whole thing to her?

She wanted to ask him that, but she didn't want to get into it with Joey hovering in front of her, his apparently dog-like ears listening in on every syllable.

"And you trust *Joey* to do this?" she asked, scoffing.

Joey, who was already grinning, somehow seemed to grin more. He winked at her.

"Shy, baby, we've been over this. Obviously I trust Joey with this."

"Okay, then," Shiloh said. Her tone sounded somewhat defiant, and she gave her hair a shake and tilted her chin up as she said it. "I'll go. And I'll keep you posted."

"Please do that," Mike begged, and she could hear the excited ripple in his voice.

"And Joey's in charge," Shiloh repeated.

The waiter was coming with her drink, so she held the phone out to Joey, who took it reluctantly.

"Joey in charge, of our days, and our nights..." she sang softly, to the tune of the eighties TV show *Charles In Charge*, grinning at Joey, who - she noted with great satisfaction - looked mildly uncomfortable as he began agreeing to whatever it was that Mike was barking into the phone.

CHAPTER 3

"Hey, baby."

The woman who answered the door seemed genuinely pleased to see Joey. She was a fantastically tall, incredibly attractive woman. Older, though Shiloh wasn't exactly sure what gave away her age: she had long, silky brown hair with streaks of blond in it that seemed to have come from natural time in the sun, dark eyes framed by thick lashes, and a youthful sheen on her full cheeks.

More arresting, though, was her body: full, round breasts and a narrow waist perched atop a Kardashian-level booty, and she had it all crammed into a tight-fitting black dress made of something that was obviously not real animal skin, or fur, or leather, but some sort of expensive synthetic designed ingeniously to look like all three.

Not that anyone would care what her dress was *made* of.

Shiloh felt instantly plain, and an intimidating burn coursed through her as the woman kissed Joey on the lips - too sensually to be a mere hello, not intensely enough to be the kiss of a true lover. "I'm so glad you're here," she purred, her limbs moving sensually, hands all over Joey's chest.

But her eyes went immediately to Shiloh. She looked her up and down, and a sensual smile turned up her mouth. "And who's this? New girl?" She offered Shiloh her hand, regally, and for a moment Shiloh almost felt compelled to kiss it. Luckily, she stopped herself and shook it instead.

Joey leaned close to the woman's ear, but spoke loudly enough that Shiloh could hear. "This is my buddy's wife," he told her solemnly. "She's off-limits. Just here to see what it's all about."

The woman's lower lip protruded in disappointment, and she stroked Joey's chest again. "Oh, you're not here just to *babysit*," she complained. Her eyes went back to Shiloh. "Or can he play, too?"

Shiloh shrugged. She was pretty lit, she had to admit, and she was enjoying channeling a character at this point. "Dunno," she said cheerfully. "Joey's in charge. That's all I've been told."

This made the woman look back at Joey with a pleased expression. "I *see*," she purred, smiling. Her hand started to travel, moving down toward Joey's crotch. Shiloh couldn't help it, she followed the woman's fingers with

her own eyes, to the one place she didn't give herself permission to look - *ever*.

Joey stopped her hand. Smoothly, he took it and brought it to his lips, kissing the back of it, eliciting another purr. "Nah, Vicky, sorry, it ain't like that."

This made Vicky pout again, but only temporarily. "We'll see," she said. She gave Shiloh another seductive look, and Shiloh momentarily wondered whether or not she *did* have a deeply buried lesbian desire she had never known about.

"Look who it is," a male voice said from behind the luscious Vicky. A tall, broad-shouldered man with curly brown hair appeared behind her and put one hand on Vicky's shoulder, extending the other to Joey. They grasped at the forearms and shook firmly.

The man didn't waste any time looking over to Shiloh, who suddenly felt extremely self-conscious. Self-conscious, but not enough to dilute the burning curiosity she had about what was inside this house.

They were in a neighborhood called The Hills, where tract upon tract of suburban housing cut into the foothills. It had all seemed so... ordinary... as they drove here. She had almost begun to believe that this was an elaborate prank engineered by Mike and Joey, though Mike wasn't the type to do that sort of thing to her.

"This is Cheyenne," Joey said, looking at Shiloh.

She glared at him.

On the way there, he had advised her to use a fake name, and she had resoundingly rejected Cheyenne. "Sounds like a stripper," she had said, horrified.

"I mean," Joey had countered. "*Shiloh* is sort of a stripper name."

"I refuse to go by Cheyenne," she had stated flatly.

"So what, then? Deb?"

"Oh God."

"Becky?"

She had slapped him on the arm, then, and gotten a lecture about distracting the driver. Joey was honestly taking his job more seriously than she felt was warranted.

But they had, if she remembered correctly, decided on Valerie.

"Cheyenne," the man said, lustily.

"Yeah, man," Joey said, leaning in to speak to him in his ear. "She's not in play."

Vicky looked at Shiloh and winked, as if the two of them shared some kind of secret. Shiloh's face felt hot and she hoped she wasn't blushing.

"*Really?*" the man asked, not taking it seriously. "That's a shame because -"

"Nah man, really," Joey said.

"He's babysitting me," Shiloh said, tipping her head to the side and crossing her arms loosely at her chest.

"Yeah, okay, kid," Joey said, diving into the role. He put an arm around Shiloh's shoulders and pulled her in to give her a noogie. It was gentle but still ruffled her hair and she swatted at him. He put his hand at the small of her back, just above where the swoop of her backless dress met her skin, and gently pushed her toward the entrance.

His hand was warm, the light callouses scraping deliciously against her spine, and as she was propelled forward, into the close proximity of Vicky, she thought she felt his thumb slide over her skin in a caress.

But it was hard to tell because her mind was spinning. Too many thoughts and images were piling up, crashing into each other, and she wasn't able to tell them apart from each other. Was she thinking about something because she was afraid of it, or excited about it? Was this just curiosity, or something deeper?

Vicky's chest was at her eyeline, her impossibly round breasts straining against the strange fabric of her dress, and the inside of the house was disorienting: the air was somehow thick, faintly humid, a little warmer than outside, and the sounds of a completely normal party - clinking glass, people talking too loudly, music changing abruptly - could be heard inside.

"Oh hey," Vicky said, sliding her arm around Shiloh's back, above Joey's. She pulled Shiloh toward her, away from Joey, and toward an end table which was littered with ribbons. She selected a red one and took Shiloh's left hand, lifting it, then tied a red ribbon around it. "You'll want this," she said, smiling. "Unless you change your mind, in which case..." she produced some scissors from nowhere and cut at the air with them.

Shiloh, stunned, looked around for Joey with her mouth open. Her wrist was tingling with the sensation of the ribbon, the brush of Vicky's fingers over her skin as she tied it, and now, with the sentiment that the

ribbon itself brought to her: she was doing something naughty, and dangerous, and sexual, and this ribbon was a symbol of it.

Joey and the man were in what seemed like a deep discussion, and one that was most definitely about *her*, because they kept glancing in her direction. Shiloh felt some heat gathering at the back of her neck, so she looked back at the end table, where a variety of other colors of ribbon were clumped loosely in a basket.

"So, this red one is for... off limits?" she said to Vicky, who was already nodding and smiling. "What are the other colors for?"

Vicky picked up a roll of green ribbon, which also happened to be the color around her wrist. She fingered it lovingly. "Well," she said, her breath warm against Shiloh's ear and neck as she stepped in closer to her. "This one is easy: green is a go. For anything."

Shiloh couldn't help herself: her eyes snapped up to look at Vicky, whose eyes glinted mischievously in return. What did "anything" mean? Especially with a woman like Vicky, who did not seem to have the most minimal fear of wearing a ribbon that said "anything goes" at a party where... literally, it seemed, anything went?

Another throb of jittery excitement swelled in Shiloh's chest. It was more like the feeling she got at the top of a roller coaster.

But Vicky was moving on. "These blue ones are for girls who are looking for girls, and then yellow is..." Vicky turned to the man. "Hey, babe, what's yellow again?"

Joey smiled. "Only pussy," he said, without hesitation. He grinned at Shiloh, who was staring at him, a little shocked.

"Uh, okay," Shiloh said, trying to look unflappable. "And black?" She asked this quickly, to move along, choosing a random color from the remainder that Vicky hadn't described.

Vicky smiled, looking at Shiloh like she was an alien. "You really are brand-new, aren't you?" she asked, but kindly, putting an arm reassuringly on Shiloh's. Joey smiled, almost laughing a little. "That one's self-explanatory, *Cheyenne*."

Shiloh was, frustratingly, unable to think of anything self-explanatory about black ribbons, except as mourning. She didn't know much, but she was pretty sure that wasn't its purpose in these circumstances.

"It's for BBC," Vicky whispered helpfully in her ear.

It took Shiloh a second, and then her mouth fell open a little more - something that didn't seem possible. "Oh," she said, before she really landed on it. Then, "*Ooh*."

"Can I get you two lovely guests anything to drink?" the man interjected, as an obvious change of subject to make Shiloh more comfortable. She looked at him gratefully.

"No more drinks for this one, for at least half an hour," Joey said, reaching for Shiloh's hand and pulling her gently toward him as he moved further in to the house. "Come on, darlin.' Let's go exploring."

"I am gonna see you later, though, aren't I, Joey?" Vicky asked, her body turning with Joey as he slipped between them, pulling Shiloh along. Shiloh smiled and mumbled something about it being very nice to meet them, but Vicky was too caught up in giving Joey a predatory, searing stare, to respond to Shiloh. Joey, ever the man of mystery, gave Vicky a noncommittal shrug and a wicked smile.

Shiloh was seized by a puritanical impulse, welling up from deep inside, to close her eyes, as they moved into a living room area that was humming with people. But she didn't, and aside from one couple making out on a love seat with a man seated next to them, staring avidly and openly at what they were doing - it was basically a totally normal party.

Joey stopped in the middle of the landing, just before the three low-rise steps that led to the sunken living room. He stepped away from Shiloh and held up his phone. "Hold your wrist up, there, Cheyenne," he said, holding the phone like he planning to take a photo.

Shiloh looked back at him blankly.

"So Mike knows everything is on the up-and-up," he explained. He lowered the phone and stepped toward Shiloh, putting a hand on her bare arm. "Trust me, Shy. He's going to love this, you get it? You want to guarantee he won't be even *seeing* those strippers at that club?"

Shiloh didn't have an answer, so she held up her wrist. Joey stepped back, grinning at her prudish posture. "I mean, make it a little sexy, Shy-shy," he told her.

"I told you not to call me that," she retorted, making him grin even more and snap a picture. He held the phone and typed with one thumb. "That was perfect, Shy... Shy."

He laughed as she reached out to swat him, and looked up at her. "That's going to get him going, for now." He scanned the living room as he

put his phone in his pocket and then clapped his hand together before rubbing them. "So. Let's go mingle, what do you say?"

Shiloh turned slowly, to take in the scene in the living room.

"I can't believe I'm doing this," she whispered, leaning back a little so Joey could hear her. He put his hands on her shoulders, sending another very wrong, very tempting, very *naughty* shiver through her. And then he gently started to push her, so that she had no choice but to descend the steps.

CHAPTER 4

"... so the way I see it, there's no way around it. And everybody's going to need a lot of lawyers."

Rich Polis finished off a lengthy speech about his thoughts on crypto - which Mike had never asked for, and didn't, ever, as a rule - with flourish, before turning his head to take in the long limbs of the scantily clad dancer on the stage right next to them.

Mike did as well, but robotically. He had never been a stripclub guy, but he had learned to mimic one. It wasn't exactly optional in his business, because all roads led to the stripclub eventually. Most roads led to either extremely expensive stripclubs, or often to the cluster of predominantly black clubs, in which very frighteningly beautiful black women did very athletic things that terrified him more than turning him on.

Regardless, he wasn't especially interested in any of it, except at the most basic level.

He was a *man*, after all.

But tonight, not even the magnificent swells of "Crystal Bee's" undulating breasts, with chocolate-dark aureole the size of espresso saucers floating in a sea of creamy white flesh, could permeate his mind. If he looked up her skirt, like he was right now, he wasn't even seeing the tiny pink triangle of silk between her coltish legs.

All he could see now, and all he could think about now, was his wife. Somewhere back home, standing in a crowded living room, holding up her left arm, around which a red ribbon was tied. She was wearing one of his favorite dresses, a polka-dotted black summer dress, short and breezy, with a deep dip at the breasts. It tied in the back and sloped down low across the curve of her bottom, just where it began its small but satisfying curve out to her firm, round shape.

Her nostrils were flared in the photo, her mouth open, and her hands a little blurry as they moved forward - he presumed - to swat at Joey, who had taken the picture. She had her "annoyed-at-Joey" face on, eyes a little wild, teeth almost gritted, the nostrils of her tiny, doll-like nose flaring as much as they could, which wasn't very much, but noticeable to him.

He had stared at the picture for a long time, unable to process what was taking place back home. In his abdomen, cold terror clawed for space

next to intense arousal. The combination was making him feel sick to his stomach, but with an intense erection. He actually felt pretty terrible, he had to admit. Sweat was beading at his temples, and yet he was ice-cold. Rich - one of the most narcissistic, self-involved, unobservant people he had ever met in his life - had even asked him if he was okay.

"You had the tacos," Rich had concluded, without waiting for Mike's answer. "Man, you oughta know by now not to eat nothing they put out at a strip club."

"Yeah," Mike had said, mostly because he wasn't even listening to Rich at that point.

Which is what he said now, as they stared up at the stripper. No problem for Rich, who didn't listen to anything that anyone else said, anyway.

Was he the dog that caught the car? Mike wondered.

He'd been working on Shiloh for years now, trying to get her to come around to the idea of entertaining his fantasy.

And it was *his* fantasy, not hers. The distinction seemed important now, at this moment, when Shiloh was out in deep water for the first time, far away from him.

Shiloh, he knew, was under the impression that Mike's hotwifing fantasy had been generated because of Joey. There wasn't any reason, back in the beginning of their "game," to disabuse her of that impression. After all, Joey got blamed for almost anything that Mike did that Shiloh didn't like or understand, and Joey didn't mind playing that role. "Blame-it-on-me," was Joey's middle name.

But the truth was that Mike had *always* fantasized about his steady girlfriends, and then his wife, having sex with other men. He imagined watching them, he imagined the burn of the jealous pain it would cause, and then the way that pain would rush into his cock, swelling until it was excruciating, bruising his insides and splitting him open.

He just never dared to act on his desires.

For one thing, until he had discovered Joey's predilection for it, Mike had always found this fantasy to be a source of intense shame. What kind of weak man wanted to watch other men paw at his girlfriend? And what would a woman say if he told her about it? If he envisioned conversations with his girlfriends about his desires, the imagined conversations always

ended in the same, brutal, humiliating way: they laughed or called him a cuck, rejected the idea, and broke up with him.

And then he found Shiloh.

He knew, the first day that he met her, that she was a queen, and he was destined to be her servant. Shiloh was one of those women with sculpted, perfect features, arranged so tidily on her face that she almost - almost - looked saccharine. This organized face, leaning always in the direction of an uptight scowl, was framed by a head of shiny, wavy, every-so-unruly hair.

It was that hair - dark, contrasting with her otherwise fair coloring; impossible to tame completely, unlike her very prim and proper face and meticulous habits; uncommitted to any real degree of waviness, sometimes straight, sometimes doll-ringlet curly, sometimes uncooperatively mixed, but always beautiful - that gave Shiloh her ultimate power. Like her personality, her appearance was *almost* perfect; like her hair, she had a messy and disorderly side to her, but one that always complemented as opposed to detracting. The hair held the same promises as her personality. Coloring just outside of the lines. Some untameable "something" inside of her that just might, one day, become too wild.

Shiloh was also smart, and witty, and for whatever reason, she had professed to be in love with him. So the last thing he thought he would ever do was dredge up a fantasy that would make him look like a weirdo to her, or a weak man. Not worth the risk.

And risk management was Mike's game.

*

It had come as a surprise to him when his buddy Joey, who Mike thought of as the most alpha, alpha male he knew (a designation that Mike had since revised, with the help of the internet, to "sigma male," because Joey really was more of a lone wolf than anything) had showed up at a party with a girlfriend, named Tyra, who had spent the entire evening throwing herself at other men.

Just literally pawing at them and cozying up with them, then making out with a basketball player.

And Joey's reaction? He just stood there drinking beer and lining himself up so he could watch her.

Mike had tried, unhelpfully, to place himself in Joey's line of sight, in an attempt to distract him. It was a work-related party, with a lot of his firm's clients there, and while Joey was there as someone else's guest, not Mike's, Mike had still felt compelled to prevent any kind of fight from breaking out.

Risk management. It would look bad for everyone, and probably cause An Incident.

But finally, Joey had reached out while Mike was talking, trying to distract him, and gently... pushed him to the side. "Man, you are *killing* my vibe," he had said.

So Mike had moved, and Joey had watched, and then Tyra had disappeared with the basketball player.

"Uh," Mike had said, after Tyra left the room and Joey had turned around to start snarfing up shrimp from the catering table behind him. "You, uh... yo, man, what's the deal with that?"

Joey had dangled a shrimp over his open mouth, grinning, and then gobbled it, and started rooting around for something else before answering. "Tyra, you mean?" he had asked casually. Then he had turned around again, grinning, and nudged Mike with his elbow, sharing a conspiratorial smile before sipping his beer.

"Uh...?" Mike had said, when Joey said no more about the subject, and enough time had passed that it was clear he wasn't going to.

Not because Joey was an asshole, which is what most people thought when he did shit like that. They had been friends since childhood, and Mike knew that Joey just honestly believed that every man was like him. Joey assumed that every guy could make every woman's panties melt just by looking at them, because that was something Joey had been able to do for his entire adult life, and possibly even before he hit puberty. Joey didn't explain things to people, ever, because he assumed all people knew as much about everything as he did. He also didn't apologize for anything, because he assumed all people, like him, didn't give a shit about anything, anyway.

Joey was the kind of guy who handed loaded assault rifles to people he had never met and told them to "have fun" shooting at targets, because Joey knew how to disassemble, repair, reassemble, clean, hold, operate, and "have fun" with assault rifles, and if he was at a party with targets and assault rifles, he would love it if someone handed him one and told him to have fun. (Fortunately for untold numbers of people, Joey also knew how to

quickly identify that someone *didn't* know what to do with an assault rifle, and how to retrieve it from said person before manslaughter took place *and* how to do so without ruffling any feathers).

Which is why, when Mike said "uh?" in need of more clarification, Joey gave his head a shake, the way he did whenever he realized that he had done something similar to handing an assault rifle to an idiot who had never held a gun in his life. "Oh, yeah, man... no, it's cool. It's like, a thing."

"A thing?" Mike had asked, a little breathlessly.

"Yeah," Joey had said, casually shoving shrimp into his mouth. "You know. Like, hotwifing. Only that chick..." Joey had turned to snag another shrimp. "Fuck these are good, like they just jumped out of the fucking ocean."

Mike was still staring at him, waiting for more info.

"That chick is *not* somebody you marry," Joey said, after chewing up his shrimp.

"Because she gets with other guys?"

Joey did a double take. "Nah, man... that's... no. You don't marry a chick like Tyra because she is fucking *insane*." He laughed, and then, seeing that Mike was still struggling with what he was talking about, he offered him a shrimp.

Mike shook his head.

"Don't tell me you ain't into something like that," Joey had said.

"Is it like... an open relationship?"

That made sense. That was very Joey.

Joey had shrugged. "Yeah, okay."

"Not? It's not?" Mike had asked.

He could feel something almost bursting inside of him. It was all fairly obvious where Joey was headed, and he had even said the word "hotwife," so things were relatively spelled out for Mike. He just couldn't believe that *Joey* - of all people - shared a fantasy that Mike had kept buried for so long on the basis of it making him feel like a weak man.

Because if there was any one word, in all the English vocabulary, that was *not* a candidate for describing Joey, "weak" was it.

"Look," Joey had said, putting a hand on Mike's shoulder. "I really, really *like* watching my girlfriend get all kinds of fucking nasty with some random dude."

Mike's eyes had widened, which was like cocaine to an addict of psychological warfare like Joey.

"Try it on for size, Mikey," Joey had said. He had leaned in close. "Just picture Shiloh, her lips sealed up around some huge black cock, taking it in the ass from some other guy, just getting banged all ways upside down and sideways, like really, thoroughly fucked, you know?" Joey shook his head and sipped his beer. "It's hot as fuck." Then he had smiled. "Yeah. Fuck. That's getting me fucking hard for all the wrong reasons." Then he had grinned at the stupefied Mike. "I promise not to picture your wife like that ever again, man. But *damn*."

So that had been revelatory. Mike hadn't pried any further that night, mainly because Joey had received a text, pocketed his phone, grabbed a few shrimp on a napkin, and headed off in the direction that his then-girlfriend had disappeared recently, saying "Duty calls."

Dry mouth. Closed throat. Racing heart.

Try it on for size, man. Shiloh, her lips sealed up around some huge black cock...

"What is *up* with that?"

Shiloh had appeared, the same half-finished champagne glass she had been wandering around with all night still held aloft in her slender hand. She had worn a gray suit-dress to the party, the kind that worked in the office and then "transformed" into an anodyne sheath when the blazer was removed. A super-thin black belt marked her waistline. Most people at the party mistook her for an agent or a lawyer, which was completely fine by Shiloh.

"You mean Joey and the shrimp?" Mike had asked. "He's a pig, for sure."

Shiloh had laughed at this, but then leaned in, covering one side of her mouth pointlessly, a habit she had that always tickled Mike. "I think I saw his girlfriend making out with some other guy. And he was looking right at her. And that's where he just went."

Then, Shiloh had gotten wide, alarmed eyes, and put her hand out on Mike's arm. "You don't think he's going to go kick that guy's ass?" she had asked. "Fuck."

There was some backstory to this: Joey, by way of being Joey, often did things that alarmed and deeply irritated Shiloh. The gun-sharing was one such example, but saying inappropriate things or starting fights were on

the list as well. Her alarm came from a very believable place, and from concern about the fact that they were at a party with Mike's clients and colleagues, and neither of them even knew why or how Joey had been invited, and Joey making a scene would be a bad thing.

She was setting her champagne glass down, and if she'd had sleeves, she would have rolled them up. That was Shiloh for you: in it with you, all the way. This was another thing about her that Mike loved, and couldn't risk losing, not for anything: Shiloh took the concept of "team" in modern marriage about as seriously as anyone could take it.

She was the kind who would be very ticked off about the murder, what with all the rules it broke, but would nonetheless definitely help you bury a body.

Properly.

"Honey," Mike had said, putting his hand on her arm.

"We have to go *stop him*," Shiloh had complained, looking nervously behind her. "You can't have this here -"

"Sweetie, no, look," Mike had turned her around and pulled her into a secluded corner. "Look," he had said. "It's not like that, okay? It's, uh... he and Tyra have an arrangement."

Shiloh had given him a look, one that he broadly interpreted to mean, "'the fuck you say?'"

"An arrangement?"

Mike had shrugged, deploying his, "you-know-Joey" face.

"What does that *mean*?" Shiloh had asked. A note of mild hysteria had entered her voice. It was never far off when Joey was around, probably because they had yet to spend an evening or any other amount of time with Joey during which he didn't do anything that made Shiloh uncomfortable. Joey was way, way too messy and uncontrollable for even the most rogue subtexts of Shiloh's hair.

But Mike was no dummy, and he detected in Shiloh the same thing he detected in all women and all men with regards to Joey: he had her under a certain spell. If Joey did something, no matter how much it vexed her, it was *cool*, and manly. She could talk a lot of trash about Joey, for sure, but even Shiloh admitted that he was a man's man.

A door, he realized, had opened for him. A golden opportunity, to get a read on his fantasy from Shiloh's perspective... maybe even to *talk* about it, admit some sympathy for it, feel out the waters with her. And all could be

done under the guise of just explaining *Joey*. It also came with the bonus of having Joey's manly-stamp all over it.

"Joey's into it," he said, watching her face intently. "He likes, uh, watching her."

Shiloh's orderly, breathtaking features remained entirely composed, except for her mouth, which went slack with utter shock, or confusion, or both.

"As in having *sex*?"

She had begun the question very loudly, but ended in a whisper-scream, which Mike was grateful for. He pushed his hands, palms-down, down toward the ground anyway, to quiet her, which only made her smack him gently on the shoulder, mouth hanging open. "*Seriously?*"

Mike had nodded, still watching Shiloh, the movement of her eyes, guessing at the glimmers in them, what they revealed about her thoughts.

It was a mystery, though, as she stood there processing what he had said. A mystery what she thought, and a mystery what it was making her feel. When she finally scoffed loudly and picked up her champagne, she muttered, "That's like, *disgusting*."

But she hadn't sounded especially convincing in her condemnation. Which, if you knew Shiloh - and Mike did - was usually more than convincing if Shiloh *actually* thought something was "disgusting."

"I mean, it seems like everyone is on-board with it," Mike had ventured.

Because another thing Shiloh was fond of saying was that whatever consenting adults did in their own bedrooms was none of anyone else's business.

Shiloh had pondered this for a moment, and Mike waited. It had seemed like the subject would just dissipate, and not be spoken of again, and he was actually feeling a little relieved that it had come up then, the way that it had, so that he could see what Shiloh's reaction was without running any risks.

"So," Shiloh had said, after finishing off her champagne - unusual for her - "I don't get this. *She* goes and has sex with *another man* and *he* watches?"

"I guess so," Mike said.

Shiloh had screwed up her face. "*Why?*"

Mike had looked back at her silently for a good long stare. Why did anyone do anything related to sex?

"He gets off on it?" she had asked, incredulously. And then she had reflected on it again.

"Why?"

Why, indeed, Shiloh? Mike would have loved to know the answer to that question.

"You know what, never mind," Shiloh had said, laughing, holding up a hand. "I don't need any more details than that. Forget I asked."

Shiloh did not like "too many details" about Joey.

She had hurried over to a wandering caterer at that moment, to get herself another glass of champagne. She brought one back for Mike and set it on the table for him, and then stood with him observing the party.

"I'm sorry, I just can't stop *thinking* about it," she had said, suddenly, turning to Mike. Her face had a giddy quality to it, her eyes gleaming with interest. "Like, she is in there right now with that guy, and he's in there, too?"

"Guess so," Mike had said.

"Just, like... what? Sitting? Just watching?"

Mike had shrugged.

"Well, does he have sex with her, too? Or what?" She had noticed then that Mike seemed uncomfortable and put her hand on his face, smiling. "I'm sorry, I'm sorry, I just *can't*... understand it. Like, what are they *doing*?" She had returned her gaze to the party, shaking her head. "It's weird," she had said, after a long pause.

"You're always saying how everybody's sexual preferences are weird to anyone else," Mike countered.

"No, not even *that*... I mean, it's weird, but... no. What's *weird* is that it's *Joey*. Right? Like he seems so..." she had curled her hands and held her arms out to mimic a gorilla, "huh, huh, I big tough guy, raaar..." She had almost spilled her champagne, and took another - large - sip, after finishing her rant. She shook her head again, a little smile on her lips. "Isn't that, like... doesn't that make him a cuck?"

Mike had shrugged.

"Joey *hates* cucks."

Mike wasn't exactly sure why Shiloh said this with such a haughty, all-knowing tone. There was a degree of familiarity implicit in that dictum,

like Shiloh knew Joey much better than it was possible for her to. On the one hand, it buoyed Mike's spirits, because Joey was a good, good friend, and Shiloh's outward dislike for Joey always unsettled him.

On the other hand, the knife had a serrated edge on the other side: Shiloh seemed to have some kind of friendly complicity going on with Joey, the way she was talking about him.

"I think it's not exactly like that," Mike had offered, seeing a small, but potential-laden, opening.

"Uh... his girlfriend is sleeping with some other dude right under his nose. I thought that was the *definition* of cuckold." Shiloh pinched her pointer and thumb together to say "*the definition*."

"Actually," Mike had said, adopting a voice that Shiloh called "professorial," and detested but also loved detesting. "It's a bit more nuanced than that."

She had laughed at the voice, which was a good sign. "Oh, it is, is it?" she had asked, turning toward him. "*Do* go on, Professor Bell."

"Joey is into something called 'hotwifing,' my dear Miss Krupp," he had begun, using her maiden name as they often did when they joked like this. "This is distinct from 'cuckolding,' in the sense that the man in a 'hotwifing' relationship is complicit in, and indeed participates, in the securing of eligible men for the woman."

"And a cuckold, Professor Bell?" Shiloh had adopted a voice that she used to make fun of Mike when he got, as she put it, "a little full of himself," but the joke was largely on her because Mike actually enjoyed the supplicating, wonderment-filled tone, even if it was sarcastic.

What could he say? He was a man, after all.

"A cuckold, my dear Miss Krupp, is not complicit in anything."

"He's just getting cuckolded," Shiloh had finished. And then they had laughed together, Mike with a bit of a nervous twist brewing in his gut. "Okay, okay," Shiloh had said, moving her head back and forth rapidly, a gesture she was unaware of making but employed whenever she wanted to indicate that she was "cool" with something. "Well, *that* makes more sense. I guess."

"Really?"

"I mean, yeah... like, I just couldn't picture *Joey*, you know. Getting *cuckled*. But if this is his thing, then... you know. Whatever." She had turned

to him then and kissed him on the cheek. "I'm just relieved he's not going to make a scene. Hopefully."

And then someone had come over to talk to Mike, and Shiloh had lingered, sipping her champagne, finishing off a second glass and then picking the one she had brought for him up discretely and downing about half of it while Mike talked.

When the conversations ended, and they were left alone again, Shiloh - who by now was pretty tipsy - had leaned against Mike's shoulder and nudged him, a hint of mischief in her eyes.

With Shiloh, mischief was what you got after two drinks, in much the same way that you got a sexy surprise out of her hair after a certain threshold of humidity.

"Hold this," she said, putting the champagne in his hand. "I have to go to the loo. It's that way, right?" She extended her arm and turned it in the direction that Joey had disappeared down the hallway.

Two critical pieces of information battled for attention in Mike's head: one, that Shiloh was drunk and getting up to mischief, and the other, that Shiloh knew there was a bathroom in the opposite direction, because she had used it when they first arrived.

Her eyes glinting, she slid away, in the direction of the corridor - which almost certainly had another bathroom, because the loft they were in was of the enormous, luxury variety.

"Shiloh," Mike had protested, in the lowest voice that he could.

But she had slipped away, looking back at him with an unusual smile on her lips.

*

Back in the present moment, at a stripclub with nothing but his thoughts and his phone, which he was clutching in his hand so that he could not possibly fail to feel it vibrate if it did, Mike stared emptily into the miasma of glitter, flesh, colored lights, and chipped black paint, seeing none of it.

Just picture Shiloh, her lips sealed up around some huge black cock, taking it in the ass from some other guy, just getting banged all ways upside down and sideways, like really, thoroughly fucked, you know?

Joey's words from that party - years ago, now - had never left Mike's mind. They were seared into his auditory cortex, always ready to rise from his subconscious and echo loudly inside his head. Like the image of Shiloh, polka-dotted dress framing her taut breasts, a red ribbon tied around her wrist.

He checked his phone again. Each time that he tipped the screen it felt like flinging his heart out into a volcano. What did he want? A message from Shiloh? A message from Joey? For Shiloh to lose her sense of decorum and jump in the sack with some guy?

Or - his heart pitched and then fell to the ground, deep into the lava pit - with Joey?

He collected his thoughts. Joey wasn't about to do anything like that, no matter what Shiloh did.

No matter what Shiloh did.

Well, sure: if Shiloh threw herself at Joey, stripping down to her magnificent naked glory and begging him to let her fuck him, of course Joey's code of honor would go out the window.

But Shiloh wasn't going to do *that*.

There were no messages, though, and so there was no way of knowing what was happening at Joey's "party." Mike couldn't even define for himself what he hoped would happen there. It was, like the incident at that long-ago party where Joey had disappeared with his girlfriend, a fluke of fate, an opportunity - but like all opportunities, it carried steep risks.

Panic - an old friend, one he had learned to control - swelled inside of him, where it always did. A cool, slimy lump midway between his Adam's apple and his diaphragm. Like a snake, it wound itself around his lungs, squeezing until his breath felt cut off, and his pulse thumped in his ears.

It was always temporary.

Life was full of risk.

The panic receded, and Chris started shouting at him over the music. Something else about crypto, which Mike had on good authority had been Chris's pet hobby, and was now his pet peeve, because he had lost his ass in the Terra meltdown.

"... just operates on fucking *faith*, man. That's what people don't understand about it. And the thing about that is, then it just turns into whatever everybody believes about it, you know? So, it's like, dude, we all just lost so much fucking money, and it's just because everybody lost *faith*."

It's like... you made this happen, douchebags. Just by thinking about it the wrong way. You know? And then just... *poof*. everything is gone."

CHAPTER 5

Babe. Please. I'm dying here.

Shiloh was seated on a couch in a second living room in the cavernous party house, her hand lying limply to her side with her phone face-up in her palm. Mike had sent the text to her about five minutes ago, and she wanted desperately to write back to him, but she was in a situation that she didn't know what to do about.

Shiloh was big on etiquette: following it, to a "t," and always doing the most polite thing. Her mother, a Southern Belle in the most literal sense of the phrase, had instilled a profound terror in her about violating social norms.

But what did one do, she wondered helplessly, when they were seated on a couch in a living room, watching a woman give blow jobs to two guys at the same time, but received a text message from your husband, who only (fairly) wanted to know what was going on, because you were at a wild sex party with his good friend?

Shiloh was frozen, her limbs cold. The paralysis didn't stem from some deep sense of horror at what she was seeing, but rather from a colder, darker horror - one targeted at *herself*. What was *she* doing here? She was trying to replay the events that had led to her sitting on this couch, from the afternoon forward, and she couldn't make sense of herself, and her decisions.

She could make even less sense of the feelings she was experiencing as she sat there, cold to the point of paralysis, but with a wild fire blazing in the center of her legs.

Vicky was the woman on her knees, her dress still on, each hand wrapped around a sizable cock, moving from one dick to the other with her mouth. Between sucking each guy off, she released her previous... man... with a wet pop and a smile. Saliva ran down her chin, and her mascara had started to smudge. She looked like a spectacularly filthy porn star, truly into it, like she was having the time of her life.

All around the house, there were similar things going on to this scene. At first, Shiloh had thought she would be wildly uncomfortable, and she had wanted to flee. This was a totally, completely, wildly inappropriate

place for a married woman to be, with her husband's friend, no less, and not even her husband.

But the red ribbon, startlingly enough, seemed to be universally respected. It had given Shiloh a strange kind of pass, almost like she was a ghost. It was an odd feeling, because Shiloh was the kind of attractive woman that men at least usually *attempted* to chat up, and here, at a party where people were openly having sex - it was, in fact, the whole point of the party - guys took one look at her ribbon and moved on after a quick smile.

She had clung to Joey at first - an equally strange situation to be in - following him around as he found them some drinks (and, she had noticed, prepared hers with just a drop of alcohol). They had wandered around the house, experiencing a mostly-"normal" party with a profound sexual energy.

But things had started rolling since then. After stumbling onto an orgy in the making on the back deck, where a hot tub was piled high with naked men and women, she had opted to wander away a little from Joey. And then a little bit more. Watered-down drink in hand, she had started walking slowly down the hallways, into the various rooms where people were pairing up (or clustering up). Some groups made out right where they were standing, and some disappeared, giggling, behind doors that Shiloh was pretty sure weren't locked.

And then her attention had been captured by the scene she was witnessing. She had stood in the doorway, transfixed, to watch Vicky float through the room and then stick to the pair of guys she was now servicing.

Joey had startled her when he came up behind her and put a hand on her shoulder.

"Whoa," he said. "Just me." He had surveyed the scene in the second living room, watching Vicky as she let one of the guys slip the shoestring straps of her dress down her shoulder and started kissing her neck while Vicky looked searingly at the other guy. Shiloh sneaked a glance at Joey's face: the calm, assured, satisfaction on it. He sipped a drink and then turned to Shiloh, who had looked quickly back at Vicky, so as not to appear to be staring at Joey.

"You all good here?" he asked her, producing another drink from somewhere and replacing the one in her hand with it, without asking or saying anything about it. "That's pretty light, too, slugger," he told her.

"Are you sure it's... cool... for me to just be here, you know?" She held up her wrist. "And this is like, solid, right?"

"Why? Has somebody been bugging you?" Joey was suddenly very serious-sounding, especially for him.

"Uh, no -"

"Good. Because that is a *no-go*. Like, you permanently get the boot for the kind of shit. So just tell me if anything like that happens."

"Yeah, okay... it hasn't, it's just that... like, for real, is it, I don't know... kosher?"

Joey grinned. "Kosher. I love it. Look, Shy, everything is 'kosher' here. There're like three or four guys with red ribbons on. It's your prerogative."

Shiloh blinked slowly.

"So, you good here?" Joey said, turning slightly to the left and looking over the top of his glass. Shiloh followed his gaze to a pretty blond in a red dress that looked more like a nightie than anything else. She was leaning against a wall, her long legs crossed at the ankle, nipples erect beneath the see-through red top, a belly-button ring gleaming in her navel. She was talking to a black man, who was drawing a finger lazily down her left arm while she smiled seductively at him.

But her eyes moved to meet Joey's, just for one moment. The two exchanged a look that seemed to warp the air, and her lips curled in a sultry grin.

The black man had reached her wrist, and was fingering two ribbons - one black, one purple - and he was sliding them between his fingers so sexually and with such intent, that they could have been the wet lips of her pussy. She turned her attention back to the black man, but the smile remained on her lips, and Shiloh knew as much as Joey did that the grin was partly for him.

Shiloh's mouth fell open a little. She glanced at Joey's face as he turned toward her again.

"She has a black ribbon, though," Shiloh said, genuinely confused.

"*And* purple," Joey said, grinning. He tossed back the remainder of his drink and set the glass on a table next to them.

Shiloh pressed him for more clarification by shaking her head a little, with her eyebrows raised.

"Ahhh," Joey said, after swallowing the last of his drink. "BBC only, and only *anal*," he told Shiloh, as though confiding with a guy friend. He rubbed his hands together. "Joey's going to go watch some dirty, dirty filth." He looked over at Shiloh. "You can join me, if you want."

Shiloh dropped her eyes to Joey's wrist, which had no ribbon on it. "So wait, what're you?" she asked.

"Freelancer," Joey said, grinning.

The blond gave Joey another look and jerked her head a little to the left, as the black man pulled her toward the corridor.

"Duty calls, code-name-Cheyenne," Joey told her. "You coming?"

Shiloh hesitated. The blond and the black man were disappearing down a hallway, the black man's hand on her ass as she strolled ahead of him.

Anal sex? Only? With a black guy?

In truth, she felt pulled to go with Joey and watch that, but as soon as she thought about the impropriety of sitting in a room, watching live, hardcore porn with her husband's good friend, she gave her head a slight shake.

"Suit yourself... you good here, then?"

Shiloh nodded.

"You gonna stay out of trouble?"

Shiloh laughed at that. It was an unexpected, sharp laugh, and it caught the attention of a few people around them. Her cheeks grew red and she put her hand to her mouth, nodding at Joey.

"*Promise*?" Joey asked. "I'm not going to come out here and find you acting like a little slut, am I?" There was an insinuation in his voice that felt like a rake against the inside of Shiloh's chest. She couldn't tell how much of a joke was in the mixture of Joey's question, and what portion of it was suggestive. She swallowed, and her throat had a lump in it.

"God, Joey," she said, rolling her eyes. Without much conviction. They settled steadfastly on Vicky, who at that point had half her dress rolled down, baring her bountiful, fleshy breasts and their dark, enormous aureole with her long nipples erect in their milk-chocolate centers. Her mouth was open in a wide, smiling expression of pleasure as one of the guys cupped her breast and brought his mouth to her nipple to suck on it, while the other ran his fingers through her long hair, tips caressing the bare skin of her back through her princess-like tresses.

"Text me if you have any trouble," Joey told her. Then he raised his eyebrows hopefully. "Or just come along?"

"I'm good here," Shiloh said, tossing her hair defiantly. Joey grinned and left her, and it burned a little as he walked away without looking back. She didn't have a *thing* for Joey, she told herself, as she stepped, a little unsettled, toward the couch. So why did she care if he went off to watch another woman take it up the ass with some huge black guy? And was he really just going to sit there and watch?

And then what? she wondered.

Her own panties were already soaked, her juices escaping her panties and making her inner thighs slick as she slinked toward the couch. No one else was sitting on it, and she felt suddenly unsteady on her feet.

So she sat, and she watched, and no one bothered to talk to her, and it was strange. She was thinking, if she was honest with herself, more about Joey and what he was doing, than she was about the scene right in front of her. She stared at Vicky - at her calm, assured sluttiness - and felt a pang of emotion that she couldn't identify. It felt like envy, but surely that couldn't be it?

And then she had received the text from Mike, the one that burned now in her hand, ten minutes after he had sent it. The man on Vicky's right side was clutching her hair, groaning, pushing her further onto his cock. "Oh, baby, fuck... yeah, all the way... I'm gonna come, fuck keep sucking, don't stop..."

Shiloh stared, transfixed, as the man's abdomen bunched up and his muscles strained, his head tipping back as he groaned. He looked down at Vicky and pushed her head into his crotch. "You're gonna swallow it all, yeah, keep going, oh fuck..." his words were consumed by a rambling set of incoherent noises, his head tipped forward and he met Vicky's eyes as he came, shouting to punctuate each spurt of come that Vicky was dutifully swallowing while looking up at him. Her hand was still gripping the other cock, moving rhythmically, as if it were a separate task performed by a different person. She didn't miss a beat.

She released the first man, her tongue sweeping under his cock as she let it slide from her mouth. And then she moved on to the other guy, grasping his buttocks with both hands. She disappeared from Shiloh's view as the man turned toward her and held her head, so all Shiloh could see was

Vicky's fingernails digging into his buttocks and his back muscles and ass clenching as he came, yelling at the ceiling.

When she was done, Vicky sat back on her heeled feet, smiling, and seductively pulled her dress up. Then she rose to her feet and smiled at her two companions. One of them reached for her face, a finger out to wipe up a glob of cum that had splashed onto her cheek.

Shiloh stared as Vicky shook her head and waved him away, and then put her hands up to both men's chests. She kissed each of them on the cheek, smiling, and stepped between them as they parted for her.

It was only then that Shiloh noticed, that among all the people scattered in the living room with her - some of whom were watching that scene, and many who were not - was the tall blond man who had answered the door. He was seated on a brick mantle in the far corner, behind the couch a little, so Shiloh hadn't seen or noticed him.

Vicky walked over to him, cat-like, and he put his hands behind her knees, pulling her in to him. She climbed onto his lap, her dress riding up high on her hips and revealing that she had no underwear on.

Vicky stared at his face: the utter, abject obsession with which he looked at Vicky. His eyes were locked on her with such an irrevocable passion that it was jarring; the house could have blown up all around them and Shiloh could see that he wouldn't have noticed.

He brought his thumb to her cheek, cradling her jaw in his palm, and swept the glob of cum into her mouth. Vicky sucked it off, slowly and deliberately.

And then he stood up, lifting Vicky with him, and they locked lips and began to move toward the couch.

It took Shiloh a second to process that they were headed toward where she was, and a moment longer to recognize that their weight had plunked onto the couch, over the armrest. Vicky's hair fell across Shiloh's lap as she fell onto the couch, and she looked up at Shiloh's shocked face, and grinned. "Oh, hey, Cheyenne," she said, bringing a finger to her mouth, biting the knuckle playfully. "You change your mind, doll?"

The blond man was grinning widely - maybe even hopefully - as he unzipped his pants. His shirt was open, his boxers sliding down, sprigs of pubic hair showing, now his cock was loose. It sprang from the boxers and pointed out, blunt, erect, wet at the tip with precum.

"I, uh..." Shiloh strained her abdominal muscles to lean forward and remove herself from the couch, which was very deep and very comfortable. She smiled widely, laughing a little. "Nope, no, still just... observing..."

She felt Vicky's hand on her leg. It wasn't an aggressive move, just a feathery touch along the backside of her knee. It sent an electrical charge through her. "You can observe right here, lovely," Vicky purred. But her hand fell away, and her body slid forward on the couch as the blond grabbed her ankles and pulled her toward him, the center of her legs lined up with his dick.

Vicky's attention went to him, and so Shiloh was mostly talking - awkwardly - to herself as she headed, on unsteady feet, out of the room.

She was still clutching her phone, which was a relief. But she didn't have any idea which way to go, or where to put herself to write back to Mike. Or - and this was crucial - what to say to him.

What to *write* to him.

She found a corner in a den area with a bar that, surprisingly, no one was using. She wedged herself into a corner between the bar and the far wall, on a stool, crossed her legs, and tried to act natural as she stared at the phone in her hand.

Babe. Please. I'm dying here.

Subconsciously, she brought her thumb to her mouth and started gnawing on the nail, but when she realized what she was doing, she snatched her thumb impatiently from her teeth and groaned. It was a bad habit, one she had a lot of trouble breaking, mostly because she wasn't even aware when she was doing it.

The party was a little bit tamer where she had installed herself. The den was on the way to the hallway that Joey had disappeared into, off to her left. She was pretty sure she knew what room he was in, and something throbbed inside of her, willing her to go and sneak into the room, just to see. Her pussy ached. She had never wanted to masturbate in her life as much as she did right now, and she had never felt, like she did at that moment, like she was in danger of making a terrible mistake with someone.

She looked at Mike's text, wanting desperately to think of something to write back to him.

She felt mildly guilty, but the worst kind of guilt, because she couldn't reconcile her guilty feeling with anything she'd actually done. She went over the evening in her head, again and again: she was just watching, Mike knew she was here, Mike knew she was with Joey, Mike *wanted* her to be here.

She started to type.

I just watched this girl Vicky give -

"Hey, can I ask you, what are you?" A female voice. Shiloh looked up, surprised enough that she jumped a little. A voluptuous brunette, quite young, with doe-like eyes and a childish, round face, was sitting down at the bar next to her. She had a green bracelet on, and her hair was roughly mussed in the back. She smelled like sex and a too-sweet deodorant, giving her a raunchy air of freshness and filth. "Are you one of those cuckqueens?"

Shiloh stared at her uncomprehendingly.

"I saw your husband, or boyfriend, or whatever, go off that way," she said. Her eyes got big and curious. "I've never met a cuckqueen before."

Shiloh blinked slowly. She held up her wrist. "I'm not, uh... I'm just... this is my first party," she blathered.

"Oh!" the girl said. She shot out a hand and put it on Shiloh's knee in a friendly way. "Sorry. I didn't get that vibe off of you."

"I don't even know what a cuck... queen? Is..." Shiloh confided.

The girl brought a vape to her lips and took an extensive drag. The scent leaving it had the skanky, spruce-tinged smell of pot. Her voice was husky when she replied, stifling a cough, "I don't really *get it*," she said, "but they're like, the opposite of a hotwife." She watched her cloud of marijuana vape dissipate and tipped the pen toward Shiloh, offering it to her. "I've never actually met one."

Shiloh looked at the pen. It was tempting, but she didn't need her mind any less clear than it already was. "Thanks," she said, shaking her head.

The girl leaned in toward her, the pen clutched in her hand next to her ear. "I'm not supposed to be smoking," she said, giggling. She fiddled with her pen, and, taking another drag, focused on Shiloh again. "So is he your husband, or what?" she said, in a hoarse cloud of smoke. She handed the

vape to Shiloh anyway, and because she did it so naturally, Shiloh took it in her hand with no intention of smoking it. "I just ask because he's *hot*."

"Oh, God," Shiloh said, ruffled. "Joey? No. No. No, he's... a friend of the... my *husband's* friend." Shiloh was still shaking her head, holding the vape, looking at it and wondering if she shouldn't be sneaky and take a drag off it.

The girl seemed delighted with this answer. "Nice," she said. She sounded like a stoner now, her young voice rising and falling, *niiiiii-iiice*. Her eyes lit up. "Does he have a huge dick?" she asked, excitedly.

Shiloh squirmed a little in her seat. "Oh, no," she said, hastily. "No, it's not like that... Joey and me, we don't..." she waved her hands almost frantically. What did she care if this girl had the wrong impression of her and Joey, anyway, she wondered?

The girl was looking more and more perplexed, and disappointed. Shiloh brought the vape to her lips and took a little hit, then coughed and handed it back to the girl. "He does," she said, her mouth twisted into a funny shape to choke back a cough, "have a big dick, though. At least I think so."

"Yeah," she answered, starry-eyed, taking the vape absent-mindedly. Then she seemed to emerge from a lull in her mind, gaining clarity. "But, like... I don't get it, then. Like, you guys are just *friends*, but you come to parties like this together?" Her hand flew to her mouth and she laughed. "Oh! Oh, gosh, wait a minute, is he *gay* or something?" She looked distractedly at a corner of the ceiling. "I didn't think they did that here," she murmured.

"Oh...no... he's *not*," Shiloh shook her head quickly and looked at her drink.

The girl looked at Shiloh in disbelief. "So... what's, like, *wrong* with him?"

Shiloh balanced an upper incisor over a lower one and pulled her lips apart to make a face that meant, broadly, she didn't know and it was awkward. "It's a long story," she finally said.

"Oh," the girl said. "Cool." She vaped again. "So you're cool if I like... go find him?" She tucked a hand between her tucked legs and twirled an ankle happily. "Do you *watch* him?"

Shiloh shook her head vigorously. "Uh... no. Yeah, no, that would be... that wouldn't be... something I, uh, we... are not into that."

The girl seemed deeply unsatisfied with *this* answer but seemed to judge herself unable to sort it out. "Okay," she said uncertainly. She slid from her stool and smiled, tugging on her skimpy dress. "Well, it was nice to meet you...?"

"Cheyenne," Shiloh said, abruptly.

"Cheyenne." She turned and started to wander off, but looked back. "I'm Christa," she said, and waved as she walked away, turning at the corridor, headed in the direction that Joey had disappeared.

Shiloh stared after her, and then scanned the scene around her. She had a deep desire to follow Christa, to see where she went, if she found Joey, to spy on what he was doing, wherever he was.

But that was wrong, wasn't it?

It was somehow over the line.

She pulled her phone out and stared at her half-completed message. She set it on the bar and looked at the liquor, then back to the screen.

Lazily, with one hand, she started to type again.

CHAPTER 6

It was getting crowded at the club, nearing two am, and the patrons were arriving drunker and rowdier than before. Mike's clients were long gone into a bubble of debauchery, which liberated him, for the most part, from having to pretend that he was listening to them or looking at the girls on stage. They *did* notice, occasionally, and slap him on the back yelling things like, "whatcha doin', streaming porn?" or something like that, but it was obvious to Mike that they were intoxicated enough to wake up in the morning with only a vague impression of what had happened the night before. It would be a medley of naked women, shrill laughter, too many shots, and somewhere in the periphery of their memories, Mike engrossed in his phone for whatever reason.

I just watched this girl Vicky give a blow job to two guys

He had been waiting, feeling tortured, for more than an hour, for a message from Shiloh.

When he had received it, it had hit him in the face like a ton of bricks. Stunned, he had stared at his screen, the phone clutched in both hands, his jaw slack. Chris had leaned over to see what he was looking at, but evidently hadn't been able to read the message. "Texting?" he shrieked. "Hey man, you got a booty call already here?" He shook his head. "Jesus, man."

"It's my wife," Mike had explained, but his words were swallowed up by an announcement presenting the next dancers, and Chris had already returned his attention to the stage.

His gut was cold. He typed with two thumbs, his view of the screen invaded at the corners by his imagination. *Watched, watched, watched* Vicky give blow jobs to two guys... he pictured Shiloh, in her prim and sexy polka dot dress, hands clasped neatly on her lap, sitting in a straight-backed chair and watching "Vicky" sucking off two guys.

But why the subterfuge? he wondered. This was hot, this was unimaginably hot, but he wanted something *more*. He could read nothing in the text about Shiloh's tone. Was she turned on? Disgusted? Was she alone, or was Joey there with her, watching as well? Or was Joey a participant, and

Shiloh was looking at his cock, wet with "Vicky's" saliva, thinking about what it would feel like to drag her tongue around the girth of Joey's huge member, thinking about the feel of it inside of her?

The screen swam before his eyes, in a soup of flashing colored lights and strobe flashes, and scraps of imagined images that floated through his field of vision: Shiloh's lips, inches from another guy's dick, Shiloh's eyes, feverishly watching, Shiloh's pussy, slick and wet...

Shiloh that's so hot

He typed his message clumsily and looked at it, unsure. He'd a billion times rather talk to her.

He added a request to his message.

*call me
please*

And then, stomach twisted into knots, he waited. The stage in front of him flashed, and girls performed athletic stunts in skimpy clothing, but he saw none of it, and felt nothing. He could have been in a shoe store, for all he cared. All he could think about was Shiloh, and the more he drank and the longer he waited, the more the whole trajectory of the evening seemed like a lunatic's fevered dream.

The minutes ticked away, and Mike clutched his phone in his hand to feel it vibrate. He checked it compulsively, but nothing.

His chest felt like it was being torn apart by expanding ice. More minutes disappeared, each one dragging by slowly, a perversion of time, the dancers on the stage moving even faster and more grotesquely, but the figures marking the time on his phone stubbornly refusing to change minute-to-minute. It felt like hours had gone by, after only twenty minutes had passed.

Losing patience, he typed a message to Joey.

You know where Shiloh is bro? She's not calling me back.

He stared at it. He didn't want to seem like a needy psycho, and he didn't want Joey giving him the gears for not trusting him. And yet... yeah,

surely Joey knew that this lack of communication was driving him batshit crazy?

And what if Shiloh had gotten caught up in something? What then? The prospect was simultaneously delicious, but also terrifying, because it just wasn't *like* her. Even Joey had said that, when he had talked to him, back when they were still at the bar. Shiloh was too tightly wrapped to "get into" any trouble, Joey had told him.

You can only dream, he had said. Doubtfully.

And that had seemed true, at the time.

Why wasn't Shiloh answering her texts, though? Why wasn't she calling him?

Why hadn't he thought this through a little better?

He turned his screen again.

Nothing.

From either of them.

CHAPTER 7

Shiloh slid off the stool after a few moments and rounded the bar to make herself a drink. She poured a hefty portion of vodka - there was no rum - into a glass and watered it down only slightly with Coke. It tasted terrible, and she knew she had consumed way too much, but she slammed it anyway, and then set it on the bar with a crack. She wiped her mouth with the back of her hand, and left her wrist close to her lips for a moment, contemplating her behavior. It was all so coarse, so uninhibited. It felt like a costume on her.

But those thoughts didn't stop her from turning to the left, walking calmly to the hall, turning left again, and then, walking slowly, comfortably, passing couples making out, couples talking, threesomes forming, she made her way down the corridor.

The door to the room was open, strangely, enough for her to peer through the four-inch gap and see the movement of black skin against white, hear the slap of flesh against flesh, the groan of sex. She could even smell the tangy scent of pussy, punctuated by the astringent spikes of male cum, bleachy and slightly sour. She could almost taste it in her mouth - not something that she usually imagined, not something she usually craved, but her mouth watered a little and the maddening ache between her legs drove her forward. She put her hand on the door and pushed it open.

She was calm as she stood there. Surprisingly, all sense of discomfort, or embarrassment, had left her. She didn't really feel like she was there, and therefore she felt like she could do anything, stand anywhere. She leaned on the door-frame and stared into the room.

The blonde from earlier was on her hands and knees on a bed, all the covers bunched and falling to the floor. Damp patches on the fitted sheet indicated that this was not their first round. Shiloh's eyes took in the entire scene, but she was unable to process it, how it fit together, for a moment. Joey leaning against the headboard, casually, an almost disgusted look on his face. The sawing of the black man's hips, shiny with sweat so that he almost looked oiled. The thick purple of his shaft, stickily sawing into the blonde's gaping, stretched asshole, her hair landing wetly on her back as she tossed her head...

Shiloh's eyes returned to the sticky pumping of the black guy's cock, the veins that wrapped around his solid flesh swollen, full, almost ready to burst. It was almost monstrous, and the pale, taut flesh of the blonde's ass rippled in waves with each thrust that he delivered. The sound that she was making was halfway between a squeak and a moan, and she had a hand on her own ass, and was turned back slightly to look at the guy who was pummeling her.

Shiloh's eyes shifted to Joey, who had his legs stretched out alongside the rutting couple, and his eyes on her ass, the same as Shiloh. But what she had mistaken for disgust on his face was actually something else, she saw, because it was only on second glance that she noticed Christa's dark hair piled on his lap, the shape of her head moving beneath Joey's fingers as he moved her head up and down on his shaft.

Shiloh's mouth fell open, and she had a pang of emotion, one she couldn't identify.

This went on for several minutes, with the black guy pounding the blonde even harder, and Joey staring at that cock slamming into her ass while Christa sucked loudly on his dick. Shiloh was paralyzed again, unable to look away, her pussy clenching and squeezing juices into her already-soaked panties. Everything smelled like sex now; she could smell her own pussy, which ordinarily would have disturbed her, but it seemed irrelevant now.

And then, just as she was thinking about stepping back and out of the room, because no one had noticed her yet, Joey lifted his eyes and met hers.

The shape of his mouth - half-open, partially snarling, the mouth of a man close to coming - didn't change at all. A smirk, though, seemed to blossom in his eyes. Some kind of searing, smackable emotion glimmered in his stare. Once he met her eyes, he held her gaze, and it sucked her in like a tractor beam. They stayed like this until Joey's eyes squeezed half-closed, and his mouth twisted a little as he folded at his abdomen, his six-pack prominent. He groaned, and his fingers grasped Christa's hair tightly.

In her own hair, Shiloh felt a phantom pull, a sharp pain at the roots of her scalp. A swell of strange desire grew in her throat - to feel the soreness of a stretched mouth, the salty taste of cum.

The black guy announced that he was going to come, and then he thrust deep into the blonde and yelled at the ceiling.

And all the time, Joey, lips snarled and mouth open, kept his eyes locked on Shiloh's. Arousal zig-zagged through her, sending goosebumps racing up her arm, down her spine, heat flaring at the back of her neck, her eyes, inexplicably, watering a little.

She stepped backward without looking, still staring at Joey, and bumped into a scantily-clad woman in the hall, who giggled and looked into the room, placing a hand on Shiloh's shoulder. "Mmm," she purred, her eyes shifting from the bedroom scene to Shiloh's body. "Come with us?"

Shiloh limply held up her wrist, tearing her eyes from Joey's stare, and then she looked quickly back.

Confused, she stumbled back to the front of the house, her ears pounding with the sound of her own heartbeat, her pussy aching intensely.

*

Everywhere she went in the house, the party had taken a decidedly physical turn. The percentage of fully naked guests had doubled, or maybe tripled, but the strangest thing was that none of it deeply disturbed Shiloh as she made her way through the various rooms. It was like she wasn't really occupying her body.

Or maybe it was because her mind was still locked on Joey's eyes, and so she wasn't really seeing, let alone thinking about, anything that she saw as she walked around.

She was walking with a purposeful pace, like a person who was headed to get something from a place she knew well. But she had no such objective, and she knew it, so she also knew that eventually she would have to stop walking, or leave the house, or stand still somewhere and *do* something, or she would look like a crazy person.

She reached the kitchen, which seemed like as good of a place as any to linger. She opened a cupboard and removed a glass from it, looked in the fridge, and found some water, changed her mind and started scanning around for alcohol bottles. But most of her brain was used up, replaying the image of Joey's face and producing feelings of guilt that she had a hard time sorting through.

She turned around and leaned against the counter, glass in hand. A couple was making out in the far corner of the room, at a table where five or

so people were cloistered, huddled together, hands touching chests and legs suggestively.

Shiloh stared. But no matter what she looked at, her mind always went back to the room she had recently departed, to the rippled flesh of Joey's abdomen, or the glimpses of his cock, or to his stare, and the hot liquid that seemed to pour through her when she thought of him.

But why? Why *Joey*? Why wouldn't her mind fixate on *anyone* or *anything* else?

She pulled her phone out of her small purse, grateful that she hadn't left it anywhere, and her heart fell as she noticed the messages from Mike. *Call me*, he had written, over twenty minutes ago. She hadn't felt her phone vibrate in her purse.

She had, instead, gotten wildly distracted.

She stared at the screen.

She really, really, wanted to call Mike. Or better yet, she had wanted to have called Mike before she had witnessed Joey with Christa. Before that, this had all seemed kind of exciting, and she had been looking forward to hearing his reaction, to telling him the story over the phone or video chat, because it was kind of fun.

But not now. Not now, with stupid, stupid Joey worming his way into all of her thoughts. And what would she say to Mike about that? How would she even explain what had happened? And if he pressed her for details? If he asked her if it had turned her on?

No.

No, she thought, firmly and resolutely repeating it to herself in her head until her lips moved silently to form the word. There was no reason to tell Mike, for one: nothing physical had actually happened.

And two, because she just couldn't fathom telling him.

And telling him what, anyway? she asked herself, exasperated, enjoying the half-truth the way a jogger enjoys water on a hot day. What was there to say? She was looking at Joey while he was getting his cock sucked by some girl at this party... just like she had looked at everyone else, and watched other people, and gotten turned on.

She had gotten turned on watching another person have sex. Perfectly normal. That it was Joey was not the point. It had nothing to do with her feelings.

She went on like this for a while, holding her arm against her stomach, bending it at the elbow to take sips of the water she'd eventually opted for, her eyes on the people at the table, who were now beginning to mix together as a larger group. But no matter how hard she tried to frame it, she couldn't make the simple reality of Joey staring at her *while* he got his cock sucked, and the fact that it was his stare - not the rest of the scene - that had worked its way into her bloodstream and made her pussy so wet, to go away. Not really.

"That there's a good choice."

Joey's voice startled her, but she managed to keep herself from actually jumping.

"Where'd you get that?"

Joey was in the kitchen, close to her. She turned toward him as he turned away from her to open the fridge, having correctly guessed that her very cold water had come from there. He was fully clothed again, a patch of sweat seeping in needlepoints through the center of his back, and his skin giving off a scent that intoxicated Shiloh when she caught a whiff of it as he moved.

She stared at the hard muscle moving under his shirt and then looked away quickly. Her head felt light, high, fast-moving. She hadn't been this turned on in a long time. Not like this, not where the throb between her legs was urging her to do things that she knew much, much better than to do. Or that simply *weren't her*. She wanted desperately, for example, to lock herself in the small bathroom off the kitchen and slip her fingers into the soaked flesh of her pussy. The way she was feeling, she could probably make herself come with just a few strokes.

But she felt like everyone would notice, everyone would know, and that gave her pause, but didn't banish the idea from her mind the way such a mortifying thought ordinarily would have.

She was left with a strange kind of distance between her conscious thoughts and her actions, like driving from the back seat of a car.

Joey had located a beer in a tall can and was turning around, pushing the door closed behind him while he cracked it open. Shiloh took a deliberate step away from him and leaned on the opposite counter. Joey raised both of his eyebrows quickly at her, smiled, and lifted the beer in a toast. "Cheers," he told Shiloh, and started chugging it.

Shiloh glared at him, at his Adam's apple rolling along the length of his throat while he chugged his beer. How fucking typically typical Joey, being this nonchalant after something like that. She hated that this aspect of Joey's personality got to her so much. She was undecided about whether or not he did it on purpose, or was just actually oblivious to everything he did. Either answer was somehow unsatisfying, and neither answer changed anything real on the ground: she was Mike's wife, and Joey was his good friend, and so they were never hooking up.

She supposed it only made a difference in her own mind. But what *was* the difference, and why did she care?

It was the caring that really irked her. She wanted to believe that Joey was deliberately acting nonchalant... but if that was true, what did it mean? What did she *want* it to mean?

And if he really was just oblivious? This seemed like the most likely answer, and yet it wasn't the one she wanted to be true.

God. Either way, he was an infuriating piece of work, and she was lucky to be with her husband, who was a clear communicator and didn't play games unless, like their "game," they had clear rules. And he was sincere, and not a serial male whore, and... so many things, Shiloh thought, pushing her mind ahead impatiently, rushing her thoughts, so they eventually bunched up together and derailed in a pile of confusing feelings.

Joey lowered the beer after chugging for a considerable time. He gave a loud, satisfied exhale, and wiped his mouth with the back of his hand, examining the label on the beer can. "Shoulda probably had water first," he said, twisting the can to find the name of the beer amid all the scrawling, cartoonish decor on the can. "What the hell is this beer called?" he asked aloud.

He drank some more, looked around, and then finally, like an afterthought, looked over at Shiloh. The raised eyebrows again. A neutral expression, maybe tinted by a little more relaxation and friendliness than she usually picked up on with Joey. But that was probably just physical, because he had recently come in some girl's mouth.

"All good, Shy-Shy?" he asked her, grinning. He fished his phone out of a back pocket with one hand while he drank the rest of the beer, sweeping his fingers over the screen while looking down and chugging. "Hey, you gotta call Mike," he said, when he finished the beer. "Or text him or something. You done that yet?"

Shiloh leaned a little to try and see the screen, but it was too far away. "Why?"

Joey looked up at her, and for a long moment just grinned, his eyes on hers. It was the sort of look that could have meant absolutely anything, and maybe it meant all of those things at once: *are you fucking kidding me? Just do it. And, were you too distracted by my cock to answer your husband?*

"He's asking, Shy. Is all," Joey flipped the phone around so she could see Mike's messages, but she scanned too quickly and only saw her own name in a blur of text.

She leaned back against the counter as Joey put his phone away, still looking at her. "I'll call him," she said. Her own voice sounded testy, and she knew that Joey would read something into that, and probably something she didn't want. She set her glass down, watching it, so she could break eye contact with Joey. "I better get home," she said quietly.

Joey shrugged and crushed the can, easily, in one hand, then, acting like he was doing a layup, knocked it out of his hand and across the room, directly into a trash bin by the door. "All right," he said, crooking an elbow for her like they were at a debutante ball and she was his escort, turning toward the kitchen door.

Not knowing what else to do, Shiloh rolled her eyes and took his elbow loosely in her hand.

Which Joey, in his ever-unflappable nonchalance, did not take one way or the other.

*

They were standing on the steps of Shiloh and Mike's porch, Shiloh with her hand on the door, her heart pounding, her blood throbbing, her panties wet. Joey had insisted on walking her to the door - his method of "insistence" being to get out and walk with her up to the steps.

Shiloh's blood was running cold, because she knew that if Joey made a move to go inside, if he just did his Joey-thing and followed her in, she was going to make terrible decisions. She was desperately searching for the right way to tell him not to come in. She needed a great deal of time and space between this evening and Joey, as a buffer, because her mind and the alcohol were playing terrible tricks on her.

"Remember," Joey said, as she tapped the fob to her door uncertainly, opening her mouth to say the something she still hadn't thought out. He was speaking as seriously as he had ever said anything before. "He's in it for the angst."

And then, as Shiloh stood with her hand still on the doorknob, her mouth hanging open, Joey spun on his heel and trotted down the steps.

After winking at her.

She heard his door close, and she pushed on the door and tumbled in, leaning against it after she closed it. Her pussy throbbed, her stomach was alive in her belly, and her heart rate was far too high for normal. She felt a little ill.

But Joey had left, and a mistake had been avoided.

Now that he was gone, she was glad for that. Her hands shook as she held her phone, a testament to the proximity of danger.

Because... God. Joey was maybe hot, and maybe all of this was somewhat intoxicating and enticing... as an *idea*. But at the end of the day, she was very, very happily married to Mike. And she knew that anything she might like about Joey would be fleeting and purely carnal, and therefore, if it stood any chance of hurting Mike at all - a terrible mistake.

I'm home, she wrote to Mike, sighing with more relief than she'd realized she felt. *Are you still up?*

CHAPTER 8

Was he still up?

What else would he be doing?

He dialed Shiloh's number, after writing a "y" and an "e," groaning in frustration, and quickly switching to the phone.

"Shiloh," he said, as soon as the phone went through.

"Hey," she said. Her voice was strange, drunk, almost childlike.

"Uh, hey..." he said. A note of concern. "You okay?"

Shiloh was speaking through stifled yawns. "Oh, yeah, I'm just really... tired. I had a few too many, I think."

Mike was silent. *He'd* had a few too many, sitting, waiting, checking his phone, imagining Shiloh and Joey, Shiloh and no one, Shiloh just watching, Shiloh doing everyone at the party.

Shiloh and Joey.

Wondering what he actually wanted. That had required a ton of booze to be poured all over it.

But now that Shiloh was on the phone, now that he heard her voice and she was really there, with all the secrets he wanted to know inside her head, he was wide-awake.

"So..." he said, deliberately ignoring the fact that she'd said she was tired. "How, uh... how was it?"

There was a brief but pregnant silence.

"It was..." Shiloh began. She interrupted herself. "Have you ever been to any of these parties? With Joey?"

"Definitely not," Mike said, and that was the truth.

"It was... an experience," Shiloh said.

He couldn't get a good read off that. But Shiloh continued.

"So when we showed up? There were these, I don't know, like the hosts were there, and they had a basket of ribbons, right? And people were just tying ribbons on that meant... uh..." Shiloh giggled nervously. "Okay, so I'm having a hard time even telling you this story, because now that I say all this, it seems like it couldn't have even actually happened."

Mike deeply loved his wife, but sometimes - like a moment like this - she could drive him to sheer insanity. "What about the ribbons?" he asked.

As cheerfully and neutrally as possible, trying to hide his overblown, burgeoning excitement.

Because, Jesus, Shiloh, what else would he want to hear about?

Shiloh yawned again. "Huh? Oh, the ribbons. Yeah, so... I got a red one, which means 'just looking,' or something like that. And it's crazy, everyone took *that* really seriously. Which was good. But then there were black ones, and blue, and green..." Shiloh's voice drifted away.

"Shy?"

"Huh?"

"The ribbons? Different colors?"

"Yeah, they just meant different things, like... did you know about the..." Shiloh's voice dropped to a whisper, almost as if she believed she was telling a racist joke in a crowded place. "... *black* ribbons?"

He didn't know anything about ribbons at all, but he did know a thing or two about the hotwife scene, and he possessed a pretty sharp mind, so he could guess. Shiloh's words poured into him like liquid arousal, seeping from every extremity directly to his groin, where they made his already-hard cock strain against the laws of biology and ache painfully. His hand wandered into his boxers, which was all he was wearing, stretched out on the hotel room bed.

"I can guess what *that* is," he replied, his voice husky.

"How does everyone know *everything* about this except me?" Shiloh asked. Mike's cock throbbed. She wasn't saying it indignantly; in fact, there was very little offense in her voice. It was a throaty voice, almost teasing.

His spine tingling, Mike swallowed. "Uh... is that something you, um...?"

He was going to dare to ask if she would be into it, but he hesitated, and so Shiloh picked up the end of the sentence.

"Saw?" she asked, her voice even more husky and flirtatious than before.

And then she waited, and Mike's jaw fell open a little. His hand grasped his dick and stroked it slowly, the organ twitching in his hand. He could see his reflection in the open windows of his hotel room, which was on a high floor and looked out on distant buildings, and between them, across Lake Ontario at nothing, so there was no need to worry that anyone was looking in. He disregarded the scene, the creepiness of it, so contrasted with the wild ride that Shiloh was taking him on.

Was this actually happening?

His stomach lurched a little, and a vague wave of nausea came over him. His vision filled entirely with an image of Shiloh staring at a black man's cock, and there was nothing that would excise the image.

"Are you still there?" Shiloh asked, her voice flirtatious.

"I'm..." Mike's voice was shaky. "Yeah, Shiloh, Jesus..."

"I saw *that*," Shiloh said, "and... well, Vicky... I told you about that..." her voice trailed away.

"Shiloh, that's so hot, it's so hot that you went there..." Mike said.

"Just, you know, tell me about it. Please?"

"Well, I'm not... like, telling you in detail, over the phone," Shiloh said, laughing.

"Oh, come on, Shiloh," Mike breathed. "At least tell me if it turned you on..."

And that was when he heard it. A gasp, a sharp inhale, the ragged breath. "It was *crazy*," Shiloh said. Her voice was more of a whisper. "This Vicky woman was just... like I said, she was giving two guys a blow job at once... just... going from one guy to the other..." her voice trailed off again.

"Where were you?"

Shiloh's breath. Ragged and unsteady. He was certain, certain enough to bet his house on it, that she was masturbating as she spoke to him, and the image rose up into his field of vision, mingling with the others he'd imagined, the photo Joey had sent him, the greatest hits of his imagination. A shudder went through him.

"Just on the couch," Shiloh finally said, between ragged breaths.

"Watching."

"Shiloh..." Mike said. He was stroking his own cock now, and it wasn't long before he'd come. "Keep talking, baby,"

Shiloh made a noise, between a mewl and a growl, and said nothing for a moment. "So I watched that," she began, "and then they came over to the couch where I was sitting..."

Mike breathed and stroked, unable to encourage her to go on with anything but a grunt. Half of him was praying that Shiloh would tell him that she got involved somehow, but the other half was enraged by the idea, burning up with angered jealousy. It was an intoxicating, erection-enhancing elixir. "Fuck, Shiloh," he said.

"And then... Vicky's hair spilled over my lap..."

He squeezed his eyes closed, and the sound of his hand stroking his cock, slick with the precum that had been oozing out constantly since he arrived at his hotel room, made a sharp, gooey sound. He was so close, able to see only a dizzying array of overlapping image-thoughts.

A sharp exhale from Shiloh. Mike pumped his fist and then was seized by his orgasm, his mouth open, leaning over and yelling silently.

"... and then," Shiloh said, her voice noticeably unwound, her breathing like it was when she exercised, ever-so-slightly labored - but Shiloh could talk through a whole marathon, she was that cardiovascularly fit. "I decided it was... too much, and I needed to get the hell out of there... so I got up and went to the mini bar in another room."

Mike's cock was still spasming with his orgasm, the final spurts landing on his thigh, sticking to the interior of his boxers, turning cold almost as fast as Shiloh's story was running aground.

She laughed. "Oh, my, God... did you just jerk off to that?" she said, lightheartedly.

"Did *you*?" he managed to breathe.

"Hmmm," Shiloh said, noncommittally. "I mean, I was just doing it because of what I *saw*, not because of what I *said*." She giggled. "I don't think I'd make a very good... like, erotica writer, or sex line operator, or... whatever."

Mike tried to control his breathing while thinking of something to say to this - to any of it. Now that the wild state of mind he had been in while thinking about Shiloh was receding, the pressure in his head relieved by the orgasm he'd just had - "suffered through" might have been a better description - he was gathering his logical and orderly thoughts, and dark ones were creeping in, along with a resurgence of want, of need, of desire.

"It was good," Mike said. "Not, uh, bad for a first try... it worked for me."

Shiloh was quiet. "Well..."

"Was that it?" Mike asked, desperate for more. This couldn't have possibly been the entirety of the evening. "How long were you guys there, anyway?"

"Yeah, no, after that, I guess I just... wandered around." Shiloh had a tone in her voice that meant she was skirting around something.

She would have made a terrible poker player, Mike often thought. It was so obvious when she had something bottled up.

He waited.

Shiloh inhaled. "I walked in on Joey, though," she said, laughing a little, like it was a memory that had just surfaced, something she had considered insignificant and only thought of because of a chain of other thoughts leading her there.

It sent a bolt through Mike. A cold, steely stab that made his cock spring back to life, and his back set fire with a burn of arousal or jealousy or both.

"Walked in on Joey," he repeated listlessly. It was all he could do.

"Yeah," Shiloh said, in another unfathomable tone. "He was with some girl I talked to."

Mike waited, but this was the end of Shiloh's sentence.

"With some girl, huh? Doing what?"

Mike was cold from head to toe, but a fire raged inside of him. Sweat was beading at his temples, even though the air conditioning was on full blast and the room was actually too cool.

There was a long pause, and then Shiloh made a dismissive noise. "Doing what? God, I don't even - I didn't even - I mean, it was Joey, right? So I just - I didn't *see* very much. Of course."

Mike shook his head, even though Shiloh couldn't see him. "So you just... walked out?"

Shiloh sighed impatiently. "I mean, kind of, yeah... I'm not going to sit there watching *Joey* getting a blowjob, right? That's... you know."

What? What? What the fuck was it? Mike's brain was screaming at him, threatening to make his thoughts pour out of his mouth. How could Shiloh be leaving him on the hook like this, wriggling like a worm?

She didn't even know she was doing it, either. Not really.

"What's so bad about... I mean, I don't know," Mike heard himself saying.

"About *Joey*?!" Shiloh practically shrieked. "You aren't *serious*."

Mike looked at his reflection. His hand was still in his boxers, his hair had somehow become disheveled, sticking up in a scruffy point at the back of his head. *Was* he serious, about Joey?

"He's your best friend," Shiloh continued. "Or like, close friend. And he's so... he's so... just... I mean, you know how Joey is." She huffed haughtily in conclusion.

"Did Joey put the moves on you or something?" Mike asked. His cock pulsed against his hand when he asked, and a cool jealousy slithered in his abdomen, feeling like equal parts cold humiliation and scorching arousal.

Why?

"Joey?" Shiloh asked. "God. No."

"Not even a little bit?"

"No. God." A pause. "I mean, he did his usual Joey things, like make jokes or whatever."

"So you went to this party, and people were having sex, and Joey didn't even *try* anything with you?"

There was a strange pause, and then an even stranger sputter of half-formed syllables that spilled from Shiloh's mouth, before she said, in her most irritated tone: "No... God, Mike, no. Like I said, no. Jeez... just... ugh"

Mike *had* been going down this path to make a point to Shiloh: that whatever she thought about Joey, the reality was that Joey was a good guy when it came to shit like this. Sure, you wouldn't trust him with a cousin or a sister-in-law at a wedding, but you could trust him not to fuck your wife. Or try to.

That *had been* the point. But Shiloh's tone was confusing him, making him think that she was hiding something. Was she too insistent? Answering too quickly? Making more of a big deal about how much she despised Joey than usual?

"So *nothing* happened between you two?"

There was a terse silence. Mike was pretty sure he had gone too far, but it was too late to take it back.

"It makes me nervous, Shy, that you aren't answering that right away," Mike said softly, a real worry gathering in his gut, the cold spreading upward now, closing a frozen fist around his heart and squeezing.

"You know," Shiloh said, her tone suddenly - and frighteningly - different. "It almost sounds like you *want* something to have happened between us."

Mike's breath turned to an immobile heaviness in his torso, unmoving, the pain of oxygen depletion spreading slowly throughout his chest, into his bloodstream. The way Shiloh said this last sentence, he pictured her leaning on the counter, swirling her finger around in a pool of condensation absent-mindedly, like she always did.

But that couldn't be Shiloh saying this, not in that voice. Not playfully, not teasing him. Not Shiloh.

"Shy," Mike breathed.

"*Mike*," Shiloh answered.

She let this linger a bit, while Mike felt like he was a de-tethered astronaut, just cartwheeling through space.

She laughed sharply, almost a kennel-cough of a bark. "God. Seriously, Mike. No. Nothing happened with Joey." She laughed then. "And nothing will. Are you kidding me?"

Mike breathed a sigh of mostly relief, and the world returned to focus. "Okay," he said. "Sorry... I, sorry, Shy."

"You still haven't answered my question, though," Shiloh said.

The world started tipping again.

"What question?"

Everything going by in a blur. His stomach lurching to his feet, his heart pulverized.

"Did you *want* something to happen between us?"

Spinning, spinning, his thoughts in one direction, the world in another, nothing concrete to hold on to, no witty comeback, no simple answer.

"It's... no, Shy, no," Mike said, wincing with a sudden, fresh, headache that made him pinch his nose. "No, I was just...playing around."

"And Joey would never go for something like that, anyway," Shiloh added, in a confounding tone that almost seemed sarcastic. "Would he?"

Mike really couldn't tell anymore.

"Exactly," he said.

He pictured this last statement as a flaccid cock, limply slapping into his own thigh.

CHAPTER 9

"Hey buddy."

Joey's tone was the same as always, not especially anything at all. Carefree, unencumbered, and efficiency-minded. Joey didn't enjoy talking on the phone, but he answered reliably whenever Mike called.

"Whatcha doin'?" Mike asked nonchalantly as he could.

"Fixing," Joey said, a little bit of strain in his voice as he lifted or reached for something. "Your wife's washer."

"Oh," Mike said, surprised. He looked at the time. Eleven. That didn't seem entirely unreasonable. But he had called Shiloh and she hadn't answered. "You're at the house."

Joey breathed a half-hearted laugh into the phone. "Don't worry, buddy. Your wife went out to the gym or something, so she isn't here to see how a real man operates." Joey's voice strained again at the end of the sentence.

Mike stared at the wall. "To the gym?" he asked.

Joey muttered a string of cusswords under his breath, and then a loud bang. "I don't know, man, she was wearing exercise shit and said she was popping out. You need something?"

That was a million-dollar question.

Mike suddenly drew a blank. Why had he called Joey? Did he have a plan for what he was going to say? It seemed like he *would* have.

"No, man," Mike said. "I just, uh..."

There was a pause in the rattling and strained voices, and a smile crept into Joey's tone. "You talk to her about last night?" he asked. "Hot, right?"

"Hot," Mike agreed, trying to push all of the reluctance out of his voice. "Yeah, of course, man. She called me right after you dropped her off."

"You just calling to verify facts then?" Joey said, and Mike could hear the grin in his voice.

This had been the center of their friendship since its inception. Joey, carefree and not giving a fuck about anything. Joey, always operating on the fringe of decency, always cracking jokes, always willing to take chances no one else would.

But *also* Joey: never crossing any *real* line. Always at your back, teeth bared, on your way out of a hostile situation. He was - and maybe this would have been inexplicable to a lot of people - exactly that sort of guy you could trust *not* to fuck your wife.

And exactly the kind of guy you thought you could trust *to* fuck your wife.

"Kind of," Mike said.

"Look man, I'm sorry," Joey said, sending a stab of cold fear through Mike's chest. Another loud bang, another grunt, while Mike began spinning again, weightless, disoriented. "I was going to keep an eye on her the *whole* time, but then this crazy hot blonde was there and she wanted to take it up the ass from this black guy who's got this fucking insane dick. But she was fine, she had a red ribbon on, they have a system, you know?"

"I... what?"

"Just to say, you know: she was outta my sight for a while, but she was fine."

"Oh, right. Yeah, no, that's what she said."

"Dude," Joey slammed something else and cursed in what sounded like a foreign language, but almost certainly wasn't. "She tell you anything?"

There was a brief pause between this question and the next. So brief, in fact, that any normal person might not have considered it to be there. Not so for Mike, who hung onto it and let it spin his thoughts wildly out of control. *Did she tell you anything?* Anything.

Anything.

Anything about what?

"You can thank me later, man, 'cuz I think I just sped your timeline up like, years." Joey groaned again. "*Fuck*," he muttered. Then: "You're welcome."

It was like Joey was a switchman. Mike's brain left the rails it had been on and glided straight in another direction, full speed.

"You think she was into it?" Mike asked, his heart beating faster.

"I mean... I don't know what she said to *you*. But from where I was sitting, I'd say... definite yes. I know the type."

"But just into... watching. Right?"

"It always starts like that," Joey said. "Then they go one of two ways."

Mike shuddered.

"And Shiloh? Definitely tipping in the 'keenly interested' direction."

Mike didn't know what to say.

"Again, buddy, you're welcome. Oh, speak of the devil."

Through the earpiece, in the background, Mike heard Shiloh's voice.

Faint, at a distance. A little out-of-breath. "Hey."

"Hey, darlin,'" Joey said, loudly. "She's here, all sweaty, got a big stain of sweat in her pink sports bra, it's running down her thighs -"

"Who the *hell* are you talking to?" Shiloh interrupted, her voice closer and on a rise.

"Now she's mad, her cheeks are all red, and her nostril is flaring out like it does..."

There was a scuffle, an exchange of cusswords, a giggle from Shiloh, a low laugh from Joey. "It's *Mike*, you crazy bitch," Joey laughed. "Jesus, here, talk to him."

Nothing. A slap of flesh. "I'll call him from my phone," she said.

"Sweetie? I'll call you after I take a shower." Then another, lighter slap of skin. "Pig."

A long pause.

"Whoooo-eeeeee," Joey chortled. "Damn, she's so fucking *hot* when she's all worked up like that, man."

"Joey..."

"You sure you don't need something else done around here?" Joey joked. "I do dishwashers, vacuum cleaners, wives, the fridge, you name it." Joey laughed at his own joke and slammed something shut, Mike heard the clasps of a toolbox snapping and the jiggle of tools as Joey hefted off the washer and started walking. "Man, though, seriously... you need anything else?"

"Uh... yeah, no, not now..."

"Great. Cuz I gotta go take a cold shower after that, if you know what I mean."

Mike with his mouth open, speechless. Showers and flesh filled the imaginarium of his mind, Shiloh pale against Joey's uneven ombre of outdoor-work tan. His vision blurred.

"You don't mind if I use your shower, right?"

Still silence, no words within his grasp in the blizzard of fleshy showers.

"That's a joke, Mikey."

"Yeah, right, 'course."

"Unless you *want* me to..."

Joey laughed almost immediately, so there was no awkwardness as Mike flailed through the universe, untethered, unmoored, a hopeless boner spinning in the vast emptiness of the unknown.

"But for real. Gotta run."

A door opening. The bash of the toolbox against the frame.

"Lates." And then, just before the phone cut off:

"Bye, Shy-shi, baby. Call me later if you need anything fixed."

CHAPTER 10

Shiloh paced through the kitchen for a fourth time, pausing in front of the laundry room door to check her appearance in the full-length mirror again before heading back through the kitchen. Her eyes landed on the dishwasher, and she considered, for maybe the fourth time, actually disabling it somehow. But again, the scenario played out in her mind poorly: she wouldn't even know how to disable a dishwasher - she really didn't even know where it plugged in - so even *that* was off the table.

Even if she did know something like that, Joey would probably catch on to it. There was nothing that could be worse than Joey getting it into his head that she was sabotaging things in the house to lure him over there.

No. It was best just to let it play out the way she had already planned: Joey would come over, she would claim that the dishwasher "just started working again," and then she would begin her request with the phrase "while I have you here, I wanted to run something by you..."

She leaned on the counter on her elbows, imagining Joey across from her. She was wearing a red scoop-neck shirt that swung low on her breasts, but it was tight enough that leaning over like that wouldn't give Joey too much of a view...

She stood up straight, rolling her eyes at herself. "Well, sorry you made the trip," she said coquettishly, moving a finger over the counter. "But while I have you here... I want to run an idea past you."

As soon as she heard the words, she scrunched up her face and shook her head. Joey would *hate* that, and he would make fun of her, calling her a corporate-speech chatbot, or something like it. He hated being "managed." There wasn't much that ruffled Joey's fun-loving, mischief-making, carefree manner, but "being managed" turned his mood on a dime.

"Okay," Shiloh said, pushing her hair from her face and watching her hand as she moved it on the counter with her typical nervous tick: she planted a finger on a hard surface and twisted her hand a little. She looked up, tossing her hair. "So the truth is, the dishwasher isn't broken anymore. But I needed..." she groaned. "I wanted... I needed? I wanted?... I wanted to talk to you about something."

She stared at the wall.

"For Mike," she added quickly. "It's for Mike -"

A knock at the door made her jump slightly. She swept her phone off the counter and looked at it. No call, no text. But it had to be Joey. He was the only person on earth who would come to the door of their house and *knock*, when there was an outrageously expensive "doorbell"/intercom/security system right in his face begging to be used.

She crossed the room to the intercom and turned it on. "It's open!" she yelled, much too loudly, unlocking the door.

She heard the door open and then close, and she strolled back to her position at the island as Joey's footsteps neared the kitchen.

He had his toolbox in one hand and a smirk on his face. "You know, Shy, you really shouldn't let people just stroll in here -"

"I knew it was you," she said curtly. Her eyes dropped to the toolbox.

Joey lifted it - with remarkable ease - and set it on the island.

"You're going to be *so annoyed*," Shiloh said. "But I think it's working again."

Joey gave her a knowing grin, and folded his arms over his chest. This emphasized the size of his biceps and forearms. "Oh, yeah?" Joey asked with amusement. It was infuriating. He said it like he'd been expecting this all along.

"I mean... check it out, like... maybe it isn't..." Shiloh told him. "And I can..." she walked over to the fridge and opened it, looking in as though she didn't know what was in there. "Offer you a beer? For your trouble?"

"A beer, huh? You know, Shy, usually when the ladies call me to fix something but there's nothing broken, they offer me something a helluva lot better than a beer," Joey quipped.

"They're probably paying you to *begin* with, though," Shiloh answered, taking a beer can out of the fridge. "I have this weird Czech beer?" She set it down on the counter. "It's the best I can do."

Joey looked at her for a long moment, and Shiloh had to fight to meet his gaze, because it seemed molten. She wondered, not for the first time, what it was she really wanted, and what it was that really got under her skin, in these interactions with Joey. If she didn't have the level of confidence in Joey that she had - that he wouldn't *actually* take her up on these jokey offers of his, and that he wouldn't *act* on any of these impulses - would she still be flirting with the danger of him?

"Well," Joey said, in a tone that was still mysterious enough to make her wonder, "if it's the best you can do..." he swiped at the can and opened

it. "Something's better than nothing."

He took a sip of his beer without taking his eyes off Shiloh.

Shiloh dodged this gaze, because he was making her squirm, and she knew he did that on purpose. The urge to slap him rose up inside of her again, but she subdued it quickly. Years of practice.

She gave her head a little shake and used the back of her long pointer finger to draw a loose lock of hair away from her face. "So, listen... I actually wanted to talk to you about something..."

Joey set his beer down, grinning. "No kidding."

Shiloh emitted an exasperated sigh and moved over to the counter, facing Joey, just like she'd planned out. Except, he hadn't brought his toolbox in her imagined conversation, and he wasn't grinning like this, either.

She felt an urge to talk to him about her very non-existent dishwasher "problem," a narrative that she'd prepared. But Joey would know it was bullshit, and she had known that even when she came up with this idea. It was only now that she had the courage, or maybe the sense, to dismiss it.

"So... Mike's coming back for the long weekend, coming on Thursday and leaving Monday night. Next week. And, uh... I kind of wanted to maybe... give him a little surprise or something."

She was pleased to see, when she looked up, that she had perforated Joey's smooth veneer. Not by much, and not for long, but she was treated to a waver in his cool attitude, a disjointed movement in his jaw, the slipping of the can in his hand - only a centimeter, and then he clenched it - but it was there.

Recovered fully after a nanosecond, Joey started grinning again. "A surprise, Shiloh?" he asked, and tipped his head back to drink some beer and look at her sideways. "That doesn't sound like you at all."

She waited, unsure of what to say next. She had spent so much time on introducing the topic that she had never gotten any further than this first interaction. And, of course, Joey wasn't saying what she had scripted him to say in her mind.

"Is this like, a *big* surprise?" Joey ventured, smiling.

Shiloh shrugged helplessly. "I don't... not *big*..."

"So you don't want to, say, time his arrival so that he comes home and finds us..." Joey swung an arm out carelessly in the direction of the living room. "Watching Netflix together?"

"No."

"Eating popcorn out of the same bowl," Joey continued, dickishly.
"Butter running down our fingers, dripping onto our chests -"

"Joey, *Jesus*," Shiloh interrupted, but Joey seemed to have anticipated her interruption and was already chuckling. He sipped the beer, somehow still chuckling, and set it down. "Shy, it's not a surprise *party*, is it? I hate that. Mikey hates that. Actually, scratch that. *All men* hate surprise parties."

Shiloh arched an eyebrow.

"Okay, I'm not sure what that means, Shy, but what I just said is a true fact, take it to the bank."

"It's not a surprise party," Shiloh said. "At least not... in the conventional sense. I was just, uh... and I'm only thinking out loud here, so -"

Joey covered his ears and started shaking his head. "No corporate gibberish, Shy, please!"

"Thinking out loud? 'Thinking out loud' is corporate gibberish?"
Shiloh was almost yelling.

This made Joey grin. He tipped the can back and forth in his fingers.
"Yeah, okay."

Shiloh sighed and pressed on. She wasn't even sure if Joey was being sarcastic or agreeing with her.

It was all beside the point.

"No, what I was *thinking*, is that maybe if you *knew* about any... you know, parties, like the one we went to... or something *like* that, then maybe, um... I could surprise him with something like that."

Joey smiled benignly.

"So, like... a *party*."

Shiloh nodded, warily.

"That's a *surprise*."

Shiloh gave a groan of exasperation while Joey grinned and downed a huge drink of beer. He crushed the can - but more of a technically superior, crushing-for-recycling-purposes crunch than a frat house chest-thumping. "I'm sorry," he said, smiling. "It was just... there. Hmmm... party." He turned his attention to Shiloh. "That's a big step, Shiloh."

His voice was serious now, and the sudden shift in tone left Shiloh disoriented. She put her hands on the counter and leaned on them, nervously. "Really? I thought it was kind of... a small step."

"A party. Like the one we went to?"

"Yeah, but I mean... as a... like, the same kind of thing we did - *I* did - last time. Not, you know. Participating."

"Uh-huh," Joey said. "Uh... well..." For some reason he flipped his hands over a few times, watching them, fingers spread wide, like he was looking for a cut or a note to himself. "I have no idea if anything's going on, but, uh... I guess I can look into it for you." His eyes shifted to Shiloh's face. The seriousness wobbled, and his eyes felt like they were burning through her again. "And Mike's cool with this?" he asked her.

Shiloh stood up straight, backing subconsciously from the counter. "Cool with it?" she asked. "He *said* he was..." she furrowed her brow. "Why? Did he say something to you about... you know?"

"Know..." Joey said, grinning. "Know, what?" But then he took pity on her and laughed. "No, of course, he seemed real gung-ho about it, Shy. Mike's up for it. I'm, uh... talking more about the, uh... *way* you're going about it."

Shiloh folded her arms across her chest. "Oh, you mean, asking his sluttiest friend to tell me where the sluttiest party is."

Joey's eyes made a trip to three corners of the ceiling in turn, while he smiled. "Well, yes, I suppose you could phrase it like that if you wanted to."

"Well," Shiloh said. "I don't know how *else* to find out about a party like that."

"Or something like it," Joey added, and smiled when Shiloh gave him a look of consumption. "You said, 'or something like it,'" he clarified.

"Yeah, okay," Shiloh said. "Same difference. But, I don't know... I thought it would be kind of, um... nice. For *him*."

She met Joey's eyes.

A series of absolutely filthy vignettes played out in her imagination, rapidly, layered over each other in scenes of wet flesh and open mouths. Her pussy ached, and her chest tightened, but she held her gaze steadfastly.

"Okay, Shiloh," Joey said. "I'll see if I can rustle something up."

Shiloh was trembling inside, though if anyone had asked her why, or what emotion was the source of the tremor, she couldn't have said. "Oh... okay. Cool."

"Anything wrong with your dishwasher at all, Shy?"

She looked behind her, as if the Bose would have an answer. "I mean... it's a shitty dishwasher," she said.

Joey was smiling when she looked back at him. "Those are all shit," he said, lifting his toolbox. "I should really send the CEO a fruit basket. *Lots* of business comin' my way, if you catch my drift."

He strolled out of the kitchen.

"Uh... so you'll be in touch?"

"Sure thing darlin'" Joey called back.

And then, after the door opened. "And lock your damn door!"

CHAPTER 11

Hey sweetie. Bad news. Can you call me?

Shiloh rushed outside as soon as she read the message and dialed Mike.

"Hey," he answered.

"Hey, hi," Shiloh said, a little breathless. "What's... going on?"

"So - I'm fine, first of all, so don't worry..."

As Mike spoke, Shiloh's insides turned icy cold. Car accident? Mass shooting? *He's fine*, she repeated to herself, the world swimming around her in a strange blend of too-fast and too-slow. She put her hand to her head.

Mike was her *everything*. This wasn't crystal-clear every moment of every day, and, especially with the uneven distribution of responsibility and fun, and the distance between them, it was hard to really *feel* that all the time. But when the prospect of something bad having happened to him grazed up against her like it was in this moment, it had a powerfully clarifying effect. She loved Mike, and all the rest of this was just... amusement.

"... no symptoms, at all, so I'm surprised. But... it means that I had to cancel the flight."

Shiloh had spaced out for part of the explanation, but she was able to piece it together from what she heard. "*Covid?*" she screeched. "But you already *had* it." She dropped her hand. "God. I'm just glad it isn't... I was freaking out."

Mike laughed. "Oh, jeez, babe... yeah, sorry about that, I can see how that might've seemed like something else. I'm fine, I'm totally fine, just like last time, I wouldn't even know I had it except I took the test. So..."

"So wait... you can't fly back here? At all? Won't you be cleared up by the time your flight leaves?"

"Uh... yeah, that's - I mean, it's like, company policy. You know? They already canceled the flight, baby, there's nothing I can do."

"But..." Shiloh complained, exasperated. "You'll be *fine* by then, you'd test negative..." She was calculating in her head. This didn't make any sense at all.

"Babe," Mike sighed. "I know that. They know that. Everybody... knows that. It's just, you know, like an automatic thing."

Shiloh steamed silently. Mike's company was particularly stringent about covid, not wanting even the whiff of any kind of scandal polluting their reputation. They tested frequently and dropped a hammer on anyone who tested positive. This wasn't even the first time Mike had been summarily axed from a flight by the travel department, even though it made little sense. He had been scheduled to fly two weeks from the date he had last tested positive and they had canceled that travel plan as well.

"No, I know," Shiloh said bitterly. "I *know*, it's just, it's so... ugh!"

"Babe, you know there's no point fighting about it. It sucks, but it is what it is. I'll come out when I get the all-clear..." Mike sighed. "And when I get caught up after this mandatory isolation gig."

"How long is *that*?"

"Same as last time, technically. But once I get a clear test, I'm not sitting here in my hotel room for two weeks, that's for sure."

Shiloh had already guessed this, and was moving back to expressing her disbelief. Not so much at the company policy - which was, at this point, kind of draconian, but more at the bad luck of the event itself. This *couldn't* be happening. "I mean, I can't just - I mean, okay, maybe I can, but..."

"Honey, I know it's disappointing, but there's nothing I can do about it, you know? The guys are being as cool as they can about it. Policy, PR, you know the deal. I'll just have to come later."

Shiloh sighed.

"Baby, I'm sorry..."

"I know there's nothing you can do about it," Shiloh said, her voice heavy with disappointment. "It's just..."

"What?"

"Nothing," Shiloh said, pushing her hair around.

"Shiloh," Mike said, in his sternest voice.

"Eh..." Shiloh said, looking around her to see if any coworkers were around. She was on her second of two mandatory days in the office, but hardly anyone else was in the building. Her firm had implemented a flex-work policy when restrictions were lifted and no one seemed to be in a hurry to revise it. Satisfied that no one was around, she cradled the phone and turned toward the wall. "It's just that I had... something planned," she told him, her voice barely above a whisper.

"Can you reschedule it?" Mike offered helpfully.

"It's... it was sort of a, um... like a party - but not a surprise party! - just a, um," she smiled, remembering Joey in her kitchen. "A party that was a surprise," she said, unable to keep herself from smiling at Joey's annoying joke.

Mike was tersely quiet.

"So not a party *for* you," Shiloh rushed to clarify. "Not that kind of, um... party."

Still silence.

"So what, uh... what kind of party, exactly?"

She was pleased to hear something in his voice, the same thing she'd been so pleased to hear the night he had been in the stripclub, the same thing that made all of this appealing to her: Mike was *listening*. *Fully*. Fully interested in what she had to say.

You didn't have to work in corporate America, or for that matter, be married for very long, to become acutely aware of the difference.

"So just a party," Shiloh sang flirtatiously, imagining her husband's face. "Like the one I went to with Joey..."

There was a long silence. A strange, guttural sound.

"Sweetie?"

"Hold on, Shy," Mike said. "There has *got* to be a way to find a workaround."

*

In the end, of course, there wasn't any way or will on Mike's part to do that. But the enthusiasm that Mike had displayed for potentially committing what Shiloh could only assume was fraud at an international-incident level, only made her disappointment about him not being able to come even greater.

There would be other opportunities, Mike told her, his voice dripping with optimism. Ask Joey. Call him back tonight.

But each time that Shiloh brought up the messaging app to text Joey the bad news, she found herself overtaken by a paralysis, unable to think or to move her fingers to write something, even if she knew what that would be.

After all, what were the chances that Joey could find a party of the same type she had wanted, on such short notice? He had been amazed that he had stumbled onto the party he had found, for this weekend.

Sure, another truth lurked around in those muddy waters somewhere. She supposed this also meant that she wouldn't be going at all, and the disappointment was something she hadn't expected.

After all, wasn't she doing this for Mike?

It's what she had told herself, and Mike had already professed to be extremely turned on that she thought of it, and disappointed that it wouldn't happen, but he had pretty much moved on.

So if Mike wasn't that disappointed, what was plaguing *her*?

Finally, she had written to Joey.

Bad news. Mike had a positive covid test and can't fly. I guess it's a rain check.

She had typed and deleted "sorry" so many times that she initially wasn't sure if she included it or not immediately after she sent it and put her phone away in a drawer. She checked it again. No "sorry."

Good.

She was not sorry.

It was just bad luck.

She hadn't heard from Joey at all by the time she got home and called Mike back. She got his voicemail and left an anodyne message saying she'd try later. And then she paced.

*

"You're not *serious*?"

On her computer screen, Mike shrugged bashfully. "I'm not *un-serious*."

Shiloh blinked at the screen. It was a strange situation, and she didn't feel prepared to navigate it. Her desires were pulling her in two different directions: she both wanted to leap at this opportunity and explore it, and she very much wanted to run away from it.

It just didn't seem... *proper*.

Or realistic.

Or like it could end in anything other than disaster.

"You're still frowning," Mike said, tenderly. Shiloh felt a huge swell of longing in her chest: longing for Mike to be home, to hear him saying something like that next to her ear.

"I just..." Shiloh leaned back. She was seated on the floor of the bedroom, her legs folded under her, and she took her folded legs with her, tilting and balancing on her sitz bones while grabbing her feet.

"Okay, okay, look... All I'm saying, Shy, is that I want you to have a good time, okay?"

"I know, but..." Shiloh fell forward, back onto her crossed legs, and put her hands on her face. "Ugh! This stupid *pandemic*!"

There wasn't anything that could be done about it: Mike couldn't fly back this weekend, and he couldn't come the following weekend, either. And that was that. She'd just have to wait.

"Shy?" Mike asked. Shiloh wiped a stray tear away with her pinkie finger and uncovered her face. She put her head in her hand and propped her elbow on one knee, smiling, trying her best to look playful.

Mike didn't buy it. "Are you crying?" he asked, leaning in toward his screen.

Shiloh wiped a spilling tear away impatiently from her left eye and sniffed. "It's just frustration," she said.

Mike gave her a melting look. "Honey, listen: I don't want this to be causing you stress, okay? The only reason I suggested it was because... you know, you had it all planned out anyway, okay? So I thought this was something you wanted to do. That's all."

Shiloh sniffed. "I know, I just... I wanted to do it, but just... with *you* here. You know?"

Mike stared at her through the screen for a moment. "Okay," he said, definitively. "Okay, I... look, I get it. No problem. Just... don't go then. Okay?"

Shiloh looked at her husband's face through the screen. Why the uncertainty? Why was this answer, this plan - of abandoning their plan - also not satisfying to her?

"What's-the-problem?" Mike sang.

Shiloh balled her fists and let out a groan of exasperation. "Ugghhhhhh, I don't *know*. I don't know what the problem is!" She squeezed her eyes shut, and then tilted her head back, looking at the ceiling.

Perhaps there would be some inspiration in the carved wood paneling they had paid so much extra for.

When she tipped her head down, Mike was still looking at her.

"Shiloh... listen. I just want to be clear about this one thing more than anything, okay? This is like... not important, okay? If it happens or doesn't happen? It's a *fantasy*, and if you feel like doing it, that's... amazing, that's... my optimal choice, okay? But not if it makes you upset. That's all I'm saying."

Shiloh nodded.

"You still don't seem very... content," Mike said.

"I *know*," Shiloh answered bitterly. The bitterness wasn't for Mike, and luckily for her, he was the kind of man who understood her personality. "I'm *not*."

"Okay," Mike said, putting on his best salesman face and rubbing his hands together after a loud clapping of his palms. "What can *I* do, to put you in... a better mood?"

"Come home," Shiloh said, without thinking and without even running the statement by herself before it came out of her mouth. She felt a temporary, lightning-quick urge to slap her hand over her mouth, but it dissipated quickly.

After all, that *was* what she wanted. She wanted Mike to come home. And then what?

Shiloh put her head in her palm and closed her eyes as Mike said, "You know I can't do that, baby." His voice caressed her, hummed in her ears, sent a vibration through her whole body.

"I don't know what to do," she complained.

Mike paused, and then, in a measured tone, asked: "Is it... like... do you want me to decide for you?"

Shiloh shrugged and meshed her fingers together over her face.

"It seems like you just aren't... ready, or something. Is that it?"

Shiloh covered her face again. "Oh, no, it's not even *that*, I mean, this isn't like... it wasn't like... I was going to *do* anything anyway. I just wanted to... you know. Do this. But with you."

"Okay," Mike said calmly, when she uncovered her face. "Okay. So. Shiloh. Just... we can't get that done, okay? It's off the table. So don't even bother mapping out that part of the decision tree."

"You would be *so good* in some kind of people management position, you know that?" Shiloh joked. It was an old joke between them. "Maybe... helping wrangle testy, narcissistic clients of some kind..."

Mike smiled appreciatively. Warmly. It infuriated her, because he was, in point of fact, doing exactly that with her. But he was also so very good at it. Which was why she loved him, truly and deeply. Because she knew it all came from a place of deep love and affection for her.

"Okay, true, that would be a great match for my skills, some kind of job like that, but it has its pros and cons. A lot of time away from home..."

Shiloh rolled her eyes.

"Look. I'm having a really hard time, Shy, getting to what you want, here, and I just want you to be happy. I can't come this weekend -"

"Or next," Shiloh added.

"Or next. And I'm sorry. So, so, *so* very sorry," Mike added theatrically. "And so... you know, go from there. I'm - look - I'm sorry if I was pushing it so much and you think it's going to disappoint me or something. Okay? I guess I just... saw an opportunity, and I was also having a hard time accepting that it got dunked on by covid, okay? So, let's just... forget about it for now?"

"Yeah," Shiloh said wistfully.

He was right, of course. He was right about everything he'd said, and he was also right that it just wasn't settling with her as a solution. But this was an old and familiar problem: Shiloh had a hard time letting go of plans she had made, even when they were obviously impossible and there was nothing to be done about it. Mike, on the other hand, was a pragmatist, and flexible in ways that she wasn't, and abandoned ideas more easily.

"So what if... what if you just go out that weekend? Not the party? Just... something else that will keep you from being so... gloomy?"

"I don't have any *friends* right now," Shiloh complained. She was deliberately theatrical, wailing a little and acting childish, but her theatrics were covering up a real pain: she didn't have any friends here right now. They hadn't moved that long ago, and almost everyone else was on some hot-shit vacation or had gone back to school, and her coworkers were... not people she really wanted to hang out with. "I don't want to be some lonely old cougar at a bar by myself."

Mike laughed. "Okay, first of all, you're 32. And second of all, I doubt very much that you'd be sitting there by yourself for long."

"I could make it happen," Shiloh said. "I could wear sweatpants and a bun."

"You wouldn't, and it wouldn't stop everyone," Mike said. He paused. "What about Joey?"

"Joey," Shiloh said, again with a strange tone in her voice.

"It's just an idea," Mike said, almost defensively. Then, upbeat, he added: "You said you had fun last time."

And this was the real problem, Shiloh realized. Joey. She *was* disappointed that Mike wasn't coming, because she missed him desperately, and she *did* want to try out this new, exciting adventure with Mike.

That was all true, one hundred percent.

But not *all* of the disappointment flowed from there. Part of it, and she didn't know how much or what it meant, welled up from the dark place in her heart where she wanted *something* from Joey.

She just didn't know what.

Was it sex? Or just the idea of it? It wasn't a real relationship, she was sure of that. But in all of her fantasizing about what was (previously) going to happen that weekend, it was *mostly* about Mike. But it all had Joey somewhere in there, like a faint but very strong flavor that completed a dish but could overwhelm things very easily.

"Shiloh, I just don't get it, is all," Mike said, to her silence. "Joey was going to that party also, right?"

"Okay," Shiloh said, bravely. "Look. It's... hard to explain this. But I just don't... feel like... it's the best idea."

Mike squinted and pursed his lips. "To...?"

"Ugh," Shiloh muttered. "Joey. Go out with Joey. It's just... not the best idea."

Mike had a funny look on his face now. "Oh-kay," he said slowly. "Uh... you want to tell me why?"

"Not especially."

"Just because... I'm just having a hard time understanding this sudden change of, I don't know... feeling. About Joey."

"It isn't like this is news to you, that Joey's not my favorite person in the entire world," Shiloh said, defensively.

"No," Mike answered, now very serious. "But you did go out, and have a good time, you said nothing happened, you got Joey to... I don't

know, find this party for you... and you, I mean, I've talked to Joey, he hasn't mentioned anything..."

Shiloh made a face. "What are you saying?"

"Not saying anything, Shiloh, just recounting facts. And then adding, to those facts, that you have really changed your tune. And that makes me..." he twisted his mouth. "Not suspicious, exactly... just... confused."

"Confused, like you think I did something with Joey?" Shiloh asked. Even she wasn't sure what the tone in her voice meant. It was almost like she *did* feel guilty, and yet she didn't have anything to technically feel guilty about.

She reminded herself that Mike was just listing a series of facts and events, and the conclusion he was "suspicious" about would be the same conclusion she would have drawn from a similar situation in reverse.

Although, if she had a female friend who was anything like Joey, she wouldn't have sent her out on any kind of "date," platonic or no, with her husband.

Mike was looking back at her very seriously. "Obviously, I don't want to think *that*," he said.

"You're the one who told me to go do stuff with him!" Shiloh whined.

"Okay," Mike said, and he really sounded like it was. Carefully, he changed tack. "So... all I'm asking is, why the sudden change of heart about Joey?"

Shiloh pulled one knee to her chest and flicked at a fingernail, somewhat enraged, ready to start crying again, her heart beating very rapidly.

"Okay, fine. I don't know how to explain this, okay? I just... don't want to, I guess."

"Okay. I got *that*. Now, why?"

Shiloh was quiet.

"Broad strokes."

"I just don't... want to go out with Joey without you, okay? It seems... inappropriate."

Mike's face transformed into an expression that Shiloh couldn't make any sense of. Serious, intense... with a sexual energy lurking in it somewhere, but one she couldn't pinpoint. Arousal? Anger that looked like arousal? Some kind of angry combination of the two?

"Is there anything else?"

"Does it not seem inappropriate to *you*?"

"Uh... Shy, we're talking about, you know, doing something that most people find 'inappropriate' in a marriage anyway, so it's just kind of like, what's your definition?"

"Okay, look," Shiloh spat, and then started talking very quickly, which was a habit of hers when she made any kind of confession. Get it over as soon as possible. "Nothing happened between me and Joey. And honestly, that's how I want it, okay? He's... an asshole. I just... he's like, so..." she moved her hands around aimlessly in front of her chest. "Just... ugh, like an ape, you know, and he's always saying this stuff, and, like... I'm not *attracted* to him or anything, I just think that, you know, on the whole, it's... just, not a good idea. Like, in the event that, I don't know what, things get heated, I just don't want like, this whole... bad idea being, like... around. Okay? Yeah, that's it, okay, and I'm just going to say it, I think I don't entirely trust that... nothing will happen. And I don't... *want that*."

Mike leaned in toward the camera. He was seated at a desk of some kind - probably in his hotel, it was hard to tell, because all the bland corporate art of the world looked the same, in an office as a hotel room, through a video call.

"*Why* don't you want that?"

Shiloh's mouth fell open. Not so much because she couldn't believe the question, but because she simply hadn't thought of asking *herself* that.

Also, because... was that really the question he wanted to ask? After she said that?

"I mean... *Mike*. He's your, pretty much your *best*, friend," she said, whining a little.

"Okay," Mike said calmly, almost smiling. Maybe the smile was in his voice, she thought, studying his face intently. "But is that the *only* reason?"

Shiloh heated up again. "No, it's not the only reason!"

"You're not attracted to him at all?"

"No."

Mike's face was incredulous. Which was fair, because there wasn't a woman on earth who wasn't at least somewhat attracted to *something* about Joey.

"Okay," Shiloh conceded, without a battle. "God. Look, obviously Joey is like, physically attractive. But he's not *attractive*. I'm not *attracted* to him. He's... ugh."

"So you wouldn't want to have a relationship with him," Mike prompted.

"Don't be an idiot."

"You just find him physically attractive. And you're worried about that. Because it is inappropriate."

"I don't want to sleep with Joey," Shiloh said quickly.

"Don't, then. Okay? Don't. I'm only putting this out there, Shy, in the name of honesty, okay? That's our deal, right? Good communication? If you don't want to sleep with Joey, don't sleep with him. I'm just saying that you don't have to, uh... Joey being my friend is not a, um, deal-breaker for me. As far as that goes."

Shiloh was silent for a moment.

"*What?*" she said, finally.

"What do you mean, 'what?'" Mike asked, laughing a little nervously. He folded his forearms over each other, and Shiloh admired them for a moment, wishing she could reach out and touch them. Mike was not as bulky in the muscle department as He-Man Joey, but he was *hot*. "I'm saying, if something happens with Joey, it's... you know. Cool."

"Cool."

"But you don't want to, anyway, right?" Mike said, leaning back. He was saying this like he was running a meeting, matter-of-fact, neutral. "So there's no conflict here, in any direction. Unless I have something totally wrong."

Shiloh fell forward in exasperation. "I still don't feel like this is sorted out."

"Shy, Shy, Shiloh, listen," Mike's voice was tinnier through the speakers the way she was leaning over. "Just... let's forget it, okay? Entirely. We'll just... take a breather. I'm almost positive I'll be back in like... three weeks, max. And you can fly out here, okay?"

"I can't, my passport," Shiloh complained from under her hair. "The wait times are like two months."

"Shiloh," Mike said sternly. She lifted her head.

"Baby, listen. I know this is hard. And all this stuff..." he waved his hand around above his head, "it seems like it's just complicating everything. Okay? I just asked Joey to help out because, you know, I trust the guy, he's there, you're all by yourself, I was really just... making sure someone was

there taking care of stuff, and you. That's all. So... just forget about it. Stay home. Watch... uh, some girly show and eat chocolate and pine for me."

"I know that's a joke," Shiloh whined, and got suddenly overwhelmed by her feelings again. "But I am so *sick of it*, Mike. I'm so sick of it. I'm sick of this stupid town, it's so... ugly, and dry, and I have no friends, and you're never here, and I want a new job, and I don't want to stay in on a Friday watching fucking girly shows for the rest of my life!"

Mike was quiet for a moment.

Shiloh composed herself. "I'm sorry, that just... I just have a lot of built-up... frustration. I guess."

"Shiloh. Listen to me. I'm going to call Joey. I'm going to tell him to take you out on Friday. To a bar or something. And you guys are going to have drinks, and have fun, and he is going to just take you home and make sure you lock the door behind you. Okay?"

"Uh..."

"What about that is not okay?"

"Just... oh, I don't even know," Shiloh said, thinking she sounded more sad than bitter. "Fine. I'm just feeling sorry for myself. I'm just... mad about this stupid virus, mad at your boss, these stupid rules, mad about, like, everything." She looked at Mike, who was patiently waiting, as he always did, for her to get around to talking herself out of her bad mood.

"You're right," she sighed. "We can't do anything about it. Might as well."

"Might as well...?"

"Go out with stupid Joey, or whoever."

"Or *whoever*?" Mike said, trying to be funny. He raised his eyebrows.

And Shiloh might not have later been able to explain what it was inside of her that snapped because of that. It wasn't a "snap" of a psychotic kind, or even a particularly bad kind of snap. It was more like the crunch of a glow stick, breaking something apart inside of her that started a chemical reaction. The kind that generated light and heat. She could feel it filling her veins, seeping into her core.

"Maybe," she said, in a sexy voice that seemed unfamiliar to herself, and obviously, also to Mike, whose features seemed to enlarge and twist in his confusion. She gave her head a slight shake and drew a finger down the center of her chest. "Maybe *Joey* can fill in for you, on *that* front?"

CHAPTER 12

Shiloh stared at herself in the mirror for a long minute, hands at her sides. Then she gave herself a little turn, looked over her shoulder at her butt, and assessed the outfit for the fifth time.

She sighed loudly, and faced the mirror again, head tilted to the side.

It would have helped, she thought, almost sullenly, if she herself knew exactly what she was getting ready for, and it would have helped even more if she could have defined the message she wanted to send.

The intercom buzzed, and her insides turned to undulating mush. She stared at her reflection, and her mind suddenly emptied. Thoughts returned like a windstorm of scraps.

"It's too much," she hissed, looking at her outfit with fresh eyes.

The stockings - the knee-high stockings - were too much. They were made of a beige, patterned material, so she had thought she could get away with them not making her look like a hooker, but in the plain light of day, with Joey at the door, she realized that there was no way on earth to wear knee-high stockings, not even ones that were printed tastefully with a trendy design, without looking at least somewhat... slutty.

Shit.

She could take them off, she thought, but then the whole outfit - a classy, neutral-colored, wrap-around dress - looked so plain and business-like.

Which she knew *should be*, but was not, the vibe she wanted to be giving off.

A low whistle made her jump and emit a sharp shriek, clutching her heart.

"Shy-loh, that is one fucking hot getup."

It was Joey, who had entered the house anyway, after ringing the doorbell.

Fuck.

"God, you scared the shit out of me!" she hissed. "Why did you ring the doorbell if you were just going to walk right in?"

"Courtesy."

"But you just walked right in!"

Joey grinned. "Making a point. How hard is it to lock a door, Shy? Anyone off the street could just stroll right in here and catch you in your... socks."

"I'm not wearing these," Shiloh said, reaching with two hands for the top of her right stocking.

"Whoa, whoa, whoa," Joey said, holding up his hands and walking toward her. "Wait just a minute, please, Shy..." He approached her, riding on a faint wave of cedar and tobacco, a scent of aftershave, and mint. He was wearing a great-fitting green shirt that made him look younger and broader in the shoulders, and a pair of jeans that, incredibly, did not have a single fleck of paint on them or any holes.

Shiloh had let go of her stocking by the time he put his hands on her shoulders, behind her, facing the mirror.

The effect was utterly disorienting, almost enough to make her feel like she would collapse. He smelled good, his hands were warm and his fingers strong and firm, pressing into the soft flesh just above her collarbone. "Shy, if you lose the socks, this is like a trench coat. I'll think you're planning to flash people." He raised his eyebrows. "*Are* you going to flash people?"

Shiloh was lost, aware only of the presence of his hands - one on her shoulder, the fingers grazing her exposed skin, moving so slowly that it could be mistaken for nothing at all, and yet it *was* something, a caress, in slow-motion. The other was on her left arm, wrapped loosely around her bicep, easily capable of encircling it, and the heat of his hand ignited her skin.

She rolled her eyes. "I'm taking them off," she said.

Joey grinned over the top of her head at her eyes in the mirror. "That's not a no," he said. "But seriously, Shy, flashing or no flashing, on behalf of men everywhere, I beg of you, please, leave these socks on."

"They're not *socks*," Shiloh said. She looked at herself, and felt a little dizzy again when her eyes went to Joey's figure. He dropped his arms and stood back from her with his phone in his hand.

"Hold up, look, Shy, let's get Mike's opinion about this, okay?" He looked up at her reflection in the mirror. "Since you *obviously* don't care about what Joey thinks."

Shiloh heard the sound of a phone camera, and Joey began typing.

She spun around, furious, and reached for the phone. But Joey seemed to have anticipated the move, and stepped back, casually and in no hurry, still looking at the phone as he typed, grinning.

"Joey, Jesus!" Shiloh said. She really wished she could go back in time and get the dress she had been wearing just before this one. It was a plain, simple black cocktail dress, one of those things you could wear to work and then make decent for going out for very professional, platonic drinks right from the office, by simply removing the blazer. It was an anodyne sheathe that staked no claim on any particular message.

It's why she had abandoned it. And now she wished she could put it back on.

She swiped at the phone again, and Joey let it tip out of his hand and into her palm. She held it up and saw that the message was already sent. To "Mikey."

"Shiloh is trying to take her clothes off already?" she said, reading the first part of his comment. "Joey!"

He held his hand out for the phone, smirking. "It also says...?" he began.

It also said: *please tell her not to lose the socks.*

She slapped the phone into her hand. The truth was that the picture he'd snapped was pretty flattering. "God," she groaned. "Forget it, I'm getting my black dress."

"Ooh," Joey said, looking at his phone. "That sounds nice too, Shy, but we really have to get a move on."

Shiloh gave her hair a toss and put her hand on her hip. "To the bar? You have a reservation or something?" she demanded, sarcastically. She started to walk out of the kitchen. "Really, Joey, it'll just take a sec-"

Her phone rumbled on the counter. She swiped it as she walked out of the room, because it was a phone call, and she knew who it was without asking. "I'll be down in five," she snapped at Joey, and waited until she was climbing the stairs, breathless, to answer.

"Baby, I am not taking my clothes off," she said, by way of greeting.

"Where did you *get those*?" Mike panted.

Shiloh rolled her eyes. "Somewhere, I don't even know." She did: she had purchased them from a boutique store where they were on display in a window she passed every day that she went in to work. She had coveted the socks, and the outfit, for a long time, but it had looked too young, or too

expensive, or too... slutty... until today, when she had driven down there without being scheduled to be in the office and purchased the whole shebang when a sales clerk told her she looked "so fucking hot" in the outfit.

"Anyway, I'm taking them off," she continued, still breathless, climbing the stairs. "They send the wrong message."

She heard Mike laugh - a soft, gentle, secretive laugh that he did when he didn't want her to actually hear it and get mad at him.

"What?" she asked. "My first clue was that Joey thought I should keep them."

"I think you should keep them on," Mike said, his voice suddenly serious.

She stopped on the stairs. "Are you serious?" she asked, and then laughed, stepping onto the next step. "You're not even here," she told him, smiling.

"Shiloh," Mike said, his voice husky and almost as thrilling as the feel of Joey's hands on her shoulders. "Please just go out like that. It's so hot. Please."

"But you're not -"

"I know, I just love the idea of you going *out* like that, Shy."

Shiloh was at the top of the stairs. She marched into the bedroom, doubting herself. Now she kind of did want to wear them, but she also wanted to buck Joey's suggestion.

And why? she wondered. What the hell did she even care what Joey thought?

"I'm already upstairs," she said, her voice partially teasing and partially whiny. "What am I gonna do, march back down there in these? I can't stand even thinking about Joey's smug little face."

There was a silence, pregnant with an unknowable sentiment. "Just wear them, Shy," Mike pleaded, his voice low. "Please? For me?"

"But you're -"

"Joey will keep me in the loop," Mike said. "Remember?"

Shiloh sat down on the bed, smiling, sighing so it didn't sound like she was sighing. She crossed her legs and felt the dampness of her panties. The truth was that she *wanted* to wear them now, and the only thing driving her to wear the boring black dress was...

What?

Joey's smug little face.

"Okay," she said, liking the purr of her voice. "But if Joey makes *one more* comment, or looks like a little frat boy pig when I go down there..."

"I'll send him the message," Mike said. "Please don't change."

"Ehhhh," Shiloh said, enjoying teasing Mike. This was where the soft center of the thrill was for her, dragging him along, sensing, and *knowing* that he was hanging on her every word, thinking only about her. "Okay. If you insist."

Mike exhaled into the phone. "Baby," he said. "That's hot."

"Yeah, well, you won't even see it so, enjoy thinking about it."

There was a long, heavy, breathy pause.

"Joey will make sure I get to see it," Mike said.

Shiloh mostly disregarded this final comment. "Okay, well... here I go," she said. "With Joey. To a bar. To..."

"Do whatever it is you end up doing," Mike offered.

Shiloh bit into her lip. "Okay, but don't get your hopes up too much," she said.

She really, pretty much anyway, meant that. This was all just fun and games. Emphasis on *games*.

"Men always have their hopes up, Shy."

She smiled. "I love you, baby," she said. "I wish you were here."

"Go have fun, Shiloh. I love you, too."

Joey was at the bottom of the stairs, hands in his pockets, a serious expression on his face. Shiloh descended slowly, watching him. He didn't even bother looking at her legs, and she felt a pang of frustration.

"Okay," she said, holding her arms out away from her body and letting them fall to her hips. "I'm ready."

Joey nodded solemnly and extended an arm toward the door.

"You're not going to say anything?" Shiloh said, crossing toward the end table where her purse was lying, ready for many hours.

"I have explicit instructions not to say anything about anything you are wearing," Joey told her, fishing his phone from a pocket and waving it in his hand, following her as she walked toward the door. She opened it and stepped out, rolling her eyes for Joey even though he couldn't see her.

"And not to have a smug face," he added, which made her turn her head slightly, to see that he was indeed wearing the smuggest of grins,

reaching up for the door to hold it open by the top edge as they walked through.

*

"Well," Shiloh said, settling into a booth at Arnold's Blues Club. "We're here."

Arnold's had a reputation around town, of being a decent blues club that attracted excellent performances to its open-mike sessions. Hipsters had had a love affair with the place for a while and were rumored to have ruined the vibe. But when they pulled up to parallel park on the pockmarked section of a notoriously bad segment of High Street, in front of the dingy old sign and downturned facade of the club - which was really just a tiny dive bar with a small teetering stage stuffed into the shop space below a decrepit building - Joey assured Shiloh that the vibe at Arnold's was "exactly the same."

Staring at the opaque windows, washed to a smoke-colored filthiness with either decades of grunge or a discount paint, Shiloh had commented, "As what?"

The inside of the club was unusually packed - especially considering the absence of vehicles outside - and the patrons did not entirely match the surroundings. Not that Shiloh felt one way or the other about blues, but the band playing seemed pretty good.

Still. The place still smelled like old cigarettes and it wasn't exactly what she'd had in mind.

Joey bounced on the booth cushion and grinned. "You said you wanted to have fun," he told her. "This place is fun."

"Okay," Shiloh said, picking up a sun-faded drink menu in a plastic stand at the far end of the table.

"I think those are basically for show," Joey said. "Just order a drink, like, 'rum and Coke,' and you'll be fine."

Shiloh kept looking at the drink menu anyway. "This is from like 1975," she said. She put it back. "Okay, it's pretty cute," she admitted, looking around.

The truth was that it was a 'cool' bar, in the sense that if you were there for the music, or just to be in a dive bar, it fit the bill. She was secretly

glad to be able to tell her hipster assistant she had been here. The feeling that plagued her, though, was disappointment.

"Well, there's no one here to flirt with, that's for sure," she said, dryly, turning back to Joey after sizing up all the patrons.

"*I'm* here, darlin'," Joey said, the joke out of his mouth the second she finished her comment. He was grinning his smug grin. His words sent a thrilling flare coursing through her, but his smug grin sent her feelings careening in the other direction.

Or was it entirely the other direction? It was a question she'd asked herself on the drive over here. She had to reluctantly admit to herself that she always felt the same way about guys like Joey: in her consciousness, repelled, irritated, annoyed. But there was always something else lurking around there, something almost primal that made her want to keep testing the waters, plunging her toe in deeper, and deeper. She told herself that she didn't like Joey at all, that her life would be easier without him, and that was true. She reminded herself that she loved Mike - and that was definitely true. But something had still made her come out with Joey instead of staying home, and she knew in her heart that she would have done that whether or not Mike had basically given her explicit permission to "do something" with Joey.

The waitress came, chewing gum, and looked at Shiloh like she was speaking a foreign language when she asked for a Diet Coke with her rum.

"Just a rum and Coke, darlin'" Joey had said, diplomatically, and she left. Joey grinned over the table at her after she departed. "You're sitting there adding up all the calories, aren't you?" Joey said.

Shiloh glared at him, aware that her nostrils were flaring. She had been doing exactly that, but she didn't like Joey pointing it out for some reason.

"Nothing wrong with that, Shy," Joey said, fishing his phone out of his back pocket and obnoxiously scrolling through his texts. "Ladies don't get a rockin' bod like that by snarfing down whatever they see. Just..." he paused, his attention snatched away by some texts, further infuriating Shiloh. She was determined - again, consciously - not to let things like this get under her skin.

Because if the story was that she was here with Joey *only* at Mike's insistence, and she really didn't think much of Joey at all, then she shouldn't give a shit if he started in on his phone, rudely, while he was out with her.

Nonetheless, the truth was that it burned her biscuits, as her mother would have preferred she both said and thought. As opposed to ticking her right the fuck off, which was a better description.

Shiloh sighed and fished her own phone out of her purse. If Joey wanted to look disinterested, fine. She'd throw it right back in his face.

Except, sadly, she didn't really have anyone to text to, or any interest in looking at anything online, and writing to Mike didn't seem to have much of a point, because there was nothing to tell him. She wrote to him anyway, just to have something to do.

Here at Arnold's the dive bar with Joey. Who is... checking his email or something.

She attached a photo of Joey on his phone for good measure. And then sighed.

The waitress came back with their drinks, and demanded payment, which at least got Joey off his phone for two seconds.

Shiloh stabbed at the ice with her tiny plastic straw. "You got a hot date after this or something?" she asked Joey.

Joey's eyes went wide at something he saw on his screen. "You're *tattling* on me, Shiloh?" he scoffed, giving his phone a quick flip to show Shiloh the screen. It was a rapid flash, but she recognized the photo she had just taken.

"Whuh?" she heard herself say and reached for her phone. "I sent that to... are you texting *Mike*?"

Joey shook his head. "I'm being very rude, Shiloh, I apologize for that." He set his phone down and smiled at her over the table, lifting his beer to his lips.

Something burned inside of Shiloh, and whatever that unnameable and unfamiliar feeling was, it rose to the surface of her skin and made her cheeks and neck fiery hot. She knew, without seeing, that her cheeks were flushed, and she wished they weren't.

But the feeling wasn't embarrassment, and it wasn't even anger, or any of the feelings she usually professed to feel toward Joey. There was something else beneath it, an invisible current of delicious wrongdoing, a thrill, driving that heat.

She lifted her glass toward Joey and shrugged. "Apology accepted," she said, trying to sound disinterested. She looked around the bar again after Joey clinked glasses with her, still smiling his smug-ass little grin.

"What I was going to say, Shy, is that you should just let your hair down once in a while."

Shiloh leaned back in the booth with her drink in hand and gave her magnificent head of hair a shake to emphasize that it *was* down, in the literal sense. She laughed lightly. "This kinda looks like the sort of place where you just put your hair up in a bun, Joey."

Joey hit the table with each of his open palms, in rapid succession, four times, and grinned at her. "Shiloh, what's wrong? I thought you wanted to go out and have fun. This is a fun place. The music is good. The dancing gets going in like an hour." He leaned over the table, smiling conspiratorially. "It's *all* slow dancing."

Shiloh rolled her eyes again and picked up her phone when it vibrated next to her elbow.

Looking more like ten

From Mike.

Shiloh furrowed her brow.

Joey leaned over to catch a glimpse of her phone, and she pulled it away.

"Hot date?" he asked, teasing her.

"No, just Mike," she told him, cradling the phone to write a message back.

Huh?

Joey's face looked like the embodiment of her question when she looked up.

"Confusing message," she said, by way of explanation.

Joey's eyes dropped to the phone, and Shiloh thought she saw a flicker of something in his features. "Probably answered the wrong text," Joey offered.

Her phone buzzed.

*Sorry babe, wrong person
Have fun with Joey tell me everything
PS you look hot*

Shiloh set her phone down and gave Joey a look when she saw him staring at her expectantly.

He leaned back and threw his arms casually over the back of the booth. "So how 'bout it, Shy?"

Shiloh groaned. "Joey, what are we even *doing* here?" she said impatiently, with no idea where the impatience had come from so suddenly.

As usual, Joey just grinned and acted clueless. She should have expected that.

"Why, Shiloh, I was under the impression that you just wanted a fun, casual night out," Joey said. He extended a hand toward the stage. "So I brought you here. Good music. Stiff drinks. The most fun this side of the Mississippi." Joey delivered this last line while pointing up, and Shiloh followed his finger to a sign that read, *Arnold's Blues Club and Spirit Emporium. The most fun this side of the Mississippi.*

Joey raised his eyebrows and reached for her drink, and was taking a sip of it before she even realized what he was doing. "Yeah. See? There's actually rum in that drink. This is a good bar."

Shiloh took it out of his hand, scowling theatrically at the straw, which she pulled from the drink and tossed on a napkin. "Rude," she told him.

She leaned back and sipped her drink from the actual glass. "Well," she said. "I guess it's better than being home by myself."

"That's the spirit," Joey said, winking over his beer glass.

Another cool feeling slithered through her gut. She tore her eyes away from Joey and focused on the stage, wondering what the hell she was doing.

*

The drinks were pretty good, and they loosened her up enough that, half an hour later, she was no longer opposed to Arnold's, even if she was mildly disappointed. The place had filled up considerably after an hour, but the crowd was still not exactly appealing. But who cared? It *was* a pretty fun place, in the end, and this way she could feel confident that nothing

would happen this evening that she might have to make decisions about. It was freeing as well as disappointing, and Shiloh wasn't one to dwell on the negatives for very long.

She might even have enough booze after the next drink, she thought slyly, to dance with Joey, who was being an amicable conversation partner, and not constantly distracted by his phone. She felt ridiculous in her fancy getup, and a little like a hot look was going to waste, but other than that, the evening was still better than her most recent Friday nights by a mile.

"Oh," Joey said suddenly, mid-sentence. He held up his arm. "Look who it is."

He looked at Shiloh very pointedly then, and she was frozen for a moment, trying to figure out what he was talking about. Finally, she turned around, just in time to see Vicky, the tall and elegant vixen from the swinger party, gliding along through the crowd - everyone parting like water before her - looking positively devastating in a tight black dress and black leather jacket, her long hair flowing.

She smiled when she saw Shiloh and leaned down to kiss her on the cheek, but her eyes were on Joey as she said, "Hello, *darlin*."

Vicky slid in next to Joey and they seemed to melt together. They didn't kiss, or hug, or even grope each other, but the way they interacted was smooth in a way that only two people who have fucked can be. Vicky placed manicured red fingernails lightly and casually on Joey's forearm and raked them along, like she was petting a cat, her eyes on whoever it was who was sitting down next to Shiloh.

The man from the party, whose name Shiloh wasn't even sure she'd ever learned. "Hey," he said, casually. Shiloh scooted over because he was going to settle in whether she liked it or not.

"What are *you two* doing here?" Vicky purred, her whole body seeming to move in a slinky, delicious wave that matched her voice. Her fingers played with Joey's skin, settling on a single finger, which she started to slide between two fingers and her thumb distractedly. It looked for all the world like she was giving Joey's finger a hand job, and it was unsettling and provocative even for Shiloh, who was trying desperately not to let it consume her attention.

"Shil - enne, here wanted to dance with me, real slow," Joey said, in a voice that was a caricature of a sexy, baritone growl.

"Mmm," Vicky responded, her eyes on Shiloh, her tone incredibly disinterested.

Shiloh looked from Vicky to Joey as the three of them began talking. Something wasn't quite right here, and she didn't know where to start. Wouldn't Vicky have been the person Joey had called looking for a party? Wouldn't she at least *be* at that party, if there was one?

The conversation was mostly about people Shiloh didn't know, so she tuned out for a bit and listened to the music. Who cared? She glanced down and saw that Vicky was wearing thigh-high stockings - black, infinitely sexier than her own.

Of course.

The music was actually pretty good though, and after a while, Vicky and Joey broke off into a very intimate discussion, Vicky with her head in her hand and her arm on the back of the booth, facing Joey, trailing her fingers up and down his chest as she talked to him in a low voice. Shiloh felt Vicky's legs shift beneath the table, grazing Shiloh's knee as she crossed one lanky leg over the other.

"So," Shiloh said, turning to Vicky's ... what? Husband? Friend? She studied him. Was he actually cool with all this?

Whatever she had wanted to ask disappeared from her thoughts when he turned toward her and looked her up and down with hungry eyes. It was a bit more than Shiloh had wanted, conversationally speaking. But he was a good-looking man, and Joey was absorbed with Vicky, and Shiloh felt like giving Joey - for whatever reason, and even though it made very little sense - a taste of his own medicine.

"So," he said. His hand moved toward her, extended, for a handshake. "I'm Todd. Pretty sure I missed your name last time we met."

Joey suddenly interjected himself into the conversation. "Cheyenne," he said. "You want another drink?"

Vicky was looking at him strangely. Shiloh nudged her glass toward Joey across the table. "Uh, sure...?"

"Cheyenne," Todd said, and Shiloh reluctantly took her eyes off Joey to look at him. "That's a hot name."

"Yeah?" Shiloh said, touching her collar bone and batting her eyes. "I think it kinda sounds like a stripper name, personally."

"*Are* you a stripper?" Vicky asked. Her eyes went up and down Shiloh's torso, then she leaned over and took in her legs beneath the table.

"Hey," she murmured sexily. "Great stockings."

She seemed to have forgotten the stripping question, and the waitress was nearing their table at Joey's request, so Shiloh smiled and rolled an ankle playfully. "Thanks," she said.

Cheyenne, Shmeyenne, she thought. And decided to roll with it. Whatever it was.

That, and to make Joey pay, somehow, for something she couldn't even really define herself. Choosing a bad name for her sexual persona? Being attractive *and* a jerk she shouldn't be attracted to? Not being Mike?

She didn't know. She just felt loose, and turned on, and vaguely dangerous.

She turned her head slowly back to Todd.

"Not a stripper," she told Todd, answering Vicky's question. She knew this wasn't the kind of guy she would ever consider sleeping with, but some flirting didn't seem out of order. What would Joey do about it? What would Mike think?

What was she doing?

She fished an ice cube out of her drink with her straw, noted Joey's glance at it and smug smile, crunched it in her mouth after placing it on her tongue as sexily as possible.

After all...

What the hell?

*

In what seemed like no time at all, Joey pulled her out of the booth to dance to a very slow and sexy song that - Shiloh was no expert or anything, but still - was *not* blues. It was the kind of dancing that was close, hands held, another along her waist, her torso against Joey's incredibly hard body. Somewhere near her hip she was sure that she brushed up against his cock and couldn't tell if he was hard or just well-endowed to the point of absurdity, and her heart beat rapidly when she tried to put those thoughts out of her mind.

He smelled good. He felt good. She could pretend all she wanted, and she was going to pretend a lot, but with her body against his, his rough hand holding hers, his body heat and the scent of his aftershave so close, she was intoxicated by Joey.

She probably just missed Mike. In fact, she knew that was a large component of why she was melting into Joey like this. But it was so... wrong.

Maybe that's why she felt the way she did about it. Because it was verboten, because she could also feel confident that Joey wouldn't take things too far. And at this point, it felt like they needed brakes from both sides, because she was in a very suggestible situation.

Satisfied with this thought, she melted into Joey a little more.

"This doesn't seem like blues anymore," she said, as they swayed - barely dancing, because there was no room, bumping constantly against the people around them. Everyone had gotten up to dance - no one was sitting anymore - and the place seemed to have gotten even more crowded.

Joey seemed distracted. "Yeah, no, uh... it's, um..." He reached behind him and produced his phone, looked at it quickly, and put it back in his pocket.

"It's this kind of thing," Shiloh told him, rolling her eyes at his phone. "That makes ladies think you're untrustworthy."

Joey gave her a tiny spin, because there was hardly any room for her to move. She came back against his chest, pleased that the spell was breaking, a little. "What kinda thing's that, Shy?"

Shiloh shrugged. "Just you. Always checking your phone. It's the kind of thing that makes me not so worried about you... you know."

Joey did know, and she could see that in his face. "I know... what?" he said, smugly.

Shiloh returned the smug expression. "That you won't, like, put the moves on me or anything."

Joey's reaction to this was strange. She was sure she felt a ripple through his body, the bounce of his cock somewhere near her hipbone, and his eyes seemed to change color for a moment. "Yeah, that's right, Shy. I'd *never* do that."

He raised his eyebrows, like it was a joke, and she kept dancing, playing along. But his words had been scorchingly hot, meant something other than what they meant, and she knew it. A dangerous shiver ran over her skin, leaving gooseflesh and downy hair spiked in its wake.

But the moment evaporated. Todd and Vicky were dancing near them and edged in their direction. Joey lifted a hand and waved Todd close to his ear, departing from her to lean over and talk to him.

Vicky became annoyed - but in the slow-moving, cat-like way of hers, by rolling her eyes only a little, slipping from between the two men, elbowing Todd and Joey out of her way. She put both her arms on Shiloh's shoulders without asking and began dancing with her. She was so tall that Shiloh was pretty much looking into her vast breasts, or up at her, like they were lovers.

"This dress is *so hot*," Vicky purred, looking down at Shiloh. It took her a moment to realize that she was talking about Shiloh's dress. Vicky was looking at her in a not-neutral way, and even though Shiloh had been hit on by plenty of women before, this felt a little more powerful than she knew what to do with.

"Uh, thanks," Shiloh said, perplexed. "I really like yours," she confided, honestly at least. But Vicky would have looked good in a gunny sack, and she seemed to know this. Vicky's body, soft and curved in every possible place, was brushing up against her in intensely intimate ways. She could feel the hard bump of her nipples against her arm or her chest when she pressed into her.

Shiloh had never been into girls, but she also had no idea how to get rid of them when they started hitting on her. She couldn't even be sure that's what Vicky was doing, and she didn't want to be presumptuous or impolite.

But a glance over at Joey, who was deep in an animated conversation with Todd and seemed to have forgotten all about Shiloh, triggered an unexpected competitive chord inside of Shiloh. She remembered Joey's admonishment that she was playing "in the kiddie pool," and had a wild urge to get his attention, to show him that he didn't have it all figured out.

Shiloh leaned in toward Vicky, tilting her head to speak into her ear. Vicky's ear was far away, though, and Shiloh had to slide a hand into her impossibly silky hair and pull a little on her head to bring her closer to her lips. She turned as she did this, just a little, so that Vicky's back was to Joey and Todd, and Shiloh could look over Vicky's shoulder as she spoke into her ear.

He didn't look at her right away, but Shiloh had to say something now that she'd brought Vicky close to her lips, so she rumbled in a voice just loud enough for Vicky to hear it: "I have a weird question for you," she said.

Vicky's said, "Mmm," or something like it, Shiloh could only feel the syllable against her arm and vibrating against her own chest. It was vaguely

- though very vaguely - erotic.

"Are you guys planning to go on to any, you know, kind of party tonight?"

A brief but palpable stiffness rolled through Vicky's body, disappearing just as quickly as it happened. Vicky leaned back, holding Shiloh intimately by the shoulders, though, still moving to the music. Her broad hips ground against hers, willing Shiloh to move in time with her. "What made you ask that?" Vicky asked. She looked, incredibly, a little ruffled.

Vicky leaned in toward Shiloh and her fingers played with the very tips of Shiloh's hair as she spoke. The sensation traveled along her gently moving hairs and tickled her scalp, sending rivulets of pleasure cascading over her body, her shoulders, along her spine, and then, like a bifurcated stream that has run into another object, turning sharply to pour straight into the center of her legs.

Where it became a liquid heat that slowly welled up in her pussy.

But maybe it was Vicky's fingers in her hair, and maybe it was Joey, whose eyes had come to land on Shiloh's face, taking in Vicky's fingers in her hair. His face didn't seem to change, except for his eyes - and Shiloh, triumphantly, noted that Joey's thoughts had been peeled away from Todd and whatever they had been talking about.

"I thought that was supposed to be a secret," Vicky murmured in Shiloh's hair, playing with the strands on the right side of her face, sending a delicious shiver so abruptly through Shiloh's body that she almost jerked her whole arm.

Joey was still looking at Shiloh, and so Shiloh smiled, letting her eyelids fall halfway, sensually - this wasn't really an act, because Vicky's fingers felt *good* - and then meeting Joey's gaze again, deliberately, intensely. She put her mouth close to Vicky's ear, the silky strands of hair brushing against her lips. Vicky smelled like expensive perfume, very subtly. "Oh," she said, not really thinking about her words or what they meant. "Then keep it a secret."

She didn't really know what was going on with that, or even what she had meant by what she said. Joey *was* cooking something up - that much was easy to see. And it didn't seem like whatever he was cooking up could possibly, under the circumstances, have anything to do with her, Shiloh. It seemed, in fact, like Joey was planning to ditch her at home and then go on

to this party anyway, and that Vicky and Todd were here to collect him. And even though that was exactly what Shiloh would have *said* should happen, she realized, holding Joey's rapt attention with her whispers in Vicky's ear, that as adolescent and unreasonable and going nowhere as it might have been, she wanted to keep Joey's attention for herself.

Or something like that.

What was he doing, taking her out at all, if he just wanted to be somewhere else?

Ah, yes. Shiloh was in the "kiddie pool."

She was a little drunk, she realized. Making silly decisions. Todd and Joey were standing still now, talking intently, but Joey's eyes kept going to her, some kind of worry in them. Shiloh deliberately moved to face Vicky and racked her brains for something else to ask her. She wanted to keep her talking, keep her fingers moving through her hair, but didn't want anything to necessarily go any further than that. And Vicky seemed like the sort of gal to move quickly on all sexual advances.

It was Vicky, though, who kept the conversation moving. "So, you decided to come after all?" she asked, moving in time to the music against Shiloh's body. She had a strange allure: Shiloh *knew* she wasn't "into" women - she never fantasized about them, and any lesbian who had ever approached her had not been attractive. But Vicky was... something else.

"Uh..." Shiloh said uncertainly. She wasn't sure what Vicky was talking about, and she was pretty loopy, so putting the pieces together wasn't the easiest task for her. But she took Vicky's comment as proof that something was, indeed, afoot, and Shiloh *hated* not being in "the know."

"I guess so," she told Vicky, in what she hoped was an equally confident, unbothered, sexy voice.

Vicky smiled. Her fingers swept over a bare patch of skin on Shiloh's back, between her shoulder blades. "Wonderful," she said. Then she leaned in and whispered in Shiloh's ear.

"I *told* Joey it's the perfect party for you," she murmured.

They continued to dance for a bit, Vicky's hands becoming more insistent with each passing moment. Shiloh just leaned into it. She might not have wanted to have sex with Vicky, but she wasn't bothered by dancing with her. Especially because it seemed to have concentrated Joey's attention on her.

And something about *that* burned more intensely than it really should have.

"Cuttin' in, darlin'" Joey said, out of nowhere, inserting himself between Vicky and Shiloh with such a self-assured manner that even the mighty Vicky allowed herself to be jostled away. Joey turned to her and kissed her on the lips, which made Vicky murmur something in his ear. He answered her in a low voice and Vicky slinked away, grinning.

Shiloh, a little tipsy, and definitely overwhelmed, leaned into Joey's body during this exchange. She could feel the hard shape of his cock against her lower abdomen, enjoyed the feel of his body against hers. A deep well of longing seemed to suddenly become uncapped, and her eyelids drooped sleepily as the throb consumed her.

She wanted this *so much*.

As soon as the thought materialized, fully-formed, in her consciousness, it startled her. She snapped to attention and pushed away from Joey's body, feeling suddenly sober as hell.

Joey registered the alarm, almost as if he had expected it. His hands were ready, taking her left hand in his and holding it to his chest, pulling her tight against him.

"Joey, I -"

"Shhhh," Joey said, leaning his forehead against hers. "I know, I know, I know what you're gonna say, Shy." He was smiling. His self-assured, smug smile. Shiloh was tugged, almost in two, by the competing forces inside of her - on the one hand, she really didn't want to lose contact with Joey's body, but it was more primal than anything, the desire to feel a *man*. And beneath it all, she knew, her desire was about Mike, the emptiness was for Mike: Joey was just a very... very hot... very masculine... very big, substitute.

Joey gave her spin, disorienting her, and pulled her close when he was done. He swayed theatrically, grinning.

"I think I need to go home," Shiloh said, in a flat whisper.

Joey seemed to be listening to this, contemplating it, taking it seriously. Feelings from all across the spectrum fluttered in Shiloh's chest. She needed to go home. Home before she made a mistake, a very different kind of mistake, the kind she was sure Mike didn't want -

"I have a secret, Shiloh," Joey whispered sensually in her ear, and her heart dropped and adrenaline filled her veins, making her feel shaky. What

would she say, if Joey's secret was something carnal, a wish for her to cheat on Mike with him? A proposition of some kind?

She felt a certain kind of danger, one she didn't like at all, one that signaled, with a weak peripheral blinking light, that she was stepping over a line. But she just stood there, swaying in Joey's clutches, mouth open, heart pounding.

Joey's lips grazed her ear as he began to whisper his secret to her, and she stared at the stage as it all unfolded from his lips.

CHAPTER 13

It wasn't the scene he'd expected. He'd never been to one of these parties of Joey's, though it wasn't for lack of trying on Joey's part.

His eyes were glassy and itchy with fatigue as he climbed the steps to the address Joey had given him. It seemed like he was in the wrong place, but he rang the doorbell anyway. It was too quiet, there weren't enough cars... he stepped back, down a step, and looked up at the building, a townhouse in a trendy part of the downtown area. All the curtains were drawn and the place looked dead.

But the door opened just as he turned on his heel to start back down the driveway to his car. A sensual woman with a big head of tight curls, wearing what seemed like a bra and a skirt, poked her head out of the door. Her mouth was large and welcoming, smiling, but she had a pink scarf tied around her eyes and was moving her hands blindly in front of her. "Yeee-ees?" she laughed, looking in the completely wrong direction.

"Uh..." Mike looked behind him, and then back at her. She was still smiling, her hands moving toward the sound of his voice. "I'm here for uh... the, uh, I'm friends with a guy named Joey... he, uh -"

She found him while he talked, and put her hands on his chest. She seemed pleased with what she found. Her lips were cherry-red and shiny, and she had a cute button nose, mocha skin, and bountiful, creamy breasts spilling from the lacy bra that she wore. "Come on *in*," she growled, after patting his chest with her hands.

Sure, Mike was here for another reason entirely, and he didn't want to fuck this woman, but he couldn't help swelling with pride after she growled like that because she liked what she felt through his shirt. He wasn't ripped like Joey, but he had a lean, decent physique, and this mixed-race lady with wild hair and a big mouth apparently liked it.

So he went inside, phone in one hand, checking for messages, eyes shifting quickly back and forth from the screen to the interior. His stomach was dropping through his feet, his senses heightened, his cock already aching.

And yet, he had a moment of doubt as he adjusted to the dim interior of the townhouse. A number of scantily-clad women, like the one who had let him in and was now wandering away at the behest of another man with a

lascivious grin, were all blindfolded, and wandered around, or had draped themselves over chairs, or were - Mike sucked in his breath - seated on a couch and languidly stroking one cock while lapping at a second in their other fist.

His eyes searched the room quickly. Shiloh wasn't here: he would have seen her immediately. The image of her sexy knee-high stockings and trench-coat dress was burned into his mind, where he savored it and sprinkled dirty thoughts onto it like seasoning: he pictured Shiloh totally naked beneath that dress, just waiting for someone to slowly pull on the tie around her waist, letting the silky cotton slide apart and then split open, revealing the contours of her body inch by inch.

And now came the real question. Did he really *want* Shiloh here?

He had bucked his company's policies, which was a pretty bold thing to do. When two rapid tests came back negative in the early hours of Friday morning, he had tried to book a flight from Toronto, but the only remaining seats were the price of a small used car. Not quite believing the depravity and riskiness of his actions, he had driven to Buffalo - a two-hour drive on the best of days, but a four-hour one on a Friday morning, just him and the entire population of Toronto with the same idea - and then hopped on a plane back home from there. It was a tortured, layover-filled flight, and to top it off, when he arrived, Joey had sent him a slew of mixed messages, and finally directed him to head straight here, to this party, where Mike was pretty sure he didn't know anyone and where, to his dismay, Shiloh and Joey didn't seem to be.

Yet, he reminded himself, didn't seem to be *yet*.

He'd had assurances from Joey that he would get Shiloh to this party, however he could. From there, Mike's intention was to surprise her, but he hadn't gamed it out all the way yet. He was flying a little blind, and he wasn't sure how he felt about that. He wasn't the kind of guy who normally enjoyed turning things over to some other man, so his actions didn't make a ton of sense, even to himself. He was letting Joey guide this whole experience, and it made him feel uncomfortable, but it was simultaneously erotic. After all, Joey was the one who had gotten Shiloh to go to the first party, which had been just the kind of crack in her shell that Mike had hoped to make. It was, truth be told, way further than he had ever expected Shiloh to go. Did it make him uncomfortable that Joey was taking the lead? Sure. But the discomfort was no match for the raw, searing desire that he

had to actually *see* Shiloh with another man. Now that this fantasy - which had always been a *fantasy*, and one he'd always believed he'd only see partially fulfilled - seemed like a tenable thing, he was just going along for the ride, seeing where it took him.

He wandered through the house, taking in the scenes of libertine sexual encounters, stopping for a long time at a scene between two men and a dark-haired woman being spit-roasted. It was easy to let his imagination get carried away by that.

Mike left the room, his mind actually throbbing, like his cock - big, painful waves of pleasure so intense it hurt, pain so sexual it felt good. It was too much, he was thinking, as he stumbled down a hallway and back through the living room. He was headed for the door, he would head them off when they arrived and maybe they would find a way to salvage the evening, have an adventure that wasn't quite this... wild. Shiloh surely wasn't ready for this.

But as soon as he started to creep through the living room - taking care not to bump any of the couples or threesomes who were making out in clumps along the way - he saw that some new guests were piling into the small entryway. He recognized the woman with long hair from the photos Joey had been sneaking to him: Shiloh had been dancing with her, their arms entwined, both impossibly beautiful in the hazy, dusky light at the blues bar.

He stopped in his tracks, unable to make a decision about what to do. He saw Shiloh's hair, her stockings, the shape of her ass as she turned around. Mike edged toward a built-in bookshelf and tried to blend in, picking up a wine glass, staring through the colliding tongues and hands of the couple in front of him, who were making out feverishly and did not care that he was there staring at them in the slightest.

Through the moving, squirming frame of their flesh, Mike saw Joey turn Shiloh by the shoulders so she was facing Vicky. Mike's heart jumped in his chest: he missed Shiloh so much, he craved her touch, craved the feel of her warm, tight pussy. He was overcome by a desire to just go and snatch her away for himself, and even started taking a few steps in that direction.

But he stalled when he saw Shiloh's smile, saw the way that she leaned back slightly into Joey's chest, one hand held up, the back of it stroking Joey's muscles.

A smile - a genuine, excited smile - as Joey lifted his arms and brought them down on either side of her face, placing a thick, red headband-type thing around the top part of her head. Blindfolding her.

Shiloh all smiles, bringing her hands to the blindfold, Joey interfering, his mouth moving next to her ear.

Telling her to leave it on, his hands moving down her bare arms on either side, Shiloh being turned toward the party, smiling.

He stared at the scene. Joey was looking out into the party, and when he saw Mike he gave him a subtle smile, and moved his head even more subtly to nod at him. Then his hands, which had traveled back up along Shiloh's arms to her shoulders, then close to her long, exposed neck, drifted to her neck and grazed the hollow of her throat while he said something in her ear.

Something, that made Shiloh smile.

And then, pressed forward by Joey, the two of them entered, Joey behind Shiloh, one arm casually around her waist.

*

Not much happened at first. It was surreal, and from the moment that they had arrived, Mike felt like he had been sucked out of his body. He was watching with his own eyes but somehow he felt distant, like he was watching a screen in a darkened room. He began to even doubt that he was actually there. Joey wasn't exactly signaling to him, and he was so disoriented that he began to wonder if he hadn't imagined Joey looking at him or not.

It was what he wanted, he reminded himself, as he followed them, his eyes glued to Shiloh. They went to the kitchen first for a drink, and then started chatting with a small cluster of people. Mike edged into the kitchen, his eyes on his wife. The blindfold looked pretty tight, but he had a hard time accepting that Shiloh couldn't see where she was going, that she wouldn't see him, or somehow realize he was there.

"This is my friend Cheyenne," Joey was saying, and Shiloh - Cheyenne - smiled, extending her hand limply in front of her. A large, young guy with tattoos but otherwise preppy, in haircut and clothing, took her small fingers in his large hand and brought the back of it to his lips. When he pressed Shiloh's hand to his mouth, he put another hand out and

stroked her from the ridge of her collarbone in slow circles until his fingers played lightly with the v-neck of the wraparound dress.

He was speaking to Shiloh, putting the moves on her pretty hard, hunger flashing in his eyes. Joey sipped a beer and looked at Mike, warning him to stay back, to let it play out.

He stared openly as his wife let the man touch her, and smiled receptively. "Hi," she said, in a voice that sounded strange to Mike's ears.

They began to talk, and the conversation was low and muffled. Mike was too far away from them to hear, and didn't dare move in closer - theirs was an obviously private group, and he would have been a man too many for whatever was happening there.

Shiloh was still smiling but seemed to be getting some guidance from Joey, who was grinning wickedly at Mike whenever he got the chance.

Mike's cock throbbed. It was what they had agreed upon, what he had asked Joey to do, and yet now that he saw it - in the flesh, with his own two eyes - he was more stunned than anything else. Maybe he hadn't expected Shiloh to respond. Even if he'd wished for it, obsessed over it, fantasized endlessly about it when he jerked off, seeing it live in front of him was making him deeply disturbed.

Not enough to interfere. No, his curiosity was a bigger beast than that. He watched, almost salivating.

Whatever they had exchanged in words, it wasn't exactly a rejection. The man took Shiloh's hand again, speaking to her in a low voice. And then, moving slowly, speaking to her like she was a frightened wild animal, he guided Shiloh's hand down his chest, to the center of his legs, where an enormous bulge pressed against his jeans.

Shiloh's mouth fell open, and then her fingers closed a little around the shape of him.

His wife was touching another man's cock, her arm held in place against her side by his best friend, who was no longer looking at Mike, but instead had lowered his own eyes to watch her fingers as they explored the shape of the guy's dick through the fabric of his jeans.

Her mouth open in surprise. Then a smile. A flicker of uncertainty at the corners. She leaned back against Joey to say something, and Joey leaned over her shoulder, his lips grazing the swath of bare skin that peeked out from behind the loosely gathered wraparound. The v-shape of skin was getting wider with each passing minute, exposing more and more of

Shiloh's skin, the dip between her breasts - and no bra seemed to be found underneath it all.

Mike was edging closer, subconsciously he supposed, and he could hear Shiloh's voice - a sexual growl, velvety and smooth, not quaking with the kind of nervous energy he would have expected her to have. This was another thought that poured through him like hydrochloric acid, unsettlingly hot-cold: *this* was not his wife. The implicit betrayal in cupping another guy's dick through some jean material was not nearly as potent as the subtle betrayal that shifted beneath it: here was Shiloh, having a good time, thinking her husband was nowhere to be found, maybe even exacting some revenge on him for not coming home.

An urge to vomit gripped him tightly, and for a split second, he was sure it was going to happen. It subsided, though, as Shiloh's words made their way through his mind. "It's... tempting," Shiloh was saying. "But I need to, uh... settle in."

Joey had lifted his head by now, and his mouth was close to Shiloh's ear as his lips moved, the contents of his message unknown to all but Shiloh, whose lips paused in a neutral, attentive line, before they curved slowly into another smile. Shiloh pushed away from Joey and put both arms on the man's shoulders before tipping her head back and standing up on her tip toes, offering her mouth to the stranger.

Who took advantage of it without hesitation. He leaned in, kissing Shiloh, his hands moving to the base of her skull to grip her hair and pull her closer to his mouth.

"Mmm," he said, releasing her. "Well, come find me later," he said, and drew a finger down Shiloh's chest again, hooking a the tip into the top layer of fabric where it crossed the other, and tugging gently. From where he was, he'd have a nice view into what was beneath Shiloh's dress. He looked, and let the material fall back into place, before repeating that he would "be around" and hoped they would find him later.

Joey lifted a hand to hold up a finger to Mike when he started toward them, telling him to wait. Mike stopped, watching as Shiloh relaxed against Joey's back and lifted an arm to put her hand at the back of Joey's head, running her fingers through his hair.

A knife of arousal and cold pain sliced Mike's chest in two.

Shiloh was smiling. "I can't believe that just happened," she told Joey.

Joey, his fingers traveling lazily down Shiloh's arm, smiled. "Shy, did I see this right? You don't have a bra on?"

Joey looked up at Mike, grinning.

Shiloh smiled, and shrugged noncommittally. But she dropped the arm slung up to Joey's head and brought her hand to the front flap of the wraparound. She fingered it sensually before catching both parts with her thumb and lifting them out, away from her chest - only an inch or two - but enough for Joey to see into what lay beneath.

"Shiloh," Joey said wickedly, making her smile. "You are a *dirty* little girl."

Shiloh smiled.

And then, it seemed to Joey's surprise as much as Mike's, she rolled around to face Joey, draping her arms on his shoulders. "I didn't wear *any* underwear," she said.

A revelation which seemed to stab Joey through the groin as violently as it did Mike.

*

"Shy, Shy, Shy," Joey was saying, and she could sense him shaking his head. His cock was hard as a rock against her lower abdomen, pulsing, and the feel of his vitality was making her wet. From the moment he had slipped the blindfold over her head, she had felt transported outside of herself. It had worked exactly like Vicky had said it would, only maybe even *better* than she had promised. When the stranger had guided her hand to his cock, she had given herself over to the experience because she *could*: Something about not being able to see, about having to rely on what Joey told her, was heightening her sensitivity, making her boil with curiosity. And somehow it also transformed her: she wasn't really the person making decisions, touching strange men, leaning against Joey's hard cock and hard body.

It was freeing - exactly the thing she had needed to liberate herself from whatever had been holding her back before. Because even with Mike's permission, even with the growing desire that she felt to step out of bounds, something had been holding her back. Making her sight disappear had done two things: it made her *feel* almost anonymous, like another person.

And it allowed her to paint a picture, in her own mind, of what was going on around her, one in which she could have any audience she wanted. All she had to do was imagine it.

Joey's hands moved over her forearms. His lips were very close to hers, she could feel it in the breath that grazed her cheek and traveled over her ears, giving her goosebumps with its feathery promises. Should she kiss Joey now? Finally? It had always been leading up to this, and she knew it, and it wasn't anything more than what it was: physical desire.

Sensing where his lips were, even though she was unable to see, she acted almost before thinking and took a quick, gentle nibble at his lower lip. It was soft and warm, pleasantly dry where she bit, but when she lingered to close her lips on what she had caught between her teeth, the promise of the moist interior of his mouth grazed her upper lip.

Why didn't she have any underwear on? It had been a last-minute choice, a brazen one, and one that had really committed her. They were in her purse, where she had stuffed them after taking them off in the bathroom at the club. There had been no reason to tell Joey, no reason to announce this.

But now that she had? Blindfolded, so she couldn't claim to be an observer with any real conviction, her pussy smearing juices on her inner thighs, unencumbered by her panties, she had just signaled to Joey, and anyone listening, that she was, this time, *in the game*.

"Who's *this*?" a male voice said, after she released Joey's lips. He still had one of her wrists in his rough but sensual hand, and she could feel his pulse in a protruding vein on the back of it: she was pleased with every beat, every forceful, pressurized, throb in his blood and the echo of it in the solid twitches of his cock. She *had* him.

"This," she heard Joey say, and felt a throb against her hip as she wriggled around sensually in his embrace to face the owner of the voice, "Is Cheyenne."

Her body moved without her brain commanding it on any conscious level. She felt a solid chest beneath her palm, felt the shape of her mouth as she smiled. A broad, open, sexual smile, an imitation of Vicky, in many ways.

"What do you think, Joey?" she said, leaning against him. "Is this a good one?"

She liked the way Joey's body tensed behind her. This was what she had always imagined, when she let her imagination run wild, thinking about actually doing this with Mike: the tension that coiled up beneath his skin, the way that her teasing seemed to arouse him so painfully, like BDSM of the mind. It surprised her how much it turned her on - it had surprised her when she had imagined it, and it surprised her, now, as she inflicted it on Joey.

But she liked it. Joey had grazed her ear to answer, and the words only now made their way through the bright fog in her mind. "It's up to you baby, he's a good-looking guy."

After she spoke again, her own voice reverberated in her ears and she could hardly believe what she'd done. But "Cheyenne" was driving now, and Shiloh didn't feel anything but... well, mild surprise... to hear her say, in a sultry and gravelly voice, after smiling in his general direction:

"I only share my mouth."

Joey exhaled behind her and it sent a shiver down her spine.

Ha.

She had caught even Joey off-guard.

*

The pain spread out from his heart, where it was first inflicted, like an ice-cold fist had punched straight through his chest. He stared at his wife, who seemed to have turned to liquid that poured through Joey's hands and fingers. Her lips had moved and her voice had left her mouth, clear and not slurred, so there wasn't even the potential excuse of drunkenness.

The confident ring to it had almost blown him over. *I only share my mouth.*

The words were so foreign to Shiloh's lips he still couldn't believe them.

He watched the guy smile and his eyes light up, focusing on Shiloh's mouth. It was as if his thoughts were being broadcast, a slew of filthy images as he imagined all the possibilities of Shiloh's mouth. Shiloh smiled. Joey's mouth fell open, and Mike went cold to see that even Joey was stunned. He shifted his gaze to Mike and widened them, which chilled Mike to the bone: if Joey had lost control of Shiloh, this was going to be a very different game than he had previously imagined.

And yet: he was right here. He could stop any of this at any moment, just by reaching out and touching her. He could say her name, and she would rip off the blindfold and possibly even slap him when she saw him. He could do it, right now.

But he didn't. He was frozen in place, a drink in his hand, his mouth open. *Shiloh*, he thought silently. *You're wading into deep water.*

Without him.

But he didn't move, not then, and not when the man, who did not know Shiloh and therefore could not know that this was so outside of her normal behavior, took advantage of his luck, and said, "That so?" leaning in for a kiss.

Mike closed his eyes. Maybe Shiloh would frighten off, maybe she would realize she was too far out. This wasn't, truth be told, exactly what he had imagined. It was worse. It was better. It was...

Perfectly filthy.

He opened his eyes to catch the end of the wet kiss that Shiloh was giving this perfect stranger. The three of them stood - Joey with his arm still around Shiloh's waist, though loosely, like he had forgotten that he was supposed to hold on to her. She was drifting away, and Mike had to fight an urge to grasp her to himself. They waited for her reaction - all three of them, eyes bright with lust.

"Mmm," Shiloh said mysteriously, considering her verdict. She smiled. Leaned against Joey. Lifted her arms up to hook them around his neck and his head, like they were old lovers who did this kind of thing all the time. "I want to go somewhere more comfortable," she told Joey. "Where are we? The kitchen?"

Joey caught a hand as she brought it up toward her face and Shiloh laughed, dropping it when Joey grasped her wrist. "Okay, okay," she giggled. "Just take me, uh... somewhere else."

Her hand went to the man in front of her. "Are you coming?"

*

A cold glob of sweat that had been gathering on the knobby, swollen vertebrae at the base of his neck, an enlarged bone that was the result of a break in high school and would probably come back to haunt him in his old age, swelled and burst, dribbling cold sweat in a trickle that slid down his

spine and into the cleft of muscle on either side of it. It rolled until it soaked into his shirt, and Mike visualized the whole thing in another compartment of his mind while he stared at the real scene before him.

He was unable to process it.

They had moved through the house, Joey in the lead, Shiloh being led by the hand by Joey, the stranger she was going to share her mouth with behind her with a guiding hand on her ass. Mike followed, feeling like a ghost. The man didn't seem to care that he was there, tagging along, and that was how Joey had said it all worked. But it was still surreal to be experiencing it.

He wondered if it was this false sense of surrealism that kept him from acting, kept him from stepping in and putting a stop to it all. He didn't *really* want Shiloh to do this, did he?

The answer, from moment to moment, seemed to be no, and yet also seemed to be yes. This was his fantasy, but it had slipped out of his control and was turning into his nightmare, but one his body was stubbornly refusing to act upon. Maybe he just wanted to see if Shiloh was really going to take it to the next level. Here. Now. When she thought he couldn't see her, when she believed he was two thousand miles away and across a border. It stung that she was going through with it, after all the gentle leading that he'd been doing up to this point.

And he realized, watching her slide to her knees on the floor, that he had been hoping to share her with Joey. He had been imagining it like that for weeks now, even if the thought hadn't fully formed in his mind. He had been the one to put all of these pieces in place, driving Shiloh and Joey together, telling himself the lie that he didn't think Joey would cross the line with Shiloh. But he had *wanted* him to.

They had passed the first guy, whose cock Shiloh had felt in her hand what seemed like a million years ago, in the hall. He wandered by the door now and lingered, looking in. "*Shit*," he said, squeezing in next to Mike, who was halfway in the doorway. "Sorry, man," he said. He pointed in Shiloh's direction. "I just saw this chick," he said, looking a little stunned. "I thought she was one of those shy ones." He took a swig of beer and edged into the room.

Shiloh, meanwhile, had unbuttoned the guy's pants. They slipped from his hips and slid slowly down to his knees. Shiloh moved her hand up

his thigh, feeling for his cock with her fingers, curling her lower lip slowly beneath her upper teeth until she bit it gently.

Mike felt relief pour into his veins for a brief moment: Shiloh seemed to be hesitating. She wasn't willing to go this far, after all. It was also disappointing, and the weight of disappointment was ball-crushing and heavy in his abdomen, but the relief was moving quickly in his blood. Now, he thought. Now was the time to step in.

But Shiloh's hand was already there, her fingers wrapping around his cock - a thick, pink, good-sized member bowed sharply up and to his left. Mike stared as his wife explored this new shape, this first new cock since her wedding day, running her hand along the length of it. Her lips closed and she smiled, brushing a thumb over the weeping eye of his dick. It glided swiftly through his precum and she made a slow circle with her thumb while her tongue ran along her upper lip, wetting it.

There was a pause, a moment that seemed to linger in the room long after it happened, like a frame of time caught in a revolving door, as Shiloh paused. Blindfolded, a curious expression on her face, the cock of a total stranger in her hand, inches from her half-smiling lips. There was no way for Mike to know what was on Shiloh's mind except to read the contours of her mouth, and he his breath in those stretched, distorted seconds as she seemed to pause and consider... *something*.

What was it? Was she thinking of her marriage, of her husband, of the way that what she was about to do was something that would change things forever? Or had that moment already passed, and Shiloh paused simply to take a breath or to savor the feel of a strange cock in her hand before she tasted it? The blindfold made it impossible to know. Maybe it would have been impossible to know anyway, but it was definitely more closed-off to Mike because of it.

Her tongue emerged from between her lips, tentatively, almost like a shy animal. She really couldn't see: her tongue reached into the space before her and found its target clumsily, then turned and traced the contours of the crown, sliding along the blubbery ridge, sweeping over the smeared precum, swirling and sampling, seeking out the topography of his foreign dick while its owner sucked in his breath and watched Shiloh's mouth.

"Oh, fuck," he groaned, when Shiloh opened wide and took him inside. She slid her lips to her fist, until they bumped against it, and she began to suck him off, using her hand to pump the lower half of his cock

while she sucked hard at the other end. The crinkly wet sound of saliva and flesh filled the otherwise silent room, a warm dampness rising in temperature and humidity as the four males gathered there all stared at Shiloh and their bodies superheated and began to sweat.

This was how Shiloh sucked cock, this hand-and-mouth technique, and so for these first few moments the threads of burning pain that shot through Mike's body were tempered by the evenness of her delivery somehow. But after a few strokes, Shiloh paused with her lips at the fat end of his dick, puckered like for a kiss, and she opened her fingers, letting her hand slide from his shaft.

And then, after a smile, she took him into her mouth all the way to the base.

Not Shiloh.

"Oh, God, baby," the guy said, staring. He looked briefly at Joey, who was still as stone, leaning against a desk, a beer suspended in mid-air. His mouth was open in the closest thing to disbelief that Mike had ever seen Joey express. "Fuck, she's good," the guy told Joey.

Joey lifted his eyes after a lengthy pause and looked briefly at Mike, giving him a sort of nod and a smile, but he looked back at the main event almost immediately.

Shiloh gagged a little but kept going, her nostrils flaring as she tried to manage breathing and sucking at the same time. Her intensity was disorienting: she just wasn't *like this*. She struggled to keep going, saliva seeping from the corners of her mouth and rolling down her chin, until she reached up to hold him in her hand and take a break. Panting, sucking in air, she lapped at the crown of his cock.

"What's the matter, honey, too big?" the guy said.

Mike's stomach felt like it revolved in a slow, aching turn, and when Shiloh smiled, breathing raggedly, and opened her mouth greedily to take him in, his chest turned ice-cold. Joey looked on approvingly, and the guy who had come in a little later edged closer to Shiloh, his fingers on his jeans, unbuttoning them, fumbling for the zipper.

"Yo man," the guy said to Joey. "Think she can handle one more?"

Joey looked at Mike, then at the guy, and shrugged. "Her call, man. What do you say, Shy?"

Shiloh sucked on her first cock for a bit before releasing him fully from her mouth. A queer smile was on her lips, and Mike would have given

anything to see behind the blindfold, into her eyes, into her mind, and see what the smile meant.

She seemed to be weighing the idea, but with what scale?

She pulled the first man by the cock closer to her lips, and brushed them over his dick. "Mmm," she said, almost thoughtfully. "The more the merrier."

Joey put a hand out, onto the guy's chest, as he stepped toward Shiloh. "Hey man, she's only sharing her mouth, okay?"

As if there were a red-hot wire that ran through Mike's center, between his heart and his balls, this statement - like Shiloh's before - plucked it, and it reverberated hotly, searing his insides, drawing the last drops of blood that circulated in his limbs to his cock. This was nothing he had ever envisioned, and it was so *base*, reducing his wife to nothing more than a single body part that she "shared."

A guilty - very guilty - pleasure welled from that thought, though, wracking him with a near-orgasmic shameful arousal.

But it was out of his hands, anyway. Shiloh was the one who was smiling as she reached out blindly to find this second cock, who then turned back to keep sucking on the first while the second guy lifted her hand and placed it on his dick. It was Shiloh who was closing her fingers around him, her lips sliding down, and up, and down, the length of the other man while she stroked him.

She turned her head abruptly, letting the first guy's dick fall from her lips and leaving him bobbing near her cheek as she opened for the second. Mike didn't have the greatest view, but the sticky, slippery sound of her mouth, the cack of her gagging when his cock bumped against the back of her throat, reached him and turned to an image in the recesses of his mind.

A pause, Shiloh's fingers wrapped around the first guy's dick and the quiet panting of her breath. "It's so *thick*," she said, a note of wonderment in her voice.

"You can do it, honey," the guy panted, his chin almost to his chest as he looked down at her. Shiloh now had one hand on each cock, her head turned toward the second guy, who was more or less facing Mike. The second guy looked to his left at Joey, who had taken this moment to casually sip his beer without taking his eyes off Shiloh. "This your girl?" he asked him. "She can do it, right?"

"You can do it, Shy," Joey said, in a low, tender voice.

It was this - and the fact that it prompted Shiloh to go back to work on his cock - that burned through Mike, even more than the sound of his wife sucking off some other guy when Shiloh started in again.

She rotated between them, sucking them off three bobs at a time before, breathing heavily, she turned back to the other and began on him. The scene unfolded in front of Mike and he seemed to float away from it in every way but visually. This was not Shiloh, he kept thinking. Where would Shiloh have gotten an idea like this, where would Shiloh have gotten the... confidence for this?

On the next turn to the first guy, he dropped his hand to Shiloh's head, gripping her hair and the blindfold loosely in his fingers. "Oh God," he groaned. "Baby, don't stop, I'm so close."

Shiloh was at the end of his dick, an inch or so of its distended crown still in her mouth. She hummed something and smiled, then reached up to grab his shaft, pushing back against his hand with her head. "Good," she said, her lips against the tip of his cock. She turned her attention to the second man, her smile the last thing to disappear from Mike's vision, like the Cheshire cat, as she turned his way.

"Oh, man," the guy complained, his hand dropping to the wrist of Shiloh's hand wrapped around his cock. He moved her hand for her, and Shiloh let him, but clearly offered some resistance. He thought he heard a muffled laugh amid the wet sounds of Shiloh sucking the second guy off.

She released him and rolled onto her heels, smiling, a cock in each hand, her fists slowly pumping. Joey seemed impressed by this, then amused, and shook his head, tipping the beer back to drink it before glancing at Mike, a smile on his lips.

An impressed smile, easy to read. Still, something was cutting deep into Mike's psyche - the exchange of control that he had never really imagined, let alone fully authorized. Shiloh's enthusiasm, Shiloh's creativity, the lingering, niggling thought that would not leave his mind and which he could not decide if he hated or loved: had Joey groomed Shiloh, maybe even taught her a few things? Had they lied to him all along, and something much more had been happening between them while he was out of town?

Did it matter?

But he couldn't ransack his mind for this information with this happening in front of him. He could only stand there with a hard dick, pain

and pleasure playing off each other, while Shiloh smiled and stroked the cocks of strangers, teasing them.

"Come on, honey, please," the first man pleaded with her. "I want to come in your mouth, baby. You're killing me here."

"*Fuuuuuhck*," Joey hissed.

"Yeah?" Shiloh said, smiling seductively. She leaned in closer to his cock, grinning. She bared her teeth and gently bit on the end of his dick. Between her bared teeth she whispered. "Is that what you want?"

If the walls of the room had melted away to reveal that they were all in outer space at that moment, Mike would have been less shocked. This was not his wife. He wasn't sure what this was. He could no longer remember what he had imagined Shiloh doing when he had fantasized about her sleeping with another man. He knew it wasn't clean, he sometimes felt like a filthy beast for the things he came up with. But they were gone now, replaced by the *real* Shiloh, his *real* wife, and... this.

Shiloh put her tongue out, wet and flat, against the crown of the first guy's dick, and licked it like an animal, like a cow on a salt block. The man groaned, Joey exhaled, Mike's vision swam.

Stroking the first man languidly with her hand, Shiloh paused, smiling, before turning her attention to the second guy. A slick sound, Shiloh's voice: "And what do you want?"

A man of few words, evidently, he palmed her head and pushed her onto his cock. Shiloh sucked on him, but released him, grinning, and turned back to her first cock. "Should I swallow?" she mused, and it seemed that this was a question for nobody in particular, maybe only for Shiloh. She delivered it in an almost ditzy tone, which was like a serrated edge that Mike could make no sense of as it cut through him, sawing like a bread knife, straight through his torso.

A beer bottle dropped to the floor, landing with a thud. It was his own, one he had been holding in his sweaty hand, liquid condensing on the glass until it was warm, and it had simply fallen at his feet without overturning, a few ounces sloshing in the bottom. This made Joey grin and take another sip of his beer after saying "whoo-ee," quietly, in a high-pitched catcall of a voice.

Shiloh released him abruptly and went to work on the first guy, and he gasped and groaned, his stomach flexing, his features contorting into the screwed-up face of a man on the verge of orgasm. "Oh yeah, oh yeah, oh,

fuck, baby don't stop..." He groaned as he delivered his seed, and Shiloh went in deep, taking the blast at the back of her throat as he held her hair fiercely.

She released him a little early, gulping for air, and a final squirt of semen erupted from him, spilling onto her lips and her chin. Smiling, Shiloh paid it no mind, simply turned to her right and started in on the second guy.

He came after only a few bobs of Shiloh's head, and she slurped him up, staying at the base of his dick through each spasm of his body as he dumped his seed straight into her throat.

The first guy collapsed on the bed behind him, lying back on his elbows, watching the show. Shiloh finished the second guy off and released him with a pop and a murmur, something like "yum" or "mmm."

She rested back on her heels, swiping a finger around her open mouth, cleaning the spilled cum from her lips and sucking it off her fingers.

Mike bent a little at the waist, a pain seizing him in the stomach. He leaned against the door frame, ill but also wildly aroused.

"That was my first time," Shiloh announced, grinning.

Joey held his hands open with a shrug when they both turned to him with disbelieving faces.

"Fuck, dude," the first guy commented, touching his cock and looking at it.

"Lucky man," the second guy said, zipping up. He reached out and touched Shiloh's hair, combing his fingers through the now-wet strands near her cheek. "Tell me if you get around to sharing anything else, baby," he said. And then, in a strange sequence that involved him nodding solemnly at Mike as he slid by through the door, he exited.

"She don't do anything else, for real?" the first guy asked Joey, pushing himself up to sitting with one arm.

Joey looked at Shiloh, smiling. "Up to her, man," he said. He looked at Mike, grinning, but with some caution in his eyes.

"Yeah, well, same," he said, standing up. "Make sure to let me know," he said, looking down at Shiloh. He leaned down next to her ear. "I'd love to get some of that pussy if you ever get to sharing it."

Shiloh squirmed on the floor, smiling. The man left, and Mike stood by the door, frozen, unsure of where to go next.

"So," she purred, rolling onto one side and then leaning against the bottom of the bed. The lapels of the trench-style dress were falling open, the

mounds of her peach breasts plump and alluring, were shiny with a faint sheen of sweat. "Are we alone now?"

It took Mike a second to realize that she was talking to Joey. She folded her legs to one side and lifted her free hand to balance her forearm on top of her head, causing the material of her dress to slide off her right breast and let her nipple pop out, erect and swollen. Her lipstick was gone, strands of hair clung to the comforter on the bed, and through the humid beer and male sweat Mike could smell her ripe pussy.

"Not *exactly*," Joey said, pushing away from the desk he had been leaning on, looking at Mike.

It was a strange response, a strange question, and the questions it generated in Mike's mind were broad and deep but not anything he could cling to for even a moment. Because Shiloh purred, and reached out for Joey, her sexual energy seeming to overflow from her skin and pour all around them, wet and tangy and unreal. "That was *fuuuun*," Shiloh murmured, when Joey caught her searching hand in his. "but now I'm so... *unsatisfied*."

"Yeah?" Joey said, looking directly at Mike as he did. He jerked his head in the direction of the door. The meaning of his gesture was clear as a bell, but the implication, even after everything leading up to this moment, was incomprehensible to Mike.

And yet...

Mike stepped to the side and put a hand out to the door, pulling it toward him, watching the arc of it in his peripheral vision. He was shutting the door, giving implicit permission for whatever was about to happen in the room.

Joey's eyes left Mike's and turned their attention to Shiloh, who was stroking the length of Joey's arm with her fingers. "What you want, Shiloh?" Joey said. "Hmmm?" He let his pants fall to the floor, and pulled off his shirt.

Mike turned the handle to close the door quietly, but a small click permeated the air when he locked it. Shiloh paid it no mind, and Joey plopped on the bed next to her head. Shiloh turned toward him and rested her arms on his thighs. "Mmm," she said, and Mike felt like she had punched her fist through his gut.

He slumped against the wall, his legs feeling weak enough to allow him to collapse, as he stared at Shiloh's wandering fingers. They traveled

along Joey's thigh, up and down, several times, but on the next pass, she grazed his cock with her fingertips. Joey was erect again, his sizable cock twitching and engorging, pointed up already, ready for more.

Shiloh surprised Mike, and from his face, it seemed she surprised Joey as well, by standing up. She caught the long belt that kept her dress tied up, and played with it in her fingers, swaying enticingly in front of Joey.

Joey looked over at Mike, but only briefly, and then his eyes were locked on Shiloh as she tugged slowly at the belt, pulling it free of the loose knot she had tied it in. The material slipped open even more, but not all the way. Shiloh dipped her fingers beneath the fabric to unbutton something, and two faint puffs preceded her dress parting down the middle, exposing the length of her completely naked body from her neck to the center of her legs.

"Shy," Joey said, a note of warning in his voice. But Mike could see that Joey was locked on Shiloh, no matter what the rules were, no matter what the situation was. The creamy hints of her body, peeking from the shadows of the beige dress, were too much for even the greatest friend to resist. Even as Joey shook his head and protested, he was reaching his hands forward, wrapping them around Shiloh's knees, stroking the tender softness behind them with his thumbs.

That drove Shiloh wild, and the sensation seemed to course through her and directly into Mike. He wished he could see her eyes, see them flutter with pleasure. Her lips parted and she smiled. "I know," she whispered. "It's against the rules... but I'm just *so horny* after that."

The line itself, had it been delivered in any other way, would have seemed like something from a cheesy porno. In Shiloh's mouth, however, it acquired a velvet quality, and the sincerity of her plea infused it with a realism that plucked at the sexual string in Mike's torso and made it vibrate violently. Another wave of nausea poured over the arousal, and then arousal poured over the nausea.

"Shiloh," Joey purred, moving his hands up her thighs. They disappeared beneath the fabric of her dress, which was now hanging loosely at her sides. The fabric bunched at Joey's forearm and lifted with his hands, like a curtain coming up, over Shiloh's sculpted thighs, revealing each place that Joey's hands had already caressed.

The bulge of his hands had reached her hips, and then they moved inward, toward the center of her legs. The curtain of trench dress fell down again, obscuring Mike's view. But a sticky wet sound and the sudden parting of Shiloh's lips announced what Mike could not see: Joey's fingers, dipping into the folds of his wife's pussy.

Joey became absorbed in Shiloh. It was as easy to see as an eclipse: the lights went out, effectively, on whatever Joey was exchanging with Mike, and all attention went to Shiloh, who gasped and flinched as Joey struck some pleasing piece of flesh between her legs. "You're awfully wet, Shiloh," Joey said, looking up at her.

By the way he twisted his hand, palm up, ligaments protruding on his forearm as he moved his fingers, Mike could see, without seeing, that Joey was slipping two fingers into Shiloh's wet pussy. He started to finger-fuck her gently, and Shiloh tipped her head back, steadying herself by putting a hand on Joey's shoulder.

"You're being a very, very, bad girl, Shiloh," Joey said, in a low voice. He fingered her a little and she mewled and leaned into his hand when he stopped, grabbing his wrist.

"Please, Joey," Shiloh whispered, lifting a knee to climb onto the bed. She might as well have kneed Mike in the balls, the pain was just as intense.

"Please, what, Shy? Hmm? I thought you agreed you were only going to share your mouth."

Shiloh was climbing onto Joey's lap now, high on her knees, and she pushed the dress from her shoulders so that it fell down to her elbows and caught there, looking more like a shawl now, her whole body exposed. Her firm breasts bounced as she moved seductively above Joey's lap, her stomach pressing to his face. She shrugged out of the sleeves of the dress and put her hands in Joey's hair. "I know," she said, dropping her hand between Joey's legs and seeking his cock, which she grabbed with her right hand and squeezed, making Joey the one to shudder and let his mouth fall open. "I just *changed my mind*, I want *more*."

Shiloh rested her left hand on Joey's shoulder, leaning against him, forcing him to lean back slightly and cup her bare ass in his palms. His six-pack strained against the skin of his abdomen as he supported himself on his hips, leaning back in a sort of half-crunch, while Shiloh moved his dick through the folds of her dripping slit.

She teased him for a while, and Joey stared between her legs, watching her move his cock through the slick channels of tender flesh. Then, losing his patience he suddenly grasped her by the hips and jerked her onto his cock, thrusting his hips up hard and deep inside of her.

"Oh!" Shiloh shouted, her arms going temporarily limp and sliding from Joey's shoulders, almost falling to her sides. Joey thrust again, sitting up, holding Shiloh by the ass so that she was driven down onto his cock violently by the movement. "Oh my... oh my God," Shiloh murmured.

Joey reached up with one hand and pulled her hair gently to tip her head back. He ran his tongue from her left nipple all the way up her chest, licking her neck, closing his mouth around her jawline. "Oh fuck, Shiloh," he groaned, as she rolled her hips on his lap. "Fuck, your pussy's so tight, baby, it's so wet."

Shiloh started to bounce slowly on Joey's lap, her hands going back to his shoulders, her mouth open in what looked like disbelief. Who could know? Maybe she was shocked about the size of Joey's cock, the fact that she was fucking him. Maybe she was shocked that she was such a slut, or maybe she was shocked by how much she was enjoying it. The possibilities were endless. Mike's eyes were drawn to her left hand, to the ring that had slid around, obscuring the sizable diamond he had bought for her.

Joey leaned back on one elbow, one hand on Shiloh's hip, moving with her, keeping the pace for her, squeezing hard into her hip bone and the soft flesh all around it. The slap of Shiloh's ass on his thighs, the wet slurp of her pussy, drowned out every other sound in the room. The party had faded to a distant clatter of people somewhere far away, and even their ragged breath was overcome by the wet smacking sounds that Mike could not escape.

"That's it, baby, ride my cock til you come, that's a good girl." Joey slipped a finger into Shiloh's ass crack and let her slide along his fingers as she fucked him, his hand gliding in the sweat of her body and the smeared pussy juices that had worked their way between her asscheeks. He dipped his fingers into her juices as she banged away on him.

As Shiloh's mewls became more intense, and she fucked Joey harder, grinding against him, Joey began to draw lazy circles around her ass hole, and Mike's eyes were drawn to this scene. The obscenity of it: Shiloh's ass bouncing on Joey's lap, waves of flesh buckling as she plopped down, his shaft, sticky and coated with a creamy goop, peeking out as she fucked him.

His balls squashed beneath the weight of her ass when she came down, and Joey's finger play on her ass traveled with her body.

And then, with a smoothness that Mike found impressive, in spite of it all, Joey slipped his pointer finger deftly into Shiloh's ass and buried it deep, holding it in place even as Shiloh bounced and jerked.

"Oh!" Shiloh exclaimed but didn't even pause. Joey had a smug grin on his face, enjoying the tight kiss of Shiloh's ass on his finger as she fucked her way to a screaming orgasm.

"There we go," Joey said, watching her face. "Good girl, that's a good girl."

Shiloh was panting, her legs trembling, and she collapsed her weight against Joey and squirmed on his lap. Joey began to finger-fuck her ass, his digit gliding easily and smoothly in the juices he'd swept up from her sopping pussy.

Joey looked over at Mike as he bit into Shiloh's lower lip and his finger plunged in and out of her ass, making a soft and filthy sucking sound. Joey put his lips close to Shiloh's ear and spoke, but looked at Mike with a grin as he did. "Your ass feels so silky and hot Shiloh, baby."

Shiloh mewled.

"You gonna let me fuck your ass, honey? Hmm?"

Mike swallowed, but his throat was dry. The way Shiloh was slumped against Mike, her legs spread, his cock still in her pussy, he could see Joey's fat member where it stretched her pussy skin taut, the flesh at the edges of her lips almost colorless from stretching. The smooth gliding of Joey's finger, in and out of the tight eyelet of her ass, was invisible to him, but easily imagined.

"Hmm?" Joey said, when Shiloh didn't answer - but also didn't squirm away, instead letting him fuck her ass with his finger, mewling softly. He looked back up at Mike. "This your first time, baby? I'll go nice and slow, I promise, but I can tell you're gonna love it, sweetheart, you're the type." He gave Mike a grin when he said this, and then licked Shiloh's earlobe, making her mewl again.

She sat up, a hand reaching for the blindfold, which she mysteriously abandoned mid-tug. "Joey," she said, mewling again. "I don't... I don't know..."

Joey pushed deep into her ass and lifted his arm, making Shiloh rise up on her knees a little and her breath cut out as though someone had closed

her windpipe. Joey was working a second finger into her ass, alongside the first.

"Oh...oh!" Shiloh wailed, but she twisted her hips and rolled them, obviously enjoying what he was doing. "No, Joey, I can't... I shouldn't..."

Joey grinned. "You already broke the rules, Shiloh," Joey purred to her. "I can tell what kind of girl you are, too. You want to try it. You been wanting to try it, haven't you honey?" He was slowly fucking her with two fingers as he spoke to her, pulling them out all the way occasionally, giving Mike a glimpse of her gaping asshole, making him see it in his mind's eye, stretched for Joey's cock, gaping like a black mouth, spewing Joey's cum.

For a second he was untethered from reality again, spinning wildly in the universe, seasick and hopeless. Shiloh was getting fucked in the ass by his best friend's fingers, and she was *loving* it.

Joey put his mouth close to Shiloh's ear. "You know we have someone watching us," he whispered, loud enough for Mike to hear. He grinned at Mike, and Mike's whole body went cold when Shiloh reacted.

She wasn't startled, and she didn't even pause her slutty squirming for a second. She purred, just like a wild cat, and rolled her head back and to the right, looking almost exactly in Mike's direction - at least, if the blindfold had been off. Her smile was wild and demonic as well, and she grinned, sending a frisson of terror through Mike.

This woman, whoever she was, was not his wife. What was happening?

"You don't want to disappoint him, do you?" Joey whispered into her ear, before finding her mouth with his and kissing her.

Mike felt like his mind had been broken into many free-floating plates of large glass, vaguely like a scene from Superman, and he was trapped in each one of them: he wanted to see Joey fuck Shiloh, hell he was realizing that he'd wanted that forever. But he also wanted Shiloh to... what? Put up the teeniest bit more of a fight? Not do something so drastic on her first try? Remember that she had a husband and that she was supposed to check this out with him?

"Mmm," Shiloh mewled, almost whining. "I'm not supposed to..." she repeated, but her effort was lackluster, and Mike could already see that she was giving in. Joey was already turning her around, his fingers still in her ass as he pushed her onto her back on the bed. He turned around with her and then pulled her by her shoulder to roll onto her stomach.

Without saying anything, he got Shiloh up onto her hands and knees, using his fingers, still twisting and fucking slowly in her ass, to lift her hips up, which prompted her to get into position. Joey leaned over her, pushing her torso down to the bed, working the fingers in her ass hard and deep. "I'm gonna get my dick nice and wet in that pussy," Joey told her, "but you gotta hold still little girl, or I'm gonna unload in there. And then we're gonna have to start all over."

Joey turned his wrist at an angle, resting the meat of his palm on the sweaty indentation just above Shiloh's hole, and used his left hand to guide his cock to her pussy while he continued kneading the inside of her ass with his fingers.

"Mmm, oh," Shiloh mewled. Her mouth opened and her feet, spread wide on either side of Joey's hips, twisted in circles. Her thigh-highs were still on, though one had been pushed to down mid-shin, and she was still wearing her attractive half-boots with high spiky heels.

"Hold still, baby," Joey said, as he sank into her pussy. "Nuh-uh, Shiloh, don't move around, baby." He smacked her ass hard with his free hand. "Just gettin nice and wet, then I'm gonna fuck that little ass full of cum."

Joey fucked Shiloh slowly in the pussy while she obediently, submissively, let him, without moving, her hand at the side of her face, her mouth open.

"You ready sweet thing?" Joey asked. He was slowly sliding his fingers from her ass, and Shiloh mewled.

"I don't know, Joey," she whined. "You're so big..."

"You can do it, baby, just relax, it's gonna feel so good. I know your type, Shy. You're a little slut, you want a big load of cum in your ass. Don't you? Say it for our friend here, his cock is nice and hard. He wants to hear you say it. Tell me how you want me to fuck your ass like a little slut, honey."

Mike stared at the pile of loose, wet limbs and distended flesh that his wife had become. She mewled and twisted, demurring only a little before she opened her mouth and said, in a hoarse and sexy whisper, "I want you to fuck my ass full of cum, Joey - ooooh, ooooh..."

Shiloh's dirty request, each word of which peeled away at the tender insides of Mike's heart like a grater run over his flesh, was swallowed up by

her moans as Joey pressed his much-too-thick cock against the small gape of her ass and pushed himself inside slowly.

Mike stared at the inches of Joey's cock as they disappeared inch by inch inside his wife, who lay on the bed with her arms folded up beside her chest, her mouth open in a soundless exclamation of pleasure, twisted slightly by pain.

Joey's wiry pubic hair bumped against Shiloh's pale skin, the imprint of his fingers fading to pink on her buttock. Joey placed both hands on her ass and held her in place, looking down at his buried cock and the firm ass that sucked on it. For a moment he just enjoyed himself without moving, a look on his face of immense accomplishment and satisfaction.

He began to fuck Shiloh, sawing gently at first, in long smooth strokes. She mewled and twisted her feet, turning her face into the bed and clawing at the sheets. "Yeah, you like that, baby? I can tell that you do," Joey said, his voice a panting whisper. Joey looked over at Mike, no expression of any kind on his face, as he moved his hips and ground his cock deep into Shiloh's back door.

"She likes it," Joey said, turning his attention back to Shiloh but speaking to Mike. "I can always tell. Isn't that right, Shiloh? You like it, turns out you're a dirty, dirty little slut who likes to take it in the ass. Tell our friend here how much you like it."

Mike's heart was plummeting. How it could keep falling, forever, he didn't know. But he was hanging on to every sound that escaped Shiloh's lips, obsessed with the rolling movement of her body, the parting of her lips. Was this really *his* Shiloh?

Shiloh pushed up onto her hands and knees, shoving her ass back against Joey's hips. No longer just a passive fucktoy for him, Shiloh was grinding against him, trying to drive his cock deeper inside of her body. "Oh! Oh! Oh!" she moaned. "Mmm, yeah, I love it, oh fuck, Joey... mmmm..."

"Tell him how you like it in the ass," Joey said.

Shiloh panted, and chewed her lip, while Joey pulled her hips tight to his own and tilted his pelvis, driving his cock upward, toward her spine. "Oh, my... oh..." Shiloh panted.

"Say it, Shy," Joey said. He reached down and caught Shiloh's face by the jaw, squeezing her lips. At the same time, he leaned back on his heels and pulled Shiloh up with him, until she was sitting on his lap, his cock still

buried in her ass. Joey put his lips close to Shiloh's ear - her right ear, where Mike could not hear or see what Joey said to her. Shiloh smiled widely, and bounced on his dick.

"I love it," Shiloh said. "It's so... big, you're so *big*, don't stop, Joey."

Mike stared, dumbfounded, as Shiloh guided Joey's hands to her pussy and started him rubbing her clit as she bounced on his cock, rising up on her knees and then falling hard to the base of his rock-hard shaft, an understated howl of pleasure warbling from her lips each time she drove her ass down on his dick. "Oh, yeah, Joey, yeah, I'm gonna come again... oh, please don't stop...oh!"

But Joey had other plans. He was shifting his legs around already, sliding first one, then the other, around so that he was seated on his ass with his legs in front of him, Shiloh's still impaled by his cock. She didn't even seem to notice, but just kept bouncing and pleading with him to give her more.

Joey leaned back on his elbows again. His feet were at the head of the bed now, and Shiloh was on his lap. She fell forward when Joey slid his fingers slowly from between her legs. Shiloh howled and leaned forward, bracing herself on Joey's shins. This gave Mike a nearly perfect view of Joey's cock as she hammered her ass over it. Plunging, driven in by Shiloh's movement entirely.

Joey brought his fingers to his mouth and sucked Shiloh's pussy juices from them while rotating slightly to look back at Mike with his eyebrows raised. "Dang, Shiloh," he breathed, smiling.

This went on for a while, and Shiloh seemed primed to come if she kept going, with Joey not far behind her. He had returned his attention to watching her ass jiggle and bounce as Shiloh fucked him with abandon. Mike groaned, but it was a quiet groan of desperation and arousal, his balls screaming at him in agony. Neither one of them seemed to hear or care.

Joey, though, suddenly reached up to Shiloh's shoulder with one hand and pushed down on her torso, ceasing her bouncing. Shiloh squirmed and looked back at him, mewls of frustration leaving her lips in disorganized mobs of whining sounds and gurgles.

Joey pulled on her gently, lifting his torso showily by flexing his muscled abdomen so that his lips were next to her far ear, whispering to Shiloh, words unheard.

Shiloh smiled, and her body seemed to turn to a liquid after whatever Joey said to her. Joey rolled back onto his back, looking over at Mike as he did, grinning. Shiloh fell down on top of him like a curtain, lying on his torso, her head falling back over his shoulder, onto the bed, her open mouth above the rumpled pink blindfold, legs spread open and hooked on the outside of Joey's thighs.

"You want our friend to join in, baby?" Joey asked her, turning his head so that his mouth and tongue could nibble at and lick her face. "Hmm? You think you can handle two cocks at once?"

Mike, impelled by a force he could not claim to be his own will, was already pushing away from the wall. Already peeling his clothes away, his fingers fumbling with the zipper of his pants, limbs struggling to extricate himself from his clothing. He didn't know how he had done it once he had, because he was climbing naked onto the foot of the bed, staring at the absurd sight of his wife, splayed out like a starfish on top of Joey. With Joey's dick snaking out of her asshole, Joey's hands fondling her breasts, sliding over her slick, wet skin and down to her thighs, spreading her open, holding her in place, feeling his way over every inch of her body.

He worked his way between her legs and Joey's, unable to stop staring at the dick penetrating her, at the inches of it bent in a sharp arc, sawing in a languished glide as she squirmed atop him. "You want it, Shiloh?" Joey whispered in her ear, looking at Mike.

"Mmm," Shiloh mewled. "Yeah. Yes, please, fuck me, I want it," she panted. Her own hands had been tangled up somewhere above, playing with Joey's hair, clawing at the bedspread. She tried to move one now, to reach for Mike, but Joey caught her wrist and guided her fingers to her pussy. He drew her fingers through the sloppy-wet mess of her pussy and then guided them to her mouth, making her suck on them.

Which Shiloh did, with abandon.

Mike was about to explode. Shiloh squirmed and whined, begging the unseen stranger to fuck her. He lined his cock up at the squelching entrance to her pussy, and felt her lips hot and silky as they sucked wetly on his crown. He could feel precum oozing from his dick and had to squeeze his eyes shut for a moment to keep himself from boiling over right then and there.

He sank into Shiloh's pussy, leaning over her, his eyes on Joey's fingers grazing her throat. Her head fell back and she squealed, but her

body moved beneath him hungrily, wanting him. "Oh, God, oh, fuck," Shiloh mewled.

Her body was draped over Joey's, almost lifeless now. Her breasts bounced as Mike fucked her pussy, which felt strangely tight, the pressure of Joey's dick hard against the length of her canal, pulsing, the flesh between them slippery and sliding, wetly sucking on Mike as he neared his orgasm.

Just as he was about to come, the blindfold slipped from Shiloh's head. He noticed that her hand was moving it, not trying to fix it, but he was tipping over the edge, cum boiling up from his balls and surging to its escape in the wet trap of his wife's cheating cunt.

She opened her eyes and looked at him. He was seized by the cold, paralyzing fear of being caught doing something he shouldn't, but it was no match for the orgasm that was surging between his legs, wrapping itself around him, gripping him fiercely. Vaguely, like something deep underwater, he recognized that Shiloh was smiling at him, her expression bearing no surprise. Perhaps he had time to feel the power of this - it mingled with the intoxication of his cum surging from his cock, the wet feel of Shiloh's pussy, the knowledge that Joey was inside his wife as well, that she had just blatantly fucked Joey and someone she thought was a stranger.

"I'm... going to come..." Shiloh whispered, her eyes locked on Mike's. And then her pussy squeezed tightly, and her body shuddered violently, her head falling back over Joey's shoulder, mouth open, a long, almost hideous wail rising up from her throat.

Mike froze, feeling Shiloh's orgasm as it shook her body at every level - tiny rolls of muscles rippled through her pussy, Joey's eyes went wide as her ass no doubt seized similarly around his cock.

She opened her eyes after this and looked at Mike.

She smiled as he recovered his ability to move, and thrust into her only twice before his own orgasm - blinding, almost painful - overcame him. He poured his cum into her, and Joey's fingers dug into her flesh as he pushed her up a little, gripping her by the shoulders, and sank his teeth into the meat of her left shoulder, a muffled scream flubbed into her skin as he came.

Shiloh. Smiling, her eyes on his.

He almost blacked out, stars spinning wildly into his vision from the corners. He rolled off Shiloh and Joey, onto his back, pulling at her body as

he went. Shiloh and Joey rolled to the side, and Mike closed his eyes, spurts of cum still oozing from his distended and spasming cock.

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Joey's lips on Shiloh's shoulder, his green-yellow eyes hovering over her skin. "You all right, buddy?"

Shiloh's face, slightly concerned, half-moons of faint black mascara dotted beneath her lower eyelid.

"Honey?"

She reached for him and put her fingers in his hair. Her lips were close to his. They formed a smile as she kissed him, but his own mouth refused to form any shape at all. He stared at her, confused, aware that he shouldn't be - the disparate pieces of the evening were all coming together now, almost making sense.

"I knew you were coming," Shiloh whispered, almost like an incantation, after kissing him and being unable to elicit any response.

"I had to tell her, buddy," Joey said, smiling, and then rolled onto his back. He sat up, caught sight of Shiloh's smooth ass, and ran a hand over it while watching his own caress. This absorbed him momentarily, and then he seemed to shake it off. He leaned over the edge of the bed using pure core strength. "God, man, don't tell me you didn't key in on that until just now?" he said sarcastically. He sat up, tossing his own shirt up in the air and catching it. He looked over at Mike. "Although," he said thoughtfully, and then shrugged. He put on the shirt. "I guess it'd be hot that way."

He kissed Shiloh on the cheek, and hopped up, dick swinging, to look for his pants. "I need something to fucking drink," he declared.

"Shiloh?" Mike said, not really listening to Joey.

Shiloh glanced at Joey and lifted a hand, almost like she wanted to signal something, but dropped it limply to her side and then onto Mike's arm. She ran her smooth palm along his bicep, up to his neck. Joey had his pants on now. "You want me to lock the door, lovebirds?" he said. "Because you're gonna have a crowd in here if I leave it open."

Joey was laughing, enjoying himself, not really asking a question as he tossed his shirt around in his arms like a pizza to get it on the right way. He tugged it down and snatched a beer from a table, before saying "whoo-eee," and opening the door.

"Nothing to see here folks!" he yelled, and Mike turned to glare at him, but Joey was already locking the door and pulling it behind him with a devilish grin on his face.

Mike turned back to Shiloh, who was looking at him as if she had asked him a question. Had she?

But he was overcome by the desire to kiss her, and so he did, drinking in the sweet taste of her lips, her mouth responsive beneath his, the taste of other men sneaking in the recesses of her mouth, surfacing to remind him in bitter, salty patches, of everything that had just happened.

"I knew you were here," Shiloh said after Joey left, a note of guilt in her voice. Her eyes were close to his, enough that her lashes sometimes grazed his, or his cheek. She kissed him, a hand under his jaw. "Joey said you wanted this." She bit gently into his lower lip, a foreign act, reminiscent of the way she had chewed on Joey's lip. "You did, didn't you?"

There was a fragile wobble in her voice, a yearning for approval that went right through Mike's gut. He cupped her cheek and kissed her. "Shiloh... yes, God..." he kissed her again. "It was hot. So hot. Just..." he rolled onto his back and put a hand to his temple. "Just... fucking unexpected, I guess. God."

Shiloh was still lying on her side, looking at him. It was the kind of look he hadn't seen for a long time: expectant, attentive. She curled a hand under her chin and pressed her lips together thoughtfully. Still doubtful.

"I loved it, Shiloh," Mike repeated, touching her hair. "I'm just... give an old man a minute to recover." He looked up at the ceiling. "What... how did you? What happened?"

Shiloh rolled onto her stomach, grinning. "Joey had to tell me about your plan," she said, grinning, her voice an excited whisper. "I wanted to go home." She looked at Mike, who looked back uncomprehendingly - more than anything because his thoughts were still caught in the whirlwind of slutty images that would not leave his mind. As if he couldn't filter them into a memory, because he still didn't believe they were real.

"At the bar," Shiloh continued, a note of playful exasperation in her voice. She played with his hair with her right hand, her fingers delicate and intoxicating. Cold needles of pleasure sank through his neck muscles and into his shoulders, sending a shudder through him. "I wanted to go home. So Joey spilled the beans about your plan." She smiled. "Very clever," she

added, with a sly grin, before kissing him. "But maybe Joey's plan was clever-er?"

Mike rolled over, on top of Shiloh, and pushed her into the bed, smiling as he kissed her. "Mmm. Joey, clever-er? What else is Joey better at?"

Shiloh played along for a moment, smiling mysteriously, but her smile faded a little as something darkened her eyes. "Seriously, though, baby," she said. "This was all just because you said... I mean, Joey said... well, you both said... Joey isn't, like... all *that*."

Mike's cock was starting to come back to life. "No?" he asked, making his way down Shiloh's body with wet kisses. Her skin was salty, damp, sexual. He played with her left nipple, liking that she squirmed beneath his body. He looked up at her. "You seemed to have a pretty good time."

Shiloh was squirming, purring like a cat, but she stopped suddenly and lifted her head. "It was only hot because I knew you were here," she told him, her voice serious and genuine.

Mike looked up at her, making his way down her body. On her stomach, slippery traces of cum - who knew whose - made their bodies glide over each other in swift spurts and then catch on rubbery, clean patches. The scent of her pussy was strong, overpowering, tempting. But he wasn't ready to go that far.

He made his way back up to her face, rolling his hips to slip his cock inside of her again. It pulsed to full firmness once he slid into her overripe, sloshy canal. Her pussy felt distended and stretched, loose now that the pressure of Joey's cock wasn't thrusting up from beneath.

Shiloh mewled when he entered her.

"Is your pussy sore?" he asked her, and she just nodded listlessly, her eyes on his, searching for a certain kind of approval and forgiveness that he saw now was the exact thing he had wanted, from all of this.

He fucked her gently, and they rolled on the sodden bed, exploring their bodies, his cock sloshing in a sea of cum that other men had stroked out of his wife. "I love you, Shiloh," he said, when she squealed and clutched his body to hers with her legs, an exhausted final orgasm squeezing from deep inside of her.

Shiloh's fingers pulled tight on his hair as he fucked his cum into her again. "I love you, baby."

EPILOGUE

Shiloh was lying on her stomach, facing the computer screen, wearing nothing more than a shiny, semi-transparent white camisole. Mike had an excellent view of her pert breasts, plumped into large, fluffy pillows by her arms, and caught the occasional glimpse of a pebbled mocha nipple as she moved around. She seemed to have almost staged herself, lining up the smooth curve of her ass behind her so that Mike could see it in its barely-covered glory, distant and slightly out-of-focus, her bare feet swinging casually through the background as they spoke.

"So... you're on? For next week?" she asked excitedly. Mike stared at her lips, enjoying the twitches of mischief that trembled at the corners of her mouth, the glint on her eyes. Shiloh's feet swooped through the background again, like the tail of a cat getting ready to pounce. "I'll make sure to plan something special."

Mike smiled, distracted to the point of helplessness. What were they talking about?

Shiloh was still smiling back at him, expectantly. She waited for a moment, then bugged her eyes a little and jutted her chin toward the screen to prompt him. "Honey?"

Mike blinked, and in the time that he did, a figure moved in the far background, and Mike recognized the flesh-colored tones of a shirtless Joey. His chiseled chest loomed in the background for a moment, and Mike's dick, already hard, pulsed with forceful longing enough to make him wince - inwardly, of course.

"Yeah," he said. "I mean, yes. I'm on. For next week. Returning... next... week..."

Shiloh was grinning. He could see in her eyes that she had recognized his expression, that she knew Joey had come into the picture behind her. Joey was moving slowly forward, the contours of his body taking sharper form as he moved closer to Shiloh.

A thrust of pain and a spike of pleasure ran through Mike's body. They were in the master bedroom: this was his bed, his wife, in the background, his walls and the entrance to his bathroom suite, a light left on deep in the recessed room casting a familiar weak yellow on the walls above the sinks. He could almost see Shiloh in 3D from Joey's perspective:

long, lean legs stretched out behind her, ass mostly bare - maybe she had a sexy thong on, perhaps she had nothing at all. He couldn't see Joey's face, because it hovered above the line of the camera's sight. But he could easily picture the look on Joey's face.

He shuddered.

"That's great, baby," Shiloh said breathlessly, but there was no telling if her breathlessness was produced by the prospect of Mike coming home, or by the sensation of Joey's hand on her foot as the latter reached for one of her swinging appendages and caught it in his hand, a thumb stroking a firm line down the sole of her foot.

The whole view jiggled violently, and a blur of flesh and white camisole moved jaggedly across the screen before Shiloh's face came back into focus. Joey was climbing onto the bed, lowering his body on top of hers. Mike got a brief look at his face, mouth slightly open, eyes devouring Shiloh's bare skin.

Shiloh smiled at him. "I guess it's time to go, baby."

"Yeah, Mikey we got places to be," Joey chimed in. "And you have a meeting, bro. Remember?"

This was true, and it was why he was going to miss whatever happened next.

Shiloh was looking into the camera with her new, sensual smile. Her eyes were dilated with excitement. A tattooed arm crossed in front of the lens, and Shiloh's hand pushed it up, above her head, as she ducked, giggling, to look into the camera. "I love you, baby," she breathed.

"I love you, Shy," Mike said, as Joey called out cheerfully, "Yeah, love you too, man."

A sultry giggle.

Darkness falling over his view like a curtain as someone - likely Joey - closed Shiloh's laptop and silence cut out the glittery rain of Shiloh's giggles, sprinkled through a sentence she may or may not have said:

"I'll tell you all about every-"

END

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